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June 19, 2026

[You're reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we're watching, listening to, and doing this week. **Sign up to receive it in your inbox.**](#)

The choreographer Lucinda Childs is having a moment. On June 26, the day she turns eighty-six, she's opening a weekend run of “Momentary Reprise,” a program featuring new work, at **Bard SummerScape** (running at the Fisher Center, in Annandale-on-Hudson, N.Y., through June 28). She's also performing in it. This comes amid a flurry of activity rare for an octogenarian. A few months ago, Childs had a retrospective show at the Guggenheim Museum; more remarkable is a five-year contract she recently signed to step in as resident choreographer of Gibney Dance, a repertory company of young movers. An hour-long première for the troupe is in the works.



Lucinda Child's “Distant Figure” Photograph by Alexandra Polina

At Bard, Childs is performing “Geranium ’64,” an adaptation of one of the early, object-focussed pieces she made in the nineteen-sixties, as a member of Judson Dance Theatre; she grips a stretchy cord and leans into a state of suspension. The rest of the bill is in the mode of balletic pattern tracing that she developed in the seventies, in part through collaborations with the avant-garde theatre director Robert Wilson and the composer Philip Glass. In tribute to Wilson, who died last year, the Bard program includes a dance from “Einstein on the Beach,” his landmark 1976 opera with Glass. An upstate première, “Distant Figure,” is set to music by Glass, too: a passacaglia of the same name written for Childs and for the Russian pianist Anton Batagov, who will play it. Another tribute, to the architect Frank Gehry, who also died last year, comes in the form of an excerpt from “Available Light,” Childs’s 1983 project with Gehry and the composer John Adams. Childs’s art may not be as imperishable as the swooping steel of Bard’s Gehry-designed Fisher Center, but it should last. Chances to see Childs perform won’t.—*Brian Seibert*



About Town

Post-Rock

Last year, the Chicago instrumental post-rock band **Tortoise** returned with “Touch,” its first album in nearly a decade, the further explorations of an inquisitive nature. “Post-rock” remains an ambiguous term, and yet Tortoise somehow embodies all of its wide-reaching implications, from progressive rock, jazz, and dub to Krautrock and electronica, the group’s compositions fluid but governed by grooves, which give the music structure amid complexity. Tortoise explored a fusionist wonderland in the nineties, with its opus, “TNT,” from 1998, collapsing the distance between ambient and funk. “Touch” is just as dynamic, a swirl of glitched-out electronics and sweeping guitars. The band is joined by the psychedelic singer-songwriter L’Rain, who shares its experimental sensibility.—*Sheldon Pearce*
(*Knockdown Center*; June 25.)

Dance

Tucked into the bucolic Berkshires, **Jacob's Pillow Dance Festival** is a dance oasis. The headliner of the first week is the Paul Taylor Dance Company, with three crowd-pleasers—the joyful “Esplanade,” the regal “Brandenburgs,” and the Second World War-era piece “Company B”—at the Ted Shawn Theatre. In the smaller Doris Duke, the choreographer and dancer Shamel Pitts takes on his intimate and exhausting duet “Touch of RED” with Channce Williams, a member of his ensemble, TRIBE. And a contemporary-dance group from Copenhagen, Uppercut Dance Theatre, has its American début, on the spectacular outdoor Henry J. Leir Stage.—*Marina Harss (Becket, Mass.; June 24-28.)*

Art



Jean-Claude Sauer's "Homage to Pop Art," from 1966. Photograph by Jean-Claude Sauer

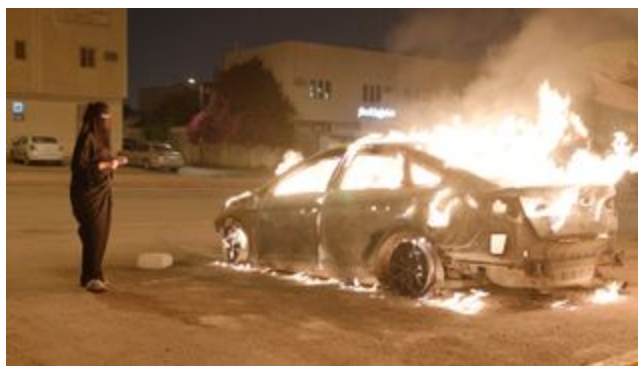
It's no surprise that **"Yves Saint Laurent and Photography"** is a sensational show of fashion images. In the years after becoming the quietly charismatic young star of nineteen-fifties Christian Dior (see Irving Penn's penetrating 1957 portrait), Saint Laurent didn't just work with every important fashion photographer—he inspired some of their most indelible and audacious pictures. The Dior gown that Dovima wore while posing between elephants for Richard Avedon was a Saint Laurent design. So was the men's-tailored "Le Smoking" pants suit that Helmut Newton shot in the gloom and glare of a Parisian back street—now an icon of androgynous chic. Even before 1971, when Jeanloup Sieff photographed Saint Laurent naked on a stack of cushions, the role of the modern fashion designer had

been redefined in his image.—*Vince Aletti (International Center of Photography; through Sept. 28.)*

Off Broadway

A gently oddball semi-solo musical about a maybe-romance on an Easter Sunday, Todd Almond’s **“I’m Almost There”** is, at its palpitating heart, about longing for love in a city of strangers. The show opens with Almond—the star of the musical “Girl from the North Country”—at his piano, confidently launching into a shaggy-dog anecdote, told in song, about a promising flirtation. But, right away, he gets derailed by tangents, as he struggles even to get down the stairs of his apartment. Time warps, in witty, surreal ways; we meet his neighbors: Noah Max Amick as Sexy Beast, on bass; Erin Hill as a curmudgeonly cat lady, on harp. Funny, lost, and a little wistful, Almond is an unreliable narrator whose dream logic we trust unconditionally—and when he morphs into a mouse in a glue trap, you’ll pray for the lurking feline (who claims to be fifty-three per cent his mother) to spare him.—*Emily Nussbaum (BAM Fisher; through June 28.)*

Movies



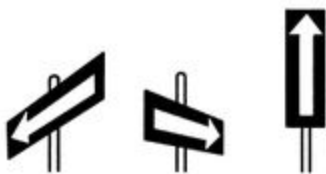
Mila Al Zahrani in “Unidentified.” Photograph courtesy Sony Pictures Classics

The police-drama template gets a vigorous update in the Saudi director Haifaa Al Mansour’s twisty mystery **“Unidentified.”** A teen-age girl’s body is found in a desert near Riyadh; the police need a woman to view the corpse, and the only one at the station is Nawal (Mila Al Zahrani), a young administrative assistant and a solitary divorcée who’s hooked on a true-crime series. When officials fail to identify the victim, Nawal hunts for the killer. Her quest reveals a wide array of misogynistic injustices, ranging

from oppressive supervision, arranged marriages, and polygamy to honor killings. Though the engaging story is sometimes filmed dismayingly plainly, its main action sequence—a pursuit on foot through a vast warren of abandoned buildings—is both thrilling and wondrous.—*Richard Brody (In limited release.)*

Off Broadway

A sense of life cooling its heels pervades Martyna Majok and Aimee Mann’s musical adaptation of the memoir **“Girl, Interrupted,”** by Susanna Kaysen, about Kaysen’s eighteen-month stay at the psychiatric hospital McLean, in the nineteen-sixties. Susanna (Juliana Canfield), looking back on her life, delivers lines about her younger self with her transfixing John Singer Sargent gaze and an icy repose, or reënacts painful episodes, trading Plath references with another patient like samizdat. But the book’s ruminative watchfulness is unsuccessfully conjugated in this overly sedate play with music, which has the feel of a song cycle, though sung by the fine cast with gorgeous, lonely sorrow. The production veers away from a documentary, “Titicut Follies”-like approach while also managing to dodge any great cloudbursts of feeling.—*Rhoda Feng (Public Theatre; through July 12.)*



Pick Three

Jennifer Wilson on Italian-lesson inspiration.



Illustration by Antonio Giovanni Pinna

1. Learning Russian humbled me, or perhaps “humiliated” is the word. In Moscow, I apologized to a professor for being late. “I was sleeping with someone,” I explained. (I meant to say “overslept” but attached the wrong prefix.) I asked a babushka where I could find the nearest “semi-automatic.” Miraculously, she understood that I meant “A.T.M.” But, with Russia largely closed off, I’m rekindling a former flame: Italian. I bought an old textbook on eBay called **“Prego!”** which I swear I didn’t choose just because it has a cup of gelato on the cover. Speaking of food, my new favorite phrase is *cavoli riscaldati*, or “reheated cabbage.” It refers to the futility of trying to revive an old love affair. That’s never stopped me before!

2. I was lured back to Italian by **“La Chimera,”** Alice Rohrwacher’s life-affirming film about the dead. It stars Josh O’Connor—who learned Italian for the role—as an archeologist turned leader of a band of *tombaroli*, grave robbers who raid Etruscan tombs to fence long-buried artifacts. He, like the objects, is stuck between here and the hereafter, and is mourning a lost love just as a new one introduces herself. Which brings me to wonder—*come si dice* “I can fix him”?

3. In Jhumpa Lahiri’s **“Roman Stories”** (written in Italian and translated into English by Lahiri and Todd Portnowitz), an American tourist is trying

to read the signs at a bus stop when an Italian man steps in to help—though he takes her off course, that day and forever. They marry. Seduction, she later thinks, is “*che ci fa smarrire*,” or “what makes us lose our way.” I haven’t found a better translation.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [“His Bed” by Alex Poppe](#)
- [The tea at A.A.](#)
- [Imagine all the ones we haven’t discovered](#)

[Brian Seibert](#) has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 2002. He is the author of “[What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing](#),” which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the *New York Times* and the *New York Review of Books*. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.

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[Vince Aletti](#) is a photography critic and the author of “[Issues: A History of Photography in Fashion Magazines](#).”

[Emily Nussbaum](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2011, is the magazine’s theatre critic. Her books include “[Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV](#).”

[Richard Brody](#), a film critic, began writing for *The New Yorker* in 1999. He is the author of “[Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard](#).”

[Rhoda Feng](#), who received the 2025 Nona Balakian Citation for Excellence in Reviewing, has also written about theatre and books for *Artforum*, the *Boston Globe*, and the *Times Literary Supplement*, among other publications.

[Jennifer Wilson](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker* covering books and culture. In 2024, she received a Robert B. Silvers Prize for Literary Criticism.

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[The Food Scene](#)

What Marcel Is Selling

At the new restaurant in the Sotheby's-owned Breuer building, money, in its most indiscreet sense, is everywhere.

By [Helen Rosner](#)

June 14, 2026



At Marcel, nearly everything in the dining room is available for purchase, including the plates on which the food is served. Photographs by Morgan Levy for The New Yorker

[You're reading the Food Scene newsletter, *Helen Rosner's guide to what, where, and how to eat.* Sign up to receive it in your inbox.](#)

To descend the stairs into Marcel, the new French-continental restaurant on the lower level of the Breuer building, on Madison Avenue, is to watch a brutalist masterpiece surrender, with a kind of gracious compliance, to the softening influence of a great deal of money. The building, which now serves as Sotheby's global headquarters, was partially landmarked last year, so Marcel Breuer's original concrete columns and his grid of circular light fixtures remain. But the dining room has been upholstered, metaphorically and, at times, literally, into submission. The mohair-wrapped banquettes are the minky greige of cocoa powder and have the downy hand of a Max Mara wrap coat. The walls that aren't subject to preservation are sheathed in vast Claro walnut panels of a sinuous, almost figurative grain. A mirrored bar

that anchors one end of the space is lined with Bauhaus-era leather stools, and Breuer-designed lighting sourced, naturally, at auction.

Breuer's blocky, cantilevered structure—"harshly handsome," as the *Times* critic Ada Louise Huxtable put it, on occasion of its 1966 opening—was originally built to house the Whitney Museum of American Art. After the Whitney decamped downtown, in 2015, the space passed to the Met and then to the Frick, before Sotheby's purchased it in 2023, for a reported hundred million dollars. The restaurant is a partnership between Sotheby's and the designer-restaurateurs Robin and Stephen Alesch, better known as Roman & Williams, who are responsible for the look of many famously beautiful restaurants ([Le Coucou](#), the Boom Boom Room) and have a growing portfolio of their own spots, including La Mercerie, in SoHo. Here, as there, they have executed a full-spectrum takeover—of the food, the branding, the objects on the walls and in the display cases, even the custom three-hundred-dollar coupes in which the Martinis arrive, each one hand-blown by a celebrated Japanese glass artist.

There is a distinction worth drawing between luxury and beauty, or more precisely between opulence and grace. Marcel is a useful case study. Everything about the place signals a level of unrestricted aesthetic devotion at which money seems almost an abstract annoyance. There's a [Helen Frankenthaler](#) on the wall, and a Robert Indiana tucked coyly under the stairs. And yet money, in its most indiscreet sense, is everywhere: each piece of flatware and plateware is available for purchase, as your server may mention, and bronze-framed vitrines that serve as subtle room dividers display treasures from Sotheby's—a clawlike Chaumet necklace, a pocket-size John Chamberlain "tidbit" sculpture—with placards noting, pointedly, "price available on request." In the dining room's previous lives—say, as Flora Bar, in the Met days—lunch might be followed by a wander upstairs to see a collection of Munch or Celmins paintings, and diners at Marcel can similarly tour certain Sotheby's floors that are open to the public. Still, there is a fundamental difference between a show and a showroom: one is culture, the other is retail. Restaurants, at their best, are adept at fusing the two, which I suspect is why Marcel feels compelling and coherent even when its corporate landlord fails to muffle the *ka-ching* of the cash registers.

The room draws a certain type: celebrities of the later-in-career variety, people just living their wealthy lives rather than performing them, many very beautiful women sporting a lot of truly excellent cosmetic work. During one of my meals there, on a trip to the rest room (which requires passing an Yves Klein “Venus”: striking, sublime, and available, of course, for purchase) I found myself party to an impassioned debate about The Formula x Meredith, a currently à-la-mode boutique fitness studio in the Hamptons, and whether the best move is to pay for a whole year up front or go month to month. Plenty of restaurants in New York are preposterously expensive, and Marcel is, too—a cocktail alone can run more than forty bucks—but the restaurant pulls off the much rarer trick of feeling actually rich. The tell, if you need a tell, is a section of the menu that invites the diner to build her own main course, with a fillet of fish or a cut of steak cooked and sauced to her specifications—a built-in concession to diners guided by cardiologists or dieticians, including the auction-house denizens upstairs, for whom Marcel might function as the office cafeteria. (The last time I remember seeing this choose-your-own-adventure option was at [Four Twenty Five](#), the Park Avenue power canteen that is, notably, the only somewhat recent opening that matches Marcel for reliable oligarch spotting.)

The menu, from the French chef Marie-Aude Rose, who also runs La Mercerie, is old-fashioned in the au-courant way. A preprandial demi-baguette is laid directly on the tablecloth—no board, no basket, no plate; nothing is chicer, or more exquisite, than exquisite nonchalance. (A puck of butter is complimentary, though you can level up to a smear of Bordier, which, made in Brittany, is reputed to be the best butter in the world, for an extra five dollars, and further loaves of bread will cost you twelve.) Rose plays her Frenchiness to the hilt, with respectable renditions of bistro staples like roast chicken, frogs’ legs, escargot, and a ladylike composition of chilled shrimp and grapefruit supremes. But her kitchen is better when it’s being a little weird. A starter of *oeuf mayonnaise* features the eggs sliced Hasselback-style, their scored openings piped with salty aioli and pink waves of watermelon radish as ruffly and surreal as a pair of nudibranchs. A dish of chilled beef terrine in aspic is more striking still, with cross-sections of carrot and leek arranged in cool geological strata around a layer of cold beef slightly fuzzy with chilled fat. The gelée around it, made with muscat-

grape juice and beef consommé, is tart and savory, and a horseradish cream is neatly sharp, if not quite bracing. A scallop crudo is made appealingly strange with smoked crème fraîche and chunky slivers of pickled citrus zest that carry an herbaceous, almost resinous bite.

Still, most of what I tried at Marcel was fairly unremarkable, and a few dishes were downright bleak. Poireaux et Poires Poivrés is a delight to say (God, I love ingredient wordplay), but rather less of one to eat—a loose stack of braised leeks with soft poached pears in a murky, muddy-brown truffle vinaigrette. A boilerplate steak tartare is served with gaufrette chips that are curiously not quite crisp. A main course of *poulet au paprika*, a nod to Marcel Breuer’s Hungarian origins, is simply a head-scratcher: a deboned leg atop a thin, bitter paprika sauce, with a dollop of sauerkraut and a strewing of raw bell pepper. With its joyless austerity, the dish bears almost no resemblance to actual chicken *paprikás*, which is boisterous and dense and, crucially, should involve a considerable portion of hearty starches to sop it all up. (A majority of the restaurant’s main courses, notably, eschew carbs.)



Desserts are the standout. The madeleines are baked to order in actual scallop shells, and served with a side of jam.

Then there is the Lobster Giverny, a Chef Rose invention that's unique to Marcel, featuring a roasted lobster tail in a stupendous ginger-scented cream sauce built on a base of intense lobster stock, with bits of roast pineapple and tart leaves of nasturtium. What this has to do with Giverny, where Monet lived and painted, I haven't got a clue, but it was the savory menu's most assured presentation, as pretty as a painting. The cocktails are wonderful, but their vessels are even better: a Kir Royale in a graceful flute with a flared bubble at the bottom, a smoky Rosita in a multi-hued cut-glass tumbler. I've been ordering Cosmos everywhere lately—they're having a moment, and I'm embarrassingly nostalgic—and I nearly fell off my mohaired banquette when Marcel's version arrived in glassware straight out of a nineties Michael Gravesian fever dream, its bowl tulip-lipped, its stem nearly a foot high.

Helen, Help Me!

[E-mail your questions](#) about dining, eating, and anything food-related, and Helen may respond in a future newsletter.

The real star of a meal at Marcel is dessert, the domain of the pastry chef Rae Gaylord. Her madeleines are baked to order in actual scallop shells, and they arrive still steaming, soft of crumb and barely sweet, with a small pot of tea-scented jam. A dish of pedigreed, ruby-like strawberries comes with a long-legged coupe of Chantilly cream. But this is not a restaurant built for restraint; turn your attentions to Les Grands, a selection of jumbo desserts, each big enough to feed a quorum. There's an entire salad bowl of chocolate mousse, perfectly bitter and rich, and a Paris-Brest the circumference of a tricycle wheel, with enormous puffs of hazelnut mousse and a dripping seam of blackberry jam. I nearly ordered the mille-feuille, which comes in cinderblock-sized hunks, until a neighboring table caught my companion and me eyeing theirs and pantomimed an emphatic no. Plenty of drama, but apparently less payoff. On my way out, I paused to admire a sixty-seven-million-year-old T. rex tooth that rests in a glass case by the door: it's yours to purchase at auction, for an estimated forty to sixty thousand dollars, in Sotheby's upcoming Natural History sale. There's something refreshing, in a resigned sort of way, about finding yourself in a restaurant that knows the value of everything—and the price, too. ♦

[Helen Rosner](#), a staff writer at The New Yorker, has received multiple James Beard Awards, including one in 2025 for her [Profile of the food personality Padma Lakshmi](#).

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The Talk of the Town

- **[The Difference Between the Knicks and the White House Cage Fight](#)**

By Adam Gopnik | Sports, spectacle, and what Juvenal would have made of this moment.

- **[Pencils Up! The Knicks on Broadway](#)**

By Dan Greene | The N.B.A. championship was a win for Mayor Mamdani, but the city's public-school kids, stuck taking their Regents exams as the ticker-tape parade thundered past their windows, weren't so sure.

- **[Alexandra Grant Brings Spirit Back](#)**

By Sarah Larson | Walking through her new exhibition, "Antigone 3000," the artist known to online hordes as Keanu Reeves's mysterious silver-haired girlfriend reflects on Sophocles and the color pink.

- **[Dan Mintz, Reanimated](#)**

By Emma Allen | The comedian and voice artist puts his "Bob's Burgers" expertise to the test with a cartoon standup special—produced by the man who officiated his wedding, John Mulaney.

- **[Isabel J. Kim Makes Her Own World](#)**

By Luis A. Gómez | At a board-game café on the Upper West Side, the lawyer and author discusses her new book, "Sublimation," about borders, parallel selves, and an eerily Trump-like government.

[Comment](#)

The Difference Between the Knicks and the White House Cage Fight

Sports, spectacle, and what Juvenal would have made of this moment.

By [Adam Gopnik](#)

June 21, 2026



Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

There are moments when a phrase, or a current of thought, that had seemed condemned to archival history is suddenly all anyone talks about. So it is right now with the chewy subject of breads, circuses, and cities. New York is alight with the joy of the Knickerbockers' doggedly pursued N.B.A. championship title with, in this summer of celebrating our gloriously hybrid Americanness, the pleasing anomaly that a team of mostly Black and brown Americans bears the name of the town's oldest, once most élite, and now obscure Dutch element. But the subject of bread and circuses arises out of the ancient observation—from the grouchy poet and satirist Juvenal, who witnessed it in first-century Rome—that, if people are supplied with food

and entertainment by their oligarchs, they won't care or even notice if the government they live under is changing from some sort of a democracy to a dictatorship right before their eyes.

The Knicks won a week ago Saturday, and New York affirmed that victory on Thursday, with a parade and a ceremony at which Mayor Zohran Mamdani presented the team with newly redesigned keys to the city, though what, exactly, the keys unlock these days is unclear. In between those civic thrills, an openly gladiatorial spectacle was staged on the White House South Lawn: a U.F.C. cage-fighting event overseen by Dana White, the combat-sports impresario and longtime friend of President Donald Trump. Meanwhile, athletes and supporters from many nations passed through our now suspicious borders to fight for the World Cup of what the rest of the world calls football. Inevitably, the question arises of whether we are each, in our way, being distracted from our own crisis by our own oligarchs, and by the circuses that they encourage. Indeed, some of our oligarchs actually own the circuses. It was James Dolan who invited his pal Trump to visit the Garden for the Knicks' Game Three, and it is Dolan, not New York, who owns the team, just as it was *FIFA's* president, Gianni Infantino, who showered praise and a faked-up peace prize on Trump ahead of the World Cup.

Violence, of course, hovers at the edges of even our favorite games, and we are not always aware of the risks that our heroes take on behalf of our entertainment. It has been pointed out that the N.B.A. final series was rougher—what is euphemistically called “more physical”—than the game used to be. A few years ago, there was a flurry of concern about the rise of concussions in the N.F.L., but that has largely subsided, as the league continues to bring in record-breaking revenues—more than twenty-five billion dollars are projected for next year. This month, as the Carolina Hurricanes won the Stanley Cup Finals, we saw sadly that the N.H.L. has become more physical, too—with a cruder version of the game, which some Canadians think was intended to be more easily accepted by the never-seen-a-winter Sunbelt cities that the league wants to thrive in. More sadly, the former player Claude Lemieux, a paladin of both the Montreal Canadiens and the New Jersey Devils, died by suicide just weeks ago, shortly after receiving the highest honor in Montreal hockey: carrying the team torch

onto the ice before the opening face-off. His family, significantly, has donated his brain to Boston University for study.

Some historian will doubtless make a case that Trump's cage fight was a Jacksonian gesture, pleasing to the people, and that only the snobbery of an élite would disdain it. But one had merely to watch the fight, and to see the fighters paraded out of the White House to the arena, to know that on the South Lawn we have moved beyond populism and entered Caligula country, where the emperor delights in vulgar cruelty for its own sake. There is a real distinction between a city unified by five fine starting players in a game that originally involved throwing a ball into a peach basket and that, however improbably, became the city game, and the bloody display in the nation's capital. One is about civic commonality, the other about authoritarian cynicism; one is about a city pulling together around a common pleasure, the other about desecrating the decorum of democracy.

Given how easily sports can be turned sour, why do they continue to move us and unify us? One looks to the story of the Haitian World Cup team, appearing in the tournament for the first time in fifty years, which has gathered expatriate players from the Haitian diaspora to play for that beautiful and utterly despoiled country, where many of them have never lived. Coming from elsewhere, they managed to make a Haitian essence in the absence of a functional Haiti to play for. "For a few hours, geography will matter less than identity," one writer noted. Surely it is, rather, that for a few hours the players will reveal that identity depends less on geography than on self-perception, less on where you were born or even raised and more on how you choose to feel.

Identity politics, so-called, are often condemned for making what you are more important than what you do, but the other side of them is that they make what you want to be as important as what you're supposed to be, allowing people to choose the identity they desire even in the face of the identity they were told they ought to have. In the country's two-hundred-and-fiftieth year, OG Anunoby, a British-born Knicks forward, tips in a shot, with 1.2 seconds remaining, to win Game Four. Jalen Brunson, of New Brunswick, New Jersey, is now as much a necessary New Yorker as Joe DiMaggio, who was of North Beach, in San Francisco, before and after

his Bronx sojourn. For that matter, a very, very tall Frenchman is now an essential Texan.

Pastimes and people are oddly matched. Some pastimes are distractions, some are distortions, and some few are true distillations—refining a city or a place or a community to its essence, deliciously sipped by all. In reminding us about the artifactual nature of teams, sports remind us that all identities are largely fictive—things we choose to embrace because we like them, and they like us. We pick a team and make it ours. Juvenal’s satire about the narcotizing effect of all that bread, all those circuses, also contains his equally classic counsel: to pray for both a healthy body and a healthy mind and for a spirit that counts long life among nature’s smaller gifts, making the brutal domination of others less important than the serenity of the self. Whether we’re watching or playing, it’s still sound advice. ♦

*[Adam Gopnik](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 1986. His books include “[The Real Work: On the Mystery of Mastery](#).”*

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Pencils Up! The Knicks on Broadway

The N.B.A. championship was a win for Mayor Mamdani, but the city's public-school kids, stuck taking their Regents exams as the ticker-tape parade thundered past their windows, weren't so sure.

By [Dan Greene](#)

June 20, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

In the spirit of New York's Regents exams, the standardized tests that public-school students have been taking in recent weeks, a multiple-choice

question:

This month, New York City witnessed which feat worthy of civic celebration?

(A) The gobsmacking series of comebacks by Jalen Brunson, OG Anunoby, et al. that secured the Knicks' first N.B.A. championship in fifty-three years.

(B) The city sanitation workers' cleanup of beer bottles, puke puddles, tons of shredded paper, gnawed blue-and-orange bagels, and other detritus from Thursday's ticker-tape parade up Broadway.

(C) The wrangling by personnel at the high schools along said parade's thronged route in order to administer said Regents exams.

The answer, of course, is all of the above. But the need for C was a matter of dispute. When Mayor Zohran Mamdani announced, shortly after the Knicks' victory, that the city would honor them with a gala parade the following Thursday morning, he quickly drew backlash: there were Regents exams scheduled to begin at 9:15 A.M. Students launched petitions for Mamdani to cancel the tests; the Queens borough president called on the schools chancellor to step in. The Mayor's hands were tied: this was state business. "Unlike the executive order for bedtimes, this is something I cannot repeal," he lamented. The Mayor risked getting demerits not only from Knicks-crazed teachers but also from his next generation of constituents—at least the ones studying Biology and Living Environment, which were the test subjects on parade day.

The *FOMO* of students and proctors was not the only problem. Parade attendance was expected to be in the millions. Ten thousand cops were deployed to the financial district; access for parade-goers was limited to twenty-three checkpoints. Attendees were advised to arrive two hours early, and the test-takers had no fast-track lane to themselves.

"This is gonna be a *day*," one school worker said to a colleague just before 8 A.M. outside the Richard R. Green High School of Teaching, at Beaver Street and Broadway. Administrators worked with the focussed urgency of a

rescue team: clipboards, checklists, phone calls, negotiations with barricade-minding cops. A school staffer hustled a boy in a Jalen Brunson shirt past an officer, insisting that he had a test. A bro in a white ball cap pulled a vape from his lips to call out, “Good luck! You got this!”

Other tête-à-têtes with police were rockier. Revellers in Knicks capes pleaded their cases fruitlessly. Miffed office workers dangled lanyards; a cop asked those without work I.D.s to show their pay stubs. So jammed were the designated viewing areas that crowds packed blocks beyond the checkpoints. Train platforms had been thronged as far east as Ronkonkoma as early as 4 A.M. During the scrum, the financial district was swarming with Knicks jerseys, honoring not only the current champs but also the beloved players who had soldiered through leaner seasons: Marbury, Ntilikina, Lin. A man in an R. J. Barrett number boasted that his was contraband. “It doesn’t get any more Knicks than wearing a bootleg,” he said. He hoped to see a Duhon or a Van Horn. Everywhere, dudes remembered guys.

In that way, Thursday was not so different from most days in the city. Life carried on, or tried to. Dentists with offices along the route rescheduled cleanings. A lot of shops didn’t bother trying to open. Some storekeepers’ plans were foiled. “Yep, just like regular,” a cashier at a Century 21 on Cortlandt Street had said the day before, of the Thursday hours. The store had just kicked off a designer clearance sale. By parade time, all the entrances were shuttered with metal gates; they didn’t open until 2 P.M. A clerk at A Little Shop in NYC, in the Oculus, spent the morning giving directions to confused Jerseyites looking to get to the parade from the *PATH* train. “All the way up,” she told them.

Some businesses explored new revenue streams. “From now on, five dollars a pee-pee,” a burly guard at an office building where passersby had sought relief said. “The other thing, twenty.” Max Funland, a new second-floor arcade on Broadway, opened five hours early for two small groups that had paid to reserve seats alongside its parade-facing windows. Michael Mimoun, a thirty-nine-year-old from Brooklyn who works in property management, coughed up five hundred dollars to watch there with a group

of family and friends, including two five-year-olds. He'd first tried renting out a vacant office nearby: "A guy quoted me, like, fifteen grand."

Watching from his neon-lit perch "was really weird," Mimoun said. "But it was incredible seeing our heroes go by." Shortly before the parade, his group had headed to a higher floor, where the arcade stores its claw machines' supply of stuffed toys. "There was something poetic about it," Talia Rosenthal, Mimoun's cousin, said. "Fifty-three years of no prizes for the Knicks, and we're surrounded by bags of them." ♦

[Dan Greene](#) is a member of *The New Yorker's* editorial staff.

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[Anakainōsis Dept.](#)

Alexandra Grant Brings Spirit Back

Walking through her new exhibition, “Antigone 3000,” the artist known to online hordes as Keanu Reeves’s mysterious silver-haired girlfriend reflects on Sophocles and the color pink.

By [Sarah Larson](#)

June 22, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

The artist Alexandra Grant flew into Newark on a recent stormy Thursday, checked into a hotel, and zipped over to the Albertz Benda gallery, in Chelsea, just before the opening party for “Antigone 3000 (Anakainōsis),” her new show of paintings. “I woke up in Warsaw this morning,” she said; her upcoming work involves German and Polish writers. Grant, who is fifty-three and tall, lives in Germany, where she has a studio, and in Los Angeles, where she has another studio and an arts-supporting business, along with a publishing company she runs with her partner, Keanu Reeves. (In 2011, as part of an earlier publishing venture, the pair released the whimsically lugubrious “Ode to Happiness,” in which Grant illustrated original Reeves lines like “I draw a hot sorrow bath in my despair room / with a misery candle burning.”) Despite the travel mayhem, Grant appeared to be elegantly at ease: graceful swoop of gray hair; silver booties from Grandezza, a big-shoes boutique in Berlin; draped silk suit in an extraordinary blue hue. What color, exactly? “I would say . . . mermaid teal,” Grant said, looking pleased.

Grant worked on the “Antigone” paintings, the gallerist Thorsten Albertz said, “last fall, right across the street, while Keanu was here, on Broadway, playing in ‘Waiting for Godot.’ ” In the gallery, rich, bright colors burst off the canvases, at once joyful and unsettling. Before gallerygoers arrived, Grant walked through the exhibit. She paused in front of the boldly pink “Volcania.” “I don’t know what this says about the fall, but I was really into the orange-pink-blue-purple combo,” she said. “And then this”—she pointed to “Modest Vestment,” nearby—“is green, verdant, coastal. You have the feeling of the spill, the emergency, the accident. I have a pink obsession—I’m a de Kooning person. He always got the perfect amount of pink in every piece.” Each painting “is like a firework, a celebration,” she said. “There’s so much violence, but in the sense of, like, a volcano erupting—the possibility that comes from crisis.”

The “Antigone” series originated in 2014. “Like many artists, many people, I was thinking about ‘Antigone’ in relation to Michael Brown’s death,” Grant said. “I fell in love with the idea of this teen-age girl standing up and being so wonderfully ruthless”—defying authority to bury her slain brother. “I thought, What if I started making a body of art just about her?” Grant, who started her career as a sculptor, had used text from Sophocles’ play (“I

WAS BORN TO LOVE NOT TO HATE”) before; for these new works, she took rubbings from one of her early sculptures using tombstone wax, photographed the results, then screen-printed the images on canvas using different colored inks. “It was much more free.” The paintings, huge and abstract, feature text, prominent straight lines, and organic-looking circles and splotches, some created with a squeegee: “The rules, the lines, being the rule of law, and the paint mess being like real, juicy life, and her voice.”

Grant had worked on the paintings, which she’d brought from Los Angeles, in Chelsea. “This is going to sound super Midwest, but I think of it as making a lasagna—making, assembling, but not cooking,” she said. (Grant grew up in Ohio, Mexico, France, and Spain.) She found New York life “very challenging” but also exciting: Mamdani’s campaign, daily surprises. “The work became about transmutation, this Greek word, *anakainōsis*, a transformation that brings spirit back.” No one knows how to pronounce it, she added. “We’re all laughing, like, ‘How do you say it?’ ” she said. “Do you think I say things out loud before naming them?”

Guests arrived, including Laura Raicovich, Grant’s college friend and a former head of the Queens Museum, who had first introduced the artist to Albrecht after admiring the works during their creation (“I call the pink one ‘Alexandra’s Broadway Boogie-Woogie Time,’ ” Raicovich said); the directors Jörg and Anna Winger (“Deutschland 83”); the writers Debbie Millman, Roxane Gay, and Fred Kaplan; the WNYC host Brooke Gladstone; and Grant’s mother, Marcia, in bright pink, who talked about visiting a Boston flutemaker and then said, “Oh, there’s Keanu.” Reeves, with spiky graying hair, entered, wearing a dark suit and a bionic-looking cast on one finger; all evening, he hovered in the background, near Grant. After a couple of jolly hours, a core group piled into a yellow school bus and drove to Avenue C, to the Francis Kite Club, a community-focussed bar for the “creative industries” which Raicovich co-owns. Albrecht made a toast to Raicovich and then to Grant, “a one-woman ‘creative industry’—publisher, philanthropist, writer, painter, artist. She has an interesting plus-one who is also in the arts.” Grant also made a toast, enthusing about “living in the real world, with real people, with real wine.” Everybody laughed. “This is how we make culture. This is how we overcome power that makes us feel powerless,” she said. People snapped their fingers,

coffeehouse style. “What makes me feel powerful is us being together,” she went on. “People come along at the right time and change your life.” ♦
[Sarah Larson](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2007.

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[Deadpan Dept.](#)

Dan Mintz, Reanimated

The comedian and voice artist puts his “Bob’s Burgers” expertise to the test with a cartoon standup special—produced by the man who officiated his wedding, John Mulaney.

By [Emma Allen](#)

June 22, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Comedians can be control freaks. However freewheeling a standup set may seem, it's usually the product of obsessive trial runs and rewrites. But every comic walks onstage along a precipice of potential disaster. Unless, that is, the set is fully animated, in which case every blink and cough can be endlessly tweaked. Dan Mintz's new YouTube special, "Well Rounded Entertainer," is this kind of routine: it is a cartoon.

In the special, a two-dimensional Mintz delivers a fusillade of non-sequitur one-liners—Borscht Belt-y, but peppered with severed-dick jokes—in a nasal deadpan that is recognizable as the nasal deadpan of Tina Belcher, the angsty teen "Bob's Burgers" cartoon character that Mintz has voiced in more than three hundred episodes. It is uncanny to hear an animated forty-five-year-old man say "A pack-a-day habit is bad for a smoker, but it's really bad for a guy who molests Cub Scouts" in Tina's voice—like seeing Bart Simpson suddenly quoting Scripture.

One recent evening, performing on "The Tonight Show," the human Mintz had no cartoon avatar to hide behind. He rattled off some of his more network-friendly fodder: "I grew up dirt-poor," he began. The audience let out a sympathetic "Aww!" He continued: "We were money-rich, but we had very little dirt."

After the taping, Mintz made his way through the bowels of 30 Rock and perused the menu at a rinkside Italian restaurant. "I always have to Google every kind of pasta," he said. Was a gnocco, he mused, "just a baked potato?" He talked about how John Mulaney, who executive-produced the new special, also officiated at his 2011 wedding. Mintz said that he was nervous before the ceremony—he had to follow Mulaney, after all, and his vows contained a bit. "It started with 'I really wanted these vows to be good. I spent so much time on them, I haven't even had a moment to watch the news,' " Mintz recalled. "Then it was, like, 'Your flaws are as hard to find as Osama bin Laden,' " who'd just been killed. "It was a big swing," he said. "What if I'd bombed?"

Mintz ordered rigatoni carbonara and described a heckler from early in his career. "It was just a woman saying, 'You're not funny and you're a bad comedian!' That's the kind of heckling that happens on TV all the time, but not in real life."

“Well Rounded Entertainer” is not the first-ever cartoon comedy special—Tig Notaro put one out in 2021. But, where Notaro used the format to dramatize long anecdotes, Mintz’s special is mainly just him, in a red T-shirt and glasses, talking into a mike. “Eventually, people convinced me that there should be a reason for the animation,” he said. So he added cameos by “Tom Hanks,” the world’s oldest tree, and a gospel choir.

In an early cut, Mintz didn’t like the shape of his head. “It’s kind of big,” he said, ruefully. “I can’t go to a hat store—I have to go to Big Hats for Big Heads.” He continued, “The tricky part was that, if someone’s trying to draw a picture of you, the funniest version is kind of insulting. But if you take the edit too far it’s like airbrushing a head shot.”

The animated set is based on a live show Mintz did at Dynasty Typewriter, in Los Angeles. The audience was packed with parents from his kids’ school (he has an eleven-year-old and a thirteen-year-old), who turned out not to be the biggest laughers. “But I didn’t want to see people laughing hard,” Mintz insisted. “If you see it, people will be, like, ‘You *drew* that! You drew them to laugh at you!’ ”

He thought back on his own teen years, in Anchorage, Alaska: “I was kind of similar to Tina, I guess, except maybe without her confidence.” He adopted his monotonic demeanor in the seventh grade, when, he said, “I just felt, like, ‘I can’t betray any kind of emotion.’ ” In high school, “I realized that, if I said something sexually inappropriate in my voice, it would get a laugh.” (From the special: “I think anything’s O.K. if there are two consenting adults—except a threesome.” A classic Tina-ism: “I’m nuts for butts.”)

For his closer on Fallon, he opted for the opening joke from the special: “When you’re little and you hear a noise in the middle of the night, you’re, like, ‘Please be the water heater, not a monster.’ But when you grow up you’re, like, ‘Please be a monster, not my water heater.’ ” Mintz had been nervous about how it would play, he explained, because, “in Manhattan, people aren’t homeowners.” He prayed that there’d be people from Jersey in the house. The joke killed. ♦

[Emma Allen](#) is *The New Yorker*’s cartoon editor and edits humor pieces on [newyorker.com](#).

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[Brave New World Dept.](#)

Isabel J. Kim Makes Her Own World

At a board-game café on the Upper West Side, the lawyer and author discusses her new book, “Sublimation,” about borders, parallel selves, and an eerily Trump-like government.

By [Luis A. Gómez](#)

June 22, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Wednesday evenings at Hex&Co., a board-game café and bar in Morningside Heights, are dedicated to “RPG Encounters,” in which fans of role-playing games gather to create collaborative stories over espresso drinks. On a recent R.P.G. night, Isabel J. Kim—a speculative-fiction author whose first novel, “Sublimation,” came out in June—sat at a table in front of a long shelf cluttered with games.

“People really love writing tabletop games, almost as an art form,” Kim, who has long dark hair and was wearing a floral blouse, said. Kim had a busy spring: she turned thirty, got married, and published “Sublimation.” (Universal bought the TV rights before the book was even out.) Her own love for T.T.R.P.G.s, a multibillion-dollar subset of the larger board-gaming industry, began in college, with a Dungeons & Dragons group, but solidified during *COVID*, when she began taking a literary interest in the games she played. “There’s a million indie games that are, like, one or two pages, and, quite frankly, a lot of them are not playable,” she said. “But it is very interesting to read them.”

On the table in front of her was a small burlap bag containing the rudiments of a mapmaking game called the Quiet Year, in which players use a sheet of paper, a pen, some dice, and a deck of special cards to tell the story of a community struggling to rebuild after society collapses. The game begins in spring, and ends when the Frost Shepherds card, representing the arrival of deep winter, is pulled. Kim started turning over cards and quickly added elements to her town—a mountain river, an evil cave, a charismatic young woman. For each new element, she made a rough sketch on the map. “When you write a story, you are creating an artificial situation that is supposed to look natural, and, if you do your job right, it looks effortless,” she said.

Kim was born in New Jersey, and grew up moving where her father’s job as a physics professor took him. In South Korea, she lived in a house in the small suburban town of Gongju, which quickly expanded when dozens of governmental offices moved to the nearby planned administrative capital of Sejong City. “Every time I would go back, more of the city would be built,” she said. “At first, it was, like, ‘Wow, they’re building high rises and stuff.’ And then, like, ‘Wow, they got a Starbucks. Wow, they got a Costco?’ ”

Kim wrote fiction while studying law and fine art at the University of Pennsylvania, and continued after she became an associate at a big law firm. She chose speculative fiction—an umbrella genre that encompasses sci-fi, dystopia, fantasy, and horror—because, she said, “you can critique a lot of what’s going on in our world without people immediately jumping to feeling defensive.”



"I know it sounds counterintuitive, boys, but if we want to rob the train we've got to catch the train, and to catch the train we're gonna have to play hard to get."

Cartoon by Avi Steinberg

"Sublimation" describes a world where crossing a border creates an "instance," an identical version of oneself, who must proceed on to another country and another life while the original remains in place. The book was written before the second Trump Administration's immigration crackdown became daily news; in "Sublimation," government bureaucrats and their corporate collaborators are "politely evil," Kim said. "They're white-glove evil. The characters feel like they have options because they are urban professionals who have money and privilege."

She went on, "Immigration is not just a 'somebody you never talk to' issue. It's not a 'somebody who works for you' issue. It is an issue that affects people of every social class. The way that people think about the world around them, and about mobility, is going to change a lot depending on whether they have a quote-unquote good passport."

Back in the game, Kim's paper map was getting filled in; what was once a tiny mining town now had paved roads, a pier, houses, and a mysterious woodland fairy circle. Finally, after ninety minutes, she pulled the Frost Shepherds card: game over.

"Sublimation" is threaded with references to the Odyssey, the Book of Genesis, and the Korean folk song "Arirang"—all stories about departure and return that include themes akin to "instancings." "In the universe of my book, we consider being a nation of instances a point of pride," Kim said, "in the same way that America, during previous Administrations, might have considered our diversity a strength." ♦

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The Teen Believers in a Christian America

For Charlie Kirk's followers, faith and patriotism are intertwined.

By [Eliza Griswold](#)

June 22, 2026



Club America, the youth offshoot of Turning Point, expanded after Kirk's death. "The whole world misses Charlie," Gracie Bell Joyce said. Photograph by Josh Aronson for The New Yorker

Wild Cargo Pets, situated just south of the intersection of Gun Club Road and Military Trail, in West Palm Beach, is a renowned local institution. During the past seventy-five years, the family-owned store has taken exotic animals to visit children at the homes of the Kennedys and, more recently, Donald Trump, Jr. One early-spring morning, a sign above the parking lot

read “*THE SON OF MAN WILL RETURN JUST LIKE THE DAYS OF NOAH.*” Inside the shop, Gracie Bell Joyce, who is sixteen, with deep dimples and hazel eyes, reached into a glass terrarium to stroke Big Bertha, the Colombian red-tailed boa that acts as Wild Cargo’s ambassador.

“She’s super, super sweet,” Joyce said. “She will bite, but she hasn’t bit anyone.” Joyce, whose parents are second-generation owners of the store, is an “unschooler,” meaning she has directed her own education: she learned to read by filling orders at the store, and to add and subtract by working the register. She also raised a baby kangaroo named Bunny, who slept in a pouch at the end of her bed. But Joyce’s job at the pet store served a higher purpose. While advising customers on care for an albino python or a bearded dragon, she evangelized them. Joyce told me, “The best way to do it when you’re explaining how to take care of an animal, you always say, ‘Copy God’s natural design.’ ”

Joyce’s hero is Charlie Kirk, the late conservative influencer, who called upon young people to extoll the Gospel wherever they went. In April, 2025, he told an audience of eighteen hundred college students at the University of Wyoming that even if they became electricians they could still evangelize. “You’re probably gonna walk into ten thousand to fifteen thousand homes,” he said. “That is a mission field.”

In 2024, when Joyce was fourteen, she founded a Palm Beach County chapter of Kirk’s youth organization, Turning Point USA. Kirk and his group were vital to turnout efforts for all three of Donald Trump’s campaigns, and leading a Turning Point chapter in Trump’s home county put Joyce in startling proximity to power. In 2025, she attended the Celebrate American Exceptionalism gala at Mar-a-Lago, where she was one of the youngest people in the room. “I was talking to people who were my parents’ and grandparents’ age and with some of the richest people in the world,” she said. “It was insane.” Through Turning Point, she became friendly with the owner of an aviation company; she said that she occasionally ran into Kimberly Guilfoyle, Trump’s Ambassador to Greece and Trump, Jr.’s ex-fiancée.

For Joyce, however, Kirk’s political positions were much less important than his faith. “He was huge on pro-life,” she explained. “He was huge on a

Christian stance on everything. He was really big on bringing back our base values in America that we were founded on.” Her activism with Turning Point was about promoting Christianity in schools and homes. “I’m not encouraging kids to start a chapter or start their own podcast. I’m encouraging kids to go to church or to read their Bible more,” she said.

Joyce was young for a Turning Point leader: there were some high-school chapters, but most were run by college students. Her age didn’t faze her. Kirk, after all, had started his right-wing youth movement shortly after graduating from high school, with the aim of opposing left-wing efforts such as Occupy Wall Street and MoveOn. He quickly became a darling of older Republicans. At the 2012 Republican National Convention, he secured a ten-thousand-dollar donation to his organization from the prominent evangelical investment manager Foster Friess. Soon, Kirk, who was from the suburbs of Chicago, began courting donors in Palm Beach. His previous garb of nerdy suits gave way to sports coats and sneakers.



Kirk often spoke about the Founders, claiming that they had envisioned the United States as a Christian nation. Photograph from USA TODAY Network / Reuters

Kirk, who dropped out of community college, made universities the testing ground for his movement. Not long after he founded Turning Point, Kirk began staging tours of American colleges, taking on liberal students in rapid-fire encounters that came to be called “Prove Me Wrong” debates. The topics—“Abortion is murder,” “College is a scam”—were designed to provoke his challengers, and as the events grew more popular, drawing hundreds or thousands of onlookers, Kirk developed his iconic approach to ideological opponents. He became annoyingly calm, unspooling practiced arguments about crime in Black communities or the dangers of illegal

immigration. He was a talented debater, though he sometimes leaned on misleading statistics and memorable one-liners. “Kids are way more important than being a data scientist at Dropbox,” he told one young woman, who argued for starting a career before having children. “We have seen a spike where half of women in their thirties that are unmarried are on antidepressants.” (This is inaccurate.) Although Kirk would occasionally concede a point or confess that he didn’t have a ready response to a question, the aim of these debates wasn’t mutual understanding; it was reducing his opponents to a state of outrage or dismay.

Among Gen Z-ers, clips from Kirk’s debates went viral, circulating on social media and YouTube with headlines such as “Charlie Kirk *DESTROYS* Liberal Logic.” He modelled arguments for young conservatives to follow. Beginning in her early teens, Joyce loved watching Kirk’s debates on Instagram, seeing in them not carefully honed rhetorical tactics but authentic civility. “He could completely win the argument and debate—no matter how rude, disgusting, and nasty these people would get toward him,” she told me. “He was not fake. He was not stuck up. He was kind. He was caring. He listened.”

Last year, on September 10th, Kirk was assassinated in the midst of a debate, in front of some three thousand people at Utah Valley University. Afterward, Joyce was inundated with D.M.s, phone calls, and visits to the pet store by kids who wanted to get involved in Turning Point or start their own chapters. Joyce knew that her state was growing redder. Still, she said, “I didn’t realize how fast Florida was going until I got a million different requests.” This spring, even as teens launched chapters of Turning Point across Palm Beach County, they grappled with dissension within the organization over Kirk’s legacy and Trump’s wars. Some began to move away from it. Joyce remained. She told me, “There are some kids like myself who have put their faith in their trust and courage in God and continue to walk forward.”

At the time of Kirk’s assassination, he was arguably the most powerful political organizer in America. Beginning in 2016, when Kirk was twenty-two, he spoke at each Republican National Convention. He harnessed his charisma, his organizing power, and his closeness to the Trump family to

build the largest and wealthiest right-wing youth organization in the country, with revenue of eighty-five million dollars in 2024. That fall, Kirk visited twenty-four college campuses and travelled with a new Christian arm of his organization, TPUSA Faith, to cast the Presidential election as a fight against evil. Democrats “stand for everything God hates,” Kirk said, calling the Trump campaign “a spiritual battle.”

Kirk had been animated first by traditional Republican topics, such as school vouchers and lower taxes, and he still sometimes spoke about those issues. But, after defending the separation of church and state early in his career, he’d embraced the Christian vision of America that drew Joyce to his movement. The pandemic played a pivotal role in this transformation. As campuses shut down, his college tours were cancelled. Many states and local governments limited in-person worship, deeming large gatherings unsafe; Kirk began speaking to congregations that defied *COVID* regulations. “Charlie thought that the church was going to push back, and they didn’t,” Andrew Kolvet, a spokesperson for Turning Point and the producer of Kirk’s daily broadcast, “The Charlie Kirk Show,” told me. “And so he realized that there was a huge void in the space for churches to get on board and to be a part of this liberty movement.”



Cartoon by Joe Dator

In the pandemic years, Kirk found common cause with Rob McCoy, an influential pastor from Godspeak Calvary Chapel, in Southern California, and a proponent of a once little-known movement called the Seven Mountains Mandate. Seven Mountains has brought the language of spiritual

warfare and demon-fighting into the mainstream of evangelicalism, through a network of pastors who view themselves as prophets and apostles engaged in a battle against evil secular forces. The movement “is both political and religious,” Matthew Boedy, a professor of English at the University of North Georgia and the author of a book about Seven Mountains, explained. Its leaders, who include the televangelists Lance Wallnau and Paula White, urge believers to take control of seven spheres of influence in the United States—education, entertainment, media, religion, family, business, and government. “Seven Mountains isn’t just charismatic theology,” Kristin Du Mez, a professor of history at Calvin University who studies the current Christian right, told me. “This is a vision for a total takeover of society.”

Kirk helped popularize some of the principles of Seven Mountains, introducing the idea of the seven spheres to his millions of followers. His broader notion of returning America to its supposed theological origins is often known as Christian nationalism. (Kolvet rejected the term, calling it “a pejorative used to smear and categorize conservative Christians.”) Kirk often spoke about the Founders, arguing that the country had been envisioned by and for Protestants. “One of the reasons we’re living through a constitutional crisis is that we no longer have a Christian nation, but we have a Christian form of government, and they’re incompatible,” he said in 2024. His later posts online interspersed paeans to Scripture with warnings about American decline and support for President Trump’s immigration policies. “No civilization has ever collapsed because it prays too much,” he wrote on X a week before his death. “But a civilization that abandons God will deteriorate and ultimately collapse from the inside out, or because it loses the will to repel a malicious, external force.” For Kirk and millions of other believers, those forces were terrifyingly real. Speaking at Illinois State University in 2025, he warned of “an unknown, unseen demonic realm.”

Two days after Kirk was killed, his widow, Erika Kirk, declared him “a martyr.” She exhorted his young followers, “If you aren’t a member of a church, I beg you to join one, a Bible-believing church. Our battle is not simply a political one above all. It is spiritual. The spiritual warfare is palpable.” Kirk’s memorial, which took place in Arizona, where he had lived, was attended by nearly a hundred thousand people. Held at State Farm Stadium, in Glendale, the event featured remarks by President Trump

and Vice-President J. D. Vance, who had flown to Utah on Air Force Two to bring Kirk's body home. Pete Hegseth, the Secretary of Defense, declared Kirk "a warrior for Christ," who "started a political movement but unleashed a spiritual revival." The conservative talk-show host Tucker Carlson, who counted Kirk as a spiritual adviser, struck a prophetic note, comparing Kirk's death to the Crucifixion. "He was bringing the Gospel to the country," Carlson said. "He was doing the thing that the people in charge hate most, which is calling for them to repent."

In the final months of his life, Kirk rebranded Turning Point's high-school chapters, casting them as part of his new vision of the United States. He called the program Club America. "We realized that the indoctrination of young kids to hate their country and to think that we're just a bunch of systemically oppressive colonialists that hate Indigenous people was happening earlier and earlier," Kolvet told me. "We wanted to have a presence in high schools, so that conservative kids, Christian kids, more liberty-minded kids, kids who were curious or who just had a penchant for loving their country, had a place to meet and gather."

According to Kolvet, the name, which was first suggested by Turning Point field organizers, delighted Kirk. "Charlie loved calling it Club America," Kolvet said. "How can you not love a club that celebrates America?" Club America would focus more on patriotism than on partisanship, encouraging students to put up flags and stand for the Pledge of Allegiance. "Let's keep it simple," Kolvet said, recalling Kirk's thinking. "We love the greatness of America. We believe in the exceptionalism of this country and in the Providence of God having his hand on this country." Faith, he added, was integrated into every aspect of Turning Point. "It doesn't mean that you have to be a Christian to be part of Club America, but, listen, there's so many kids that were inspired by Charlie's faith," he said. "So it's there, and it's a huge part of it."

Kirk's ambition was to seed a Club America chapter in every high school in the country. Kolvet told me that, after Kirk's death, he "realized that Charlie's vision was within reach." Officials in eight states—Arkansas, Florida, Indiana, Montana, Nebraska, Oklahoma, Tennessee, and Texas—encouraged students to establish Club America chapters in their public

schools, often describing the group as devoted to free speech and civil discourse. Turning Point says there are now thirty-six hundred Club America chapters nationwide. (Not all are officially recognized as student organizations.)

After Kirk's death, Club America chapters proliferated in Palm Beach County's private schools, including the Benjamin School, which is among the most academically rigorous. The school was founded in 1960, when the town of Palm Beach was mostly a seasonal community. Now, following the pandemic, Palm Beach has become a leading destination for families relocating from New Jersey, New York, and California. High-school tuition at Benjamin is roughly forty thousand dollars per year. Tiger Woods's son, Charlie, recently finished his junior year, and Trump, Jr.,'s daughter Kai just graduated.



Liam Duffy argued the liberal side in high-school debates inspired by Kirk. "A lot of people like the spectacle," he said. Photograph by Josh Aronson for The New Yorker

"This is primarily a white and wealthy school," Nahla Bond, a junior and the president of the diversity council, told me when I visited the campus

this spring. “The parents are Republicans, and so are the kids.” But events in students’ lifetimes also played a role in sharpening their opinions. Darren Lowe, a retired banker and the former chair of the board of the Benjamin School, told me, “The kids that are growing up here that are the *COVID* babies, who are ages fourteen to twenty, question other people telling them what to do.” During the pandemic, Lowe, the father of two boys, wrestled with establishing safety measures at Benjamin, and he was struck by the arbitrariness of many health protocols. “We found there were a lot of doctors that were wrong on the right. There were a lot of doctors that were wrong on the left,” he said. “And we also found that no doctor ever came back to us and said, ‘By the way, I was wrong.’ ” Kids in the community, including Lowe’s elder son and his friends, were subject to inconsistent rules, which made them quick to question authority. “They grew up faster,” Lowe said.

Unbeknownst to many parents, Charlie Kirk was reaching millions of adolescents online during the *COVID* lockdown, warning about government overreach and liberal shaming. After Kirk claimed that the drug hydroxychloroquine was “100 percent effective” in treating *COVID*-19, he was temporarily banned from Twitter. But kids weren’t following him on Twitter. They were watching videos of him on YouTube, TikTok, and Instagram, in which Kirk stoked resistance to vaccine mandates, arguing that they created “almost this apartheid-style, open-air hostage situation” and that they were particularly unfair to low-risk groups, such as people under thirty. “Children are so phone-based and YouTube-based that a lot of us as parents, if we were more middle of the road, were surprised at how the children were viewing it,” Lowe told me. By taking on established authority figures, Kirk became phenomenally consequential. “I would say that eighty per cent of the parents down here learned about Charlie Kirk and what he was presenting after he died, not before,” Lowe said. “And his death galvanized those children.”

About a week after Kirk’s killing, Benjamin observed a minute of silence in his honor at the end of an assembly, which was followed by an invitation to gather at a flagpole and pray. Students went on to found the Club America chapter, which quickly became one of the most popular groups at the school, amassing forty or fifty members. Ava Seested, a senior, had started

watching Kirk's debates in middle school. When he died, she said, "everyone who followed him felt the loss of a brother, because of how grounded he was in his faith, how much he led people to God." Julian Koehler, a sophomore and a nationally ranked golfer, first encountered Kirk on Instagram and was drawn to his stance on abortion; Kirk opposed it, on the basis of his Christian faith, with virtually no exceptions. Koehler's mother, Evelyn Burbano-Koehler, credited Kirk with kicking off a spiritual revival. "In this country, it became bad to have faith and say the word 'God,' but it's changing," she told me. (A recent Gallup poll suggests that young men, in particular, are experiencing a deepening connection to their faith, with forty-two per cent saying religion is "very important" to them.)

The praise for Charlie Kirk proved controversial among some Benjamin students. Bond said she was "shocked" that her classmates were honoring Kirk. Although she described her political leanings as "libertarian"—a term she landed on by doing an online quiz in her A.P. government class—she was turned off by Kirk's statements about civil rights and gender identity, among other topics. He frequently maligned Black leaders, calling Martin Luther King, Jr., "a bad guy," and described the Civil Rights Act of 1964 as "a huge mistake." He said that "the transgender thing happening in America" was "a throbbing middle finger to God." Kirk was also a proponent of the "great replacement" theory, which posits that a liberal élite—particularly Jews—is attempting to erase white America by flooding the country with immigrants. "They won't stop until you and your children and your children's children are eliminated," he warned. Bond asked, "What Charlie Kirk said about women and people of color, how can you agree with that or think that's normal?"



Juan Suarez Escobar and Alexandra Kravetz founded a chapter of Kirk's high-school group, Club America. "Charlie Kirk reflected Christ in ways I could only imagine doing," Suarez Escobar said. Photograph by Josh Aronson for The New Yorker

Liam Duffy, a sandy-haired senior who served as vice-president of the diversity council and president of the student body, vehemently opposed Kirk. Duffy, who is openly gay, was well liked and more outspoken than many of his classmates. One evening, he invited me over for a dinner of filet mignon and baked sweet potatoes with his parents and his sister, a sophomore at Benjamin. During dinner, as CNN played in the background, Duffy pointed out that a few weeks earlier the TV would've been tuned to Fox News. His parents, who had voted for Trump in the past three elections, were moving away from him because of his increasing engagement in foreign wars. Still, they didn't share their son's liberal politics or his disdain for Kirk. "He's homophobic, so I'm not a fan," Duffy said. "I also think he's racist."

A few days later, Duffy hosted my visit to Benjamin. Duffy, who'd been handing out Dunkin' Donuts to classmates, led me through an airy compound of blue-and-white buildings surrounding a turf-covered knoll

dotted with Adirondack chairs. Outside an English classroom, a bulletin board featured an image of a smiling pig and the last line of “Animal Farm”: “The creatures outside looked from pig to man, and from man to pig, and from pig to man again; but already it was impossible to say which was which.”

Inside the classroom, Duffy introduced me to Seested, who wore a Parke mock-turtleneck sweatshirt. (“Hoodies overstimulate me,” she said.) A transplant from the North, like so many kids at Benjamin, she grew up in Maryland as a nondenominational Christian, attending Catholic school until she was nine. “I would go to school and do Hail Marys,” she said. “I knew deep down that my belief was that we only pray to God.”

In 2017, Seested’s family threw out their snow scrapers and moved to Florida, where she found herself among like-minded Christians and a welcoming conservative culture. Seested soon began watching Kirk on YouTube at night before bed. “I wanted to be informed about why I was believing what I believed, and I wanted to have the facts,” she said. Seested was especially compelled by Kirk’s strong stance on illegal immigration. Her mother, Biani Xavier, had emigrated legally from Brazil, and the family felt that, as Xavier told me later, “if someone gets deported, they’re breaking a law.” Seested said that watching Kirk had taught her “to be very proud of what you believe in but also be respectful and do it in a way that you love everyone.”

Seested attended Club America’s lunchtime debates, which took place in a calculus classroom decorated with University of Florida pennants. Inspired by a format often used on Jubilee, a popular YouTube channel, one conservative student took a seat in the center of a ring of chairs, and liberal audience members jostled to sit across from him and debate him. They argued over hot-button topics—health care, gun rights—in three-minute rounds. Seested didn’t volunteer to debate, but she listened closely and was impressed by the eloquence of speakers on both sides. “I think he had good facts, good evidence,” she said of a liberal classmate. “Although I don’t agree.”



"I'm thinking maybe the time has come for me to grow a beard and have a second act."
Cartoon by William Haefeli

Later, Duffy told me that, despite the high rates of attendance, he was one of only about ten kids willing to participate at the debates. At the first one, in November, he'd argued in favor of abortion and gun control. At another, in February, he'd contested the legality of *ICE* raids in Minneapolis. But, when one student made a provocative claim that noncitizens aren't entitled to equal protection, the debate devolved. Boys on the sidelines began to clap and whoop. "A lot of people like the spectacle," Duffy said. "It's like watching a YouTube video."

Club America had a moment at Benjamin, but it may have more lasting appeal among teens who see themselves as being outside the conservative establishment. Kirk was fixated on the economic woes of young people. "You don't have to stay poor," he said in his speech at the 2024 Republican National Convention. "You don't have to accept being worse off than your parents. . . . You don't have to support leaders who lied to you and took advantage of you for your vote." Many kids joined Club America in part because Kirk's conservative principles appealed to them and in part because rubbing elbows with wealthy donors who frequented Mar-a-Lago did, too.

One afternoon, Gracie Bell Joyce met three current and former officers of Club America at a Starbucks a couple of miles from the pet store. The four were friends, and Joyce called the others her “team.” Jayden Antropov, a floppy-haired recent high-school graduate, had taken the day off from working two part-time jobs, at Publix and at a burger joint. He was the only one who’d met Kirk, he told me proudly; Antropov had encountered him at two Turning Point events in 2023, and Kirk had called on him to start a chapter at his high school, in Palm Beach County. Nick Perisse, wearing a suit and a red tie, was a fervent young Catholic whose family had arrived from Brazil in 2017. He’d founded a chapter at his public high school, in neighboring Martin County, in 2025. Juan Suarez Escobar, who was born in Venezuela, had emigrated from Colombia with his family in 2016. He was a student at a private Christian school, the King’s Academy, and ran a regional chapter of Club America. He also worked as a cater waiter and pulled espresso shots at a nearby BMW dealership on weekends.

In addition to the pressures of work and school, there were challenges to being a visible member of Kirk’s movement. “There’s a million people out there who hate us,” Joyce said as she waited in line for a Mint Majesty tea with two pumps of honey—Kirk’s signature drink. When her tea was ready, Joyce cupped her hands around the warm drink and recounted a story she’d seen on Instagram of a woman who’d made the same order only to have “loser” written on her cup. “Anytime I post something in support of Trump, I get ‘MAGA maggot’ in my comment section,” Joyce said.

Perisse had recently represented Turning Point in a debate at the University of South Florida St. Petersburg, and he’d been heckled by liberals while he was arguing against abortion. “I was booed and called a fascist,” he said. Perisse was an intellectual, and his family wasn’t rich; he was used to being an outsider, which was a large part of why he liked Kirk. “Charlie led a group of students who felt disenfranchised by the establishment, who for years were cast aside as if their opinions had no value,” he said.

Joyce posed the boys for a picture, calling them her “fellow-nerds.” Suarez Escobar ducked out of the frame. “Speak for yourself!” he said. He hoped to be a Marine pilot, and with aviators hanging from the neck of his quarter zip he epitomized the new “Top Gun” conservative aesthetic. Suarez

Escobar said he had been drawn to Kirk's movement mostly because of his own political leanings—he described himself as a fan of Marco Rubio—and also because he viewed it as “helpful for college.” In 2024, the same year he became a U.S. citizen, he tried to start a Turning Point chapter at the King's Academy. But the school demurred, he told me, so he'd founded his regional chapter in Palm Beach Gardens, a city of some sixty thousand people just north of West Palm Beach.



Days after Kirk was killed, his wife, Erika, exhorted his followers to join a church. “The spiritual warfare is palpable,” she told them. Photograph from Bloomberg / Getty

Around a blond-wood table, the teens traded stories about how *COVID-19* had informed their perspectives. As middle schoolers during the pandemic, they'd endured masking, Zoom school, and vaccine mandates. Joyce, as a homeschooler, was a step ahead: her family already opposed all vaccination. “I have never gotten a vaccine,” she said. She asked her friends about the *COVID-19* vaccine. “Any of you guys got it?” All three said no and quickly pivoted to talking points. “It showed Charlie's point that freedom is not free. Authoritarianism is always knocking at the door,” Perisse argued. Suarez Escobar said, “We're all about ‘My body, my choice’ ”—the anti-vaccination movement has adopted the abortion-rights slogan. “But we didn't have a choice back then.” As a seventh grader, he'd spoken out at school against the vaccine. “A girl slapped me,” he said.

The following afternoon, Suarez Escobar invited me to visit the King's Academy. It was born out of a prayer circle, in 1969, in which a group of evangelical businessmen began to speak about the need for a major Christian school in Palm Beach County. Since then, the King's Academy, which is dedicated to “the King of Kings and Lord of Lords,” has come to occupy a sprawling sixty-five-acre campus in West Palm Beach.

When school let out, at 3:05 P.M., a line of Mercedes S.U.V.s and Cadillac Escalades snaked around the lot, driven by women in hand-knit sweaters with tousled hair. Gone were the outmoded trappings of evangelical subculture (“The higher the hair, the closer to God”). Suarez Escobar was waiting for me in the school’s glassed-in entry, along with Alexandra Kravecz, the vice-president of his Club America chapter. She was also his girlfriend. Wearing a blue-and-red plaid uniform skort and carrying a Stanley tumbler bedazzled with the American flag, she led the way across campus, noting, with pride, that Mike Pence was going to be their graduation speaker. “That’s insane to me,” Kravecz said, gleefully.

High-school tuition at the academy is at least thirty thousand dollars, and Kravecz was on a partial scholarship from a Christian pre-law-studies program. She took me to a vast mock courtroom at the school, which was wood-panelled and windowless, with a judge’s bench, a witness stand, and a large gallery. Stencilled on one wall was the Preamble to the Constitution. Every year, she had to stand up in the courtroom before her donors and prove to them what she’d learned about the law. She also participated in law and debate competitions against other schools. These events were secular, Kravecz explained, but the King’s Academy kids argued their positions from “a Biblical perspective.”

Leaving the building, Suarez Escobar and Kravecz settled in the sunshine at a round blue picnic table and talked about their Club America activities. Most of what they did was hand out merch—laptop stickers and tiny Constitutions sent to them by Turning Point. “Charlie Kirk stood up for what Jesus would believe in,” Kravecz said. Suarez Escobar was wearing a navy-blue polo that revealed a Latin phrase tattooed on his right biceps: “*Aut viam inveniam aut faciam*”—“I shall either find a way or make one,” a quote attributed to Hannibal, the Carthaginian general who, in the third century B.C.E., battled against the powerful Roman Republic. A few weeks ago, Suarez Escobar texted me to say that he’d decided to go to Florida State University, where Kravecz was also headed. Suarez Escobar was determined to become the president of F.S.U.’s Turning Point chapter. “I have a lot of vision, and I feel like I have the charisma to get it done,” he told me.

In his view, winning teens over to Club America wasn't a matter of hammering home statistics. "I don't force facts down their face, because you don't really learn from facts at the end of the day," he said. "You gotta appeal to people's emotions." Suarez Escobar described Kirk as a modern-day version of the Apostle Paul, who spread the Christian message throughout the ancient world in the years following Jesus' death. He said, "Charlie Kirk reflected Christ in ways I could only imagine doing."

In Kirk's absence, the Trump Administration has attempted to anoint someone else to legitimize its Christian bona fides. Pete Hegseth, a Christian nationalist, has served as one of Kirk's stand-ins, but J. D. Vance's messaging has carried more authority. In May, at a prayer rally on the National Mall, Vance, appearing by video, invoked George Washington, John Adams, and "my dear friend, the late, great Charlie Kirk." Kirk believed that "all law reflects a morality" and that both law and morality "ultimately come from religion," Vance said. "And the morality and religion that formed the American consciousness were decidedly Christian."

These ideas continued to animate Kirk's followers, but by the end of the spring semester Turning Point's influence had waned. At Benjamin, Club America still held well-attended meetings, but the energy had "kind of died down," Koehler told me. When the chapter first started, he had been so enthusiastic that he'd hoped to become an officer. Not anymore. He felt the same admiration for Kirk, but he'd lost interest in Turning Point. "I don't see them on my social-media feed, any big campus events," he said. "It's less about free speech and more supporting Trump." And young people were losing interest in Trump, as he saw it. No one wanted more "forever wars."

Duffy offered more pointed observations. "With high schoolers, it's more about what they see on their social media," he said. Kirk had disappeared from their feeds, and Erika Kirk had gone viral for the wrong reasons—taking the stage at her husband's memorial service amid pyrotechnics and attempting her own campus tour, undermining her image as a Christian trad wife whose priorities were her family and her home. "There's been all kinds of attacks from the left but also from the right," Du Mez, the historian of the Christian right, said of Erika. "She seems to lack any kind of authenticity."

Crowds had thinned at recent Turning Point events, and after Erika failed to appear at a University of Georgia rally, citing security concerns, the chapter president resigned. With the *MAGA* alliance strained and conspiracy theories emerging about Kirk's death, it wasn't clear who, if anyone, possessed the gravitas to hold Turning Point together. "Erika Kirk made it into a joke," Duffy said. "It's not a good look. People don't want to be associated with it." (In a text message, Kolvet wrote, "Erika Kirk has displayed incredible courage and strength, stepping into an unimaginable tragedy while shepherding Turning Point through the largest, most explosive growth period in its history." He added that the organization is "100% behind Erika Kirk.")



Joyce has started praying over her family's pet shop, Wild Cargo. "I notice there's less chaos," she said. Photograph by Josh Aronson for The New Yorker

If Turning Point was to survive, it would likely need to continue moving, as Kirk had, toward a Christian politics. "Charlie Kirk was one of the most open-minded people," Tucker Carlson told me. "Maybe because of his age, Charlie was absolutely delighted to change his views." Carlson, who began

reading the Bible four years ago and claims he has read no other book since, noted that Kirk took a radically progressive tone in an interview with him last summer. Kirk had fretted about the heavy debt loads of young people and what he described as an “economic nihilism that has set into a lot of this next generation.” He saw a solution in the Bible. “One of the more beautiful teachings is called the Year of Jubilee,” Kirk said. Every fifty years, all debt was abolished. “I know I sound like a left-wing, Elizabeth Warren person,” Kirk went on. “I don’t care.”

When Carlson and I spoke, he proposed that Kirk was feeling his way toward “a Christian economic system.” “I don’t know that there’s a prescription for it in the New Testament. However, I do know there’s a lot about money and the purpose of it, and it’s to serve other people,” Carlson said. “And so I know that whatever we have now is like the opposite of a Christian economic system.”

Since Kirk died, Carlson has continued to develop his thinking about Christianity as a blueprint for America. In February, he withdrew his support for Trump, calling Trump’s foreign interventions “not acceptable for Christians.” He asked, after Trump posted an image of himself as Jesus, “Could this be the Antichrist? Well, who knows?” Carlson told me that he’d never heard of the Seven Mountains Mandate, but he echoes many of the movement’s ideas, saying that Trump’s ability to bend others to his will may be “supernatural” and that the Iran war is driven by “demonic influence.” Carlson has spoken of his own brush with demonic forces, who left him bloodied and scratched in the night, while his wife and their four spaniels slept undisturbed. He has also used more secular language to describe his fear and disillusionment. “You vote for a guy who’s wholly outside the political system in order to change the political system, and he’s immediately captured by the political system and becomes its most effective tool,” he told me. “So what does that tell you? It tells you that politics is not the solution.”

In Carlson’s view, “politics has reached its terminus,” he said. “So your options at that point are violent revolution—which I think Palantir is going to make pretty difficult to pull off—or spiritual revival.” But though Carlson and many of Kirk’s young followers were moving away from

Trump, there were few indications that right-wing Christians were abandoning him. When Trump posted the image of himself as Jesus, Franklin Graham, a son of Billy Graham and the leader of his father's evangelical empire, defended him. "He is the most pro-Christian, pro-life president in my lifetime," Graham wrote on X. Du Mez said she had "a hard time seeing a full parting of ways" between Christian nationalists and the Trump Administration. "What they have in common is the realization that majoritarian democracy will impede their goals. And they both need each other."

As the summer began, Gracie Bell Joyce still missed Kirk profoundly. "The whole world misses Charlie," she told me. Joyce, who didn't like to criticize anyone, was reluctant to call out Erika Kirk, but she said that, as Erika's credibility plummeted, friends and family members had called on her to leave Turning Point. "The first thing that came to my mind when everyone was telling me, 'Quit, quit, quit,' was Isaiah 41:10: 'Fear not, for I am with you; be not dismayed, for I am your God. I will strengthen you and uphold you with my righteous right hand,' " Joyce said. "And so I said, 'Lord, if it is not for me, pull me out of it.' " But she had received no indication that God wanted her to leave Kirk's movement.

Joyce was moving away from *MAGA*, which she'd never really embraced. "I got a hat and a sticker on Election Night, but I've never worn them," she said. She also tired easily of the various voices vying for power in Kirk's absence. "Everyone hates Nick Fuentes," she said, of the popular white nationalist. "I don't agree with Nick Fuentes, but I don't agree with Taylor Swift, either."

Recently, Joyce has taken to praying over Wild Cargo Pets. "Every single day before I open up, I put my AirPods in, I put on worship music," she told me. "As I'm sweeping and vacuuming and mopping, I'm praying." She lights a white timber Pet Odor Exterminator candle to mask the scent of fish scales and furry bodies. Then she checks on the three hundred baby chicks the store has for sale, to make sure "everyone's alive and kicking."

She asks for God's guidance during her day, and for his protection. The store has received unnerving visitors in the past: one man, after being refused a rabbit, flashed a firearm, which turned out to be a toy. Now that

Joyce was praying in the store, “I’ve noticed there’s less chaos,” she said. She was talking to Turning Point about starting an explicitly faith-based chapter. “I really, really, really, really want to do that,” she said. “But at the end of the day, no matter what happens with Turning Point, I’m still here, unless they take me out.” ♦

[Eliza Griswold](#) is a contributing writer. Her book “[Circle of Hope](#),” about the evangelical church, was a finalist for the 2024 National Book Award. She directs the Program in Journalism at Princeton.

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What Science Knows About Grief

After my husband's death, I had never been more pliable, tender, open, or raw. It was then that I tried E.M.D.R. therapy.

By [Amanda Petrusich](#)

June 22, 2026



“We talk about trauma recovery,” a psychologist said. “We do not talk about grief recovery. Grief is an adaptation process.” Illustration by Jillian Tamaki

In 1967, Leonard Cohen released “So Long, Marianne,” a requiem for a love affair that was unravelling, or at least transforming in some critical way. The song is romantic—the Marianne of its title was Cohen’s girlfriend and muse in the nineteen-sixties—but its fourth verse contains what I’ve always thought was a profound articulation of grief:

Your letters, they all say that you're beside me now
Then why do I feel so alone?
I'm standing on a ledge and your fine spiderweb
Is fastening my ankle to a stone.

I listened to “So Long, Marianne” dozens, possibly hundreds, of times after my husband experienced two catastrophic seizures and died, in the summer of 2022. The spiderweb—the object of my grief—became both a tether to and a protection from danger. The night of his death, I left the emergency room in the gauzy predawn hours, carrying our thirteen-month-old daughter. I was alone, stupefied with shock, mentally replaying a scene in Joan Didion’s “The Year of Magical Thinking” in which a hospital social worker gestures toward Didion and asks, “Is this the wife?” I had not been assigned a social worker. Maybe that meant my husband wasn’t dead. I felt hot and weightless, as if my feet weren’t making full contact with the ground. A nurse had offered my daughter a little package of crayons, but she was too young to use them, and now I was clutching them in one hand. I woke up my sister, who was living in New England. Her voice was tight but steady on the phone. I must have sounded insane. I let her assume the controls: Buckle the baby into the car seat. Is she safe? Are you sure? Get in. Put on your seat belt. Start the ignition. Are the headlights on? Can you drive? Are you sure? It felt as though I were a dazed passenger attempting to land a nose-diving airplane. I tried not to think about the clatter and thud of his body being slid into a refrigerated compartment. My parents lived fifteen minutes from the hospital; they were standing in the driveway when I pulled in. Had I phoned them? The horizon was a soft and murky pink. Did I open the car door and fall out? Did my mother get the baby? I don’t know. My husband and I met as teen-agers, and married in our late twenties. Later that morning, I called his family. I called his boss. I called our friends. Most of them answered the phone cheerfully.

My daughter and I stayed with my parents for a couple of months. When I went back home for the first time, to collect some toys and clothes, I cleaned streaks of my husband’s dried blood off the floorboards and threw up in the kitchen sink. Then I cleaned that up, too. I put his eyeglasses, still cloudy with fingerprints, into a drawer. It seemed impossible that he didn’t need them anymore. When I was presented with a rendering of my

husband's headstone, after pawing through a binder of unhinged-seeming designs (did he want an etching of the Buffalo Bills logo?), it felt like a gag gift, something that friends might have mocked up for his birthday. It suddenly seemed so easy to disappear. "*Media vita in morte sumus*," someone said at the funeral. In the midst of life we are in death.

My situation was, on some level, achingly ordinary. People die all the time. Or worse things happen. My father lost his father when he was a toddler. My mother lost her sister when she was a teen-ager. My husband lost both his parents. After a while, a sort of austere survival instinct kicked in for me. My existential panic was subsumed by more pragmatic concerns. When a death is quick, and the practical ramifications are both vast and immediate, any platitudes associated with "good" grieving feel like luxurious fantasies. There was no time for grace. I was astounded—fixated, on some level—by the irresolvable mathematics of my scenario. My household income had been halved, and my domestic responsibilities had doubled. I was now a single mother, with a slate of grisly and endlessly regenerating administrative chores, most of which concluded with the faxing of a death certificate to an institution, accompanied by a deranged note saying "Thanks!" I returned a car that we had bought a few days prior to his death, sitting in the exact same stiff, faux-leather chair at the dealership, trying to explain to the very smiley salesperson that my husband, whom he'd recently shaken hands with, was not alive anymore and I didn't need two cars. He was flummoxed, then horrified. My parents had to finish the paperwork. Between grief-induced insomnia and waking in the night to care for my baby daughter, I was feral with exhaustion. The tiniest decisions were paralyzing. Was the trash full enough to take out? Was her fever high enough to call the pediatrician? What was for dinner?

Grief mangles cognition and memory in ways that can make even banal tasks feel surreal, if not impossible. When a bank clerk asked me for my daughter's birth date—I was attempting to add her name to our savings account—it felt as though I'd been charged with solving a math equation. I did my best. I boxed up and donated my husband's jeans and sweaters. I took his toothbrush out of the holder and threw it in the garbage. I ordered a new sofa. I thought that if the room looked different I could begin to resolve some of the dissonance of sudden loss. I indulged in my share of magical

thinking. The question that hounded me the most that fall was: Where did he go? Perhaps that's why the word "lost" is so synonymous with death—it can feel as if your person is simply misplaced.

I went back to work. People marvelled at this, as though it were a choice, but I needed money, and I needed to engage some cooler, steadier portion of my brain. Unfortunately, I found music largely unlistenable—an inconvenient development for a professional pop critic. The emotional circuit that my favorite songs lit up inside me was too vivid; music felt overwhelming, if not revolting. There were a few things I could stand: Nick Cave and the Bad Seeds' "Ghosteen," P. J. Harvey's "Stories from the City, Stories from the Sea," Paul Simon's "Graceland," anything by Leonard Cohen. Some Nina Simone, some Miles Davis. Listening to most records felt shaky, ominous, like reintroducing food after a stomach bug. What could I receive without retching? Somewhat serendipitously, I was already in the midst of reporting [a Profile of Metallica](#), a band famously preoccupied by death. (Metallica's bassist Cliff Burton died in a ghastly bus accident in 1986, when he was twenty-four, an event that haunts even the current iteration of the group.) I now found the singer and guitarist James Hetfield's clenched-fist articulations of despair wildly comforting. Death was interesting to him. These songs both normalized pain and made it beautiful. Understanding that this was even possible—that grief could shape-shift into something less ugly, less weak—kept me going.

Appearing steady around my subjects was hard. (One afternoon, while watching the indie-rock band the National rehearse at its airy, sunlit studio space in Hudson, New York, I had a fairly sizable breakdown in the bathroom, stifling my sobs with a mitten.) But I was grateful for the sense of control I felt when writing. The real work of nonfiction, and of profile writing especially, is in making a series of arbitrary and disconnected events legible. The best profiles force a coherent arc from a string of mostly random occurrences: of course it all happened just like that. Writing was a corrective to my reality, which felt incoherent.

The rawness and terror of that first year was so visceral and embodied. "And grief still feels like fear," C. S. Lewis wrote, in 1961. His wife, Joy, had recently passed away, of cancer, at age forty-five. "Perhaps, more

strictly, like suspense. Or like waiting; just hanging about waiting for something to happen.” I was locked in a kind of defensive crouch. My daughter surely sensed the hum of my heartbreak, though I tried to be soft, even joyful, in her presence. I was toggling maniacally between otherworldly love for her and anguish that her father was dead and she would have no memory of him. During nap time, I’d tiptoe out to the driveway, sit in my parked car, place the baby monitor in my lap, and weep into the hood of my sweatshirt. Part of me wanted her to know that grief is a reasonable reaction to a devastating occurrence, but mostly I just wanted her to remain connected, in the way children are, to the ecstasy and wonder of existence, without any premature knowledge of its concomitant pain.

I got very good at sensing when the heft and finality of the loss was making someone uncomfortable. I found this both relatable (I surely wouldn’t have known what to say, either) and alienating. Grief can’t be “fixed”—death is famously irreversible—so conversations about it require both parties to abandon problem-solving and accept a kind of unpleasant stasis. When well-intentioned friends or colleagues asked me how I was doing, I felt dread. What I wanted to say was *This feels exactly as bad as you think it feels*. What I usually said was *Yeah, I’m O.K.*



“We did some digging on you, Tomato. Turns out you’re not even a real vegetable.”
Cartoon by Paul Noth

I was having a hard time connecting with anyone who hadn't locked eyes with a particular sort of darkness. I sought out people who felt complicated and fucked up—who were able to reckon in some way with the lunacy of human life. In 1986, a trio of social psychologists introduced an idea called terror-management theory, based on the cultural anthropologist Ernest Becker's claim that fear of death is "the mainspring of human activity." (Becker's book "The Denial of Death" won the Pulitzer Prize for general nonfiction in 1974.) T.M.T. posits that civilization itself is largely a response to mortality—an elaborate system of distraction and repudiation. Because humans have a sophisticated and symbolic awareness of death, we invest aggressively in shared cultural beliefs, which "[provide the universe with order, meaning, value, and the possibility of either literal or symbolic immortality.](#)" Simply sitting with the idea that death is compulsory and irreversible is too hard. Most of us will do almost anything to forget it.

Yet becoming a young widow was easily the most fascinating thing that has ever happened to me. In fact, it often felt like the only thing that had ever happened to me. In [a 2019 conversation](#) between Stephen Colbert and Anderson Cooper, Colbert spoke about the isolation of grief, even decades later: "Why is nobody asking me about this? My brothers died forty-five years ago, and sometimes I'll go, 'How come nobody is asking me about Paul?' " I knew what he meant. Talking about anything else felt nuts. It was hard not to think of "moving on" as a kind of annulment, a final act of severance. In this context, the whole idea of recovery seemed vaguely dehumanizing—too results-oriented, too transactional, too American. Who was I to believe that I could vanquish the ache of death?

I liked speaking with people who could acknowledge the enigma at the core of existence without feeling embarrassed. One afternoon, the Episcopal minister who'd performed my husband's funeral service said to me, only half jokingly, "I guess he has all the answers now." I found the idea that he'd suddenly been made privy to cosmic information both funny and comforting. Rare air; good for him. In 2023, Paul Simon released a thirty-three-minute album of acoustic hymns titled "[Seven Psalms.](#)" Simon spends most of the record musing about a higher power and what happens, or doesn't happen, when we die. On "[The Sacred Harp,](#)" a gentle and

circuitous song, he sings, “The Lord is my personal joke / My reflection in the window.” I repeated the phrase like a mantra.

Encountering new motherhood and acute loss in quick succession was harrowing, though I eventually came to see them as deeply consonant experiences. Both required enormous amounts of selflessness, stamina, plasticity, courage, and improvisation. I reminded myself to take it day by day, or, sometimes, minute by minute. I sent a lot of weird texts to friends. I posted very personal things on Instagram. I fumbled a few relationships. I wanted to be around people all the time, but I also couldn’t bear anyone needing anything from me, including my polite participation in a social interaction. At Christmas, my daughter and I caught the flu. We stayed home by ourselves. I had a panic attack at the pediatrician’s office, triggered by the sound of a blood-pressure machine in another room, or the starchy crinkle of parchment paper on the exam table, or maybe just the ambient smell of rubbing alcohol—it was all too close. I yanked off my mask and tried to suck in just enough air not to pass out. The situation was so grim that it was almost funny; I was so sick I couldn’t stand. On Christmas Eve, I had to crawl up the stairs, one arm dragging my body, the other cradling my baby, who was ruddy with fever. At that moment, I could not imagine ever feeling good again.

In 1999, *The New Yorker* ran a cartoon of two beleaguered cowboys looking out over a cliff with the caption “Hard to tell from here. Could be buzzards. Could be grief counsellors.” It’s difficult to say when grief tips from normal to pathological. It’s even more difficult to say when it might require intervention. “I don’t think that any grief is pathological, actually,” Katherine Shear, the founder and director of the Center for Prolonged Grief, at Columbia University’s School of Social Work, told me recently. “It’s a little bit analogous to pregnancy, in the sense that it’s a normal state, but it’s a high-risk state.” She continued, “The problem people have is not in the experience of grief itself. The problem is how to learn to accept the unthinkable.”

The Center for Prolonged Grief, which was founded in 2013, is an academic institution focussed on education and research. (It is not a brick-and-mortar clinic open to the public, though in the months immediately

following my husband's death I often yearned for a place like that: something in between an urgent-care center and an A.A. meeting, where the mental and physical symptoms of bereavement are recognized, and the ebb and flow of sorrow doesn't require explanation or apology.) The center's work is largely supported by outside grants, though it also generates income through its [clinical-training programs and workshops](#). Shear first studied internal medicine but then decided that she wanted to be a psychiatrist. She completed her residency at Cornell in the late nineteen-seventies, when, she said, grief was not very well understood by clinicians. "A group of colleagues who were doing depression research had started seeing people who were bereaved and thought they were depressed," Shear said of her time as a professor at the University of Pittsburgh, in the early nineties. "The depression treatment wasn't working, basically. Those colleagues, like almost all mental-health professionals, including myself, knew almost nothing about grief. Everybody knew that loss is important, but grief wasn't in the curriculum." In 2005, Shear published a paper in the *Journal of the American Medical Association* that demonstrated the efficacy of a treatment plan for "traumatic grief."

In March, 2022, a revision of the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* included something called prolonged-grief disorder, which for adults is defined as debilitating, life-altering grief that is still ongoing a year after loss. Shear led a committee that lobbied for its addition. (The World Health Organization's *ICD-11*, a global analogue to the *DSM*, gives a timeline of six months for the same condition.) According to some estimates, P.G.D. could affect about seven to ten per cent of all bereaved people. The diagnostic criteria include "intense yearning/longing for the deceased person" and "preoccupation with thoughts or memories of the deceased person." A P.G.D. diagnosis hinges chiefly on time; clinically, at least, the difference between functional and nonfunctional grief is duration.

The inclusion in the *DSM* was controversial for obvious reasons—grief is not a mental disorder. The decision was preceded by several decades of fervent debate and disagreement among practitioners; detractors argued that adding the disorder was reckless, if not mercenary. A formal diagnosis means that a patient can be categorized, and that doctors can be more easily

reimbursed by insurance companies for treatment. In an editorial published in *The Lancet Psychiatry* in 2022, the psychologists and researchers Joanne Cacciatore and Allen Frances described the decision as “a huge mistake that solves no existing problem and creates many new ones,” including the careless prescription of antidepressants or other drugs, without consideration of the immediate cause of a patient’s distress. They added, “Pathologising grief is an insult to the dignity of loving relationships—it proclaims griever as mentally ill.” They concluded, “Grief warrants strong social support and compassionate connection, not medicalisation.”

In the book “The Other Side of Sadness,” the psychologist George Bonanno points out that the most common response among bereaved people is resilience. Grief “is something we are wired for, and it is certainly not meant to overwhelm us,” he writes. When I met with Bonanno in New York, in February—he is a professor of clinical psychology at Columbia, though he is not affiliated with the Center for Prolonged Grief—he told me, “We evolved these emotions because they’re functional. They do something very efficient from an evolutionary perspective.” He continued, “If they go on for a long time, then they become problematic. Stress is adaptive, but after about a month it goes into the realm of being maladaptive.” In our conversation, Bonanno was careful to distinguish grief from clinical depression. “Depression is objectless, and grief has an object,” he said.

Ultimately, the *DSM* is a diagnostic tool; it doesn’t include guidelines for treatment. Though I understood the misgivings about the medicalization of grief, I also found the naming and codifying of it sort of validating—it acknowledged that the situation had gravity. Seeking out “social support and compassionate connection” is generally excellent advice, but those things aren’t always so easy to come by. Spending time with a grieving person is exhausting. It requires enormous amounts of patience and generosity. After a while, people get tired of your bottomless melancholy.

The Center for Prolonged Grief used to be known as the Center for Complicated Grief. (The name was changed to align with the diagnosis in the *DSM*.) I told Shear that I liked the earlier name better—it felt gentler, less contingent on a schedule of recovery. “I agree,” she said. “I now think it really should be called post-loss stress disorder or post-traumatic-loss

disorder.” She went on, “When I started this work, grief was defined as deep sorrow. That’s how people think of it, even today. My latest thought is that it’s a trans-diagnostic psychological state, because grief contains many emotions, not just one. You experience sadness, anxiety, anger, guilt, the whole range. Even positive emotions come up—they’re a part of grief. It’s a complex state of being.” She also felt that the diagnostic criteria could be more flexible. “Our therapists see people as early as two or three months sometimes. If you are really, really struggling, even for two months, that’s a long time to feel underwater,” she said, then paused. “I guess I don’t have to tell you. You know what it feels like. It’s very reasonable to want a little help.”

The center has its own recovery program, a six-part plan supported by studies from the National Institute of Mental Health. It contains elements of exposure therapy (the gradual, repeated introduction of a triggering thought or object, ideally leading to habituation), as well as a variety of established psychotherapeutic methods that encourage patients to recount and reframe their trauma. It was the first treatment for the condition to be found efficacious in a randomized controlled trial, and, in 2024, Shear received the Award for Research in Psychiatry from the American Psychiatric Association.

Now there are numerous emerging treatments for P.G.D. One involves the use of naltrexone, a drug previously approved to manage alcohol and opioid addiction. Some [studies](#) indicate a connection between symptoms of P.G.D. and the reward pathways responsible for addiction, suggesting that, in some way, grief requires a kind of detox. Transcranial magnetic stimulation, which uses magnetic fields to stimulate nerve cells in the brain, has also been trialled for efficacy. (T.M.S., as both an isolated and a repeated treatment, is currently approved by the Food and Drug Administration as a therapy for major depression, obsessive-compulsive disorder, smoking addiction, and migraines.) One of the more compelling developments for P.G.D. involves the monitored use of various psychedelic drugs, usually administered in conjunction with traditional therapy. Psilocybin, in particular, appears to be highly effective for helping people with terminal illnesses feel less terrified of dying. A [Johns Hopkins study](#) of fifty-one patients with cancer who had exhibited “clinically significant” signs of

anxiety or depression found that a monitored dose of psilocybin resulted in “increases in ratings of death acceptance.” I was too timid to take psychedelics, though the thought of increasing my death acceptance was appealing. What is grief, after all, if not a reaction to the overwhelming perpetuity of mortality? Certain drugs seem to make the membrane between Here and There feel more permeable—maybe, by that logic, the person you lost might begin to feel a little less unreachable. A little less gone.

My husband had been dead for six weeks when I asked my primary-care doctor about a form of psychotherapy called E.M.D.R. I’d read that it was useful for coping with trauma and post-traumatic stress disorder. She was encouraging, though she also reminded me that I wasn’t post-anything yet. I was grieving—active verb. A month earlier, I’d reached out to the photographer Tabitha Soren; in 2021, she and her husband, the writer Michael Lewis, lost their nineteen-year-old daughter, Dixie, who was a passenger in a car that crashed in Northern California. Soren suggested that it might be helpful to think about my grief as a brain injury—to be awake, at least, to the ways in which it might manifest physically. There was a reason that the phrase “grief-stricken” had entered the lexicon. The experience was not entirely dissimilar to getting whacked in the skull.

When I asked Shear about the biological aftermath of grief, she brought up two-person neuroscience, an emerging discipline that studies how our brains affect other brains. “Our closest relationships, especially when we’re living together—in particular, when we’re living together—have an impact on our immune system, our cardiovascular system, our sleep, our eating, probably the whole body,” she said. “I think we have to understand what happens, neurologically, when we’re with someone to really understand what happens when we lose them.” (In the three months immediately following the death of a spouse, particularly in older couples, the surviving partner’s risk of death can increase by as much as an extraordinary sixty-six per cent, a phenomenon known colloquially as the widowhood effect.)

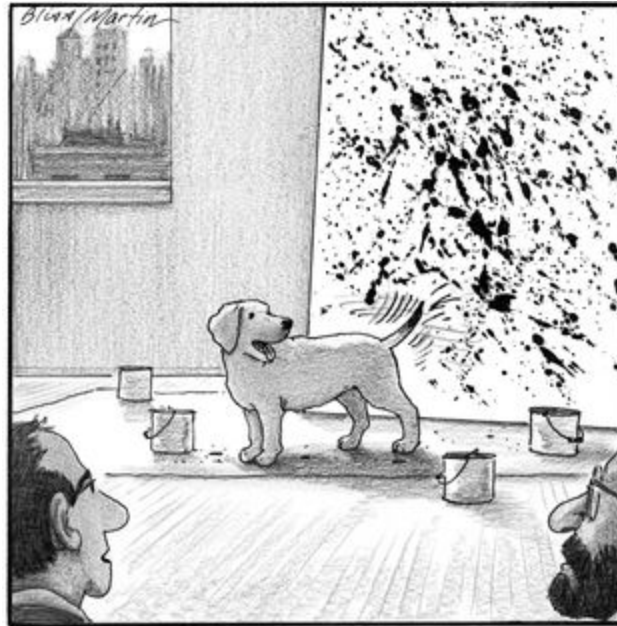
E.M.D.R., an acronym for eye-movement desensitization and reprocessing, combines elements of talk therapy, exposure therapy, and bilateral stimulation, or alternating activation of the right and left hemispheres of the brain. This is most often achieved via guided eye movements, though it can

also occur through a number of benign physical sensations: a patient might tap her own shoulders, or hold a buzzer in each palm, or listen to a series of alternating tones on headphones. In the past decade, E.M.D.R. has moved from the fringes to the mainstream, both within the culture and among clinicians. In 2021, Prince Harry, who suffers from anxiety, underwent E.M.D.R. on camera for an episode of the Oprah Winfrey-produced docuseries “The Me You Can’t See”; in 2025, Miley Cyrus told the [Times](#) that the treatment had saved her life by helping her to process unresolved childhood trauma.

I was already seeing a therapist, who’d helped me navigate a series of routine yet formidable transitions: moving out of the city, changing jobs, becoming a parent. I found our sessions useful and edifying, but she didn’t practice E.M.D.R. (Practitioners are not legally mandated to be certified beyond their country’s basic therapy-license requirement, though the E.M.D.R. International Association requires at least forty hours of training, and ten hours of direct consultation, before offering its approval.) I eventually Googled my way to a local therapist who was certified in E.M.D.R. In my introductory e-mail, I described myself as “hopeless.”

He was intelligent and compassionate. Sessions were held in a little wood cabin on his property. Sometimes a small dog nosed in the door and curled up by the space heater. I was still in the roughest and least comprehensible stage of my grief. Most of the time, driving to his office felt like an insurmountable task, but I went anyway—twice a week at first. I held a little buzzing paddle in each palm. I narrated my memories of the event. There are eight formal stages to E.M.D.R., which typically unfold over eight to twelve weeks, though it’s the fourth and the fifth stages, desensitization and installation, that feel the strangest and most crucial. In desensitization, patients repeatedly recount a traumatic event while receiving bilateral stimulation (squeezing the buzzing paddles, in my case), ideally until they are close to unperturbed by the memory. Discomfort is measured via something called the Subjective Units of Distress Scale, or *SUDS*. In installation, the bilateral stimulation continues, and a positive belief is added to the narration—usually some version of “But I survived.” I cried a lot during both parts. I’m not sure how to describe the experience beyond some vague sense that my pain was coalescing. For me, it happened

quickly, after three or four sessions. Grief started to seem less predatory—it was no longer lurking around a dark corner, eager to pounce. It was here. I could see its contours. That felt good.



*“His lithographs lack this spontaneity.”
Cartoon by Harry Bliss and Steve Martin*

The therapy was first formalized in the late eighties, when a psychologist named Francine Shapiro took a walk and found that the anguish she associated with traumatic memories was alleviated when she was also experiencing rapid and simultaneous eye movement. According to Shapiro, E.M.D.R. is designed to target specific “unprocessed” or “pathogenic” memories—which contain negative emotions, sensations, or beliefs—allowing them to be integrated and therefore defanged. In “EMDR: The Breakthrough Therapy for Overcoming Anxiety, Stress, and Trauma,” first published in 1997, Shapiro suggests that E.M.D.R. works “on a physiological level.” Sometimes, she writes, “the system becomes ‘stuck’—as if it was choking on trauma—and often requires assistance in order to get moving smoothly again.”

Shapiro, who was born in Brooklyn in 1948, received a Ph.D. in clinical psychology from the Professional School of Psychological Studies, in San Diego. She had previously been enrolled in a Ph.D. program in English literature at New York University, and in the late seventies, while she was

still living in New York, she was diagnosed with breast cancer. In 1985, Shapiro told the [Los Angeles Times](#) that she believed cancer was “a stress-related disease,” which led her to start researching alternative life styles. She eventually discovered neurolinguistic programming, a behavioral theory positing that people experience the world via a combination of three distinct perceptual systems (visual, auditory, and kinesthetic), with one becoming dominant. Being able to recognize which system a person is primarily engaging in can help strengthen relationships and communication, or, perhaps more nefariously, be used to influence decision-making. (The founders of N.L.P., Richard Bandler and John Grinder, eventually began marketing it as a business tool, selling courses in California.) N.L.P. isn’t directly associated with E.M.D.R., though Shapiro’s interest in what most consider a tawdry New Age scam—the L.A. *Times* once compared N.L.P. to Scientology—has been fuel for skeptics.

E.M.D.R. touts itself as evidence-based, and the treatment is recognized as effective for trauma by the American Psychiatric Association, the W.H.O., and the Department of Veterans Affairs. But our understanding of why it might work is limited. It’s possible that E.M.D.R. mimics aspects of *REM* sleep, a phase also marked by eye movement, and associated with the processing of memory. Another hypothesis, usually referred to as the working-memory theory, focusses on the way that bilateral stimulation encourages something called dual taxation, or, basically, what happens in the brain when we try to remember something while doing something else. [A 2022 study](#) asked patients with P.T.S.D. to draw a figure, solve a math problem, or play Tetris while simultaneously recalling a trauma. The study suggested that “the secondary task distracts attention away from the retrieval of memory” and has “a detrimental effect on storage.” Because the memory was now imperfectly stored, it would also be imperfectly retrieved. “The partial retrieval of these memory traces would blur their content, resulting in the reduction of vividness or the level of emotion,” the study concluded.

In a [2007 paper](#), Bessel van der Kolk, the author of “The Body Keeps the Score,” which has spent almost six years on the *Times* best-seller list, conducted a study in which eighty-eight P.T.S.D. patients received either eight weeks of E.M.D.R., a course of fluoxetine (the generic form of

Prozac), or a placebo pill; seventy-five per cent of the patients in the E.M.D.R. group who had experienced adult-onset P.T.S.D. “achieved asymptomatic end-state functioning compared with none in the fluoxetine group.” In 2012, a team of Italian researchers, led by Marco Pagani, used electroencephalogram imaging to “fully monitor neuronal activation throughout EMDR sessions,” and found that “traumatic events are processed at cognitive level following successful EMDR therapy, thus supporting the evidence of distinct neurobiological patterns of brain activations during bilateral stimulation associated with a significant relief from negative emotional experiences.” Which is to say, E.M.D.R. can help the brain to process trauma in a more adaptive way, thereby lessening its capacity to completely capsize a person.

Roger Solomon, who has been practicing psychology since 1979, learned E.M.D.R. directly from Francine Shapiro, in 1990. “I think it was the second class she taught in the United States,” he recalled. Today, he teaches E.M.D.R. workshops and seminars around the world. Solomon has found the treatment transformative in its ability to shift the way we remember trauma. “With your husband dying under those circumstances, those are risk factors—the unexpectedness, the violence of it,” he told me. “You have the loss, but it’s a traumatic loss. Hopefully, what E.M.D.R. does is to reduce the trauma so that you can go through the mourning process, which is still continuing.” He went on, “It will always continue. It doesn’t stop. It evolves. We talk about trauma recovery. We do not talk about grief recovery. Grief is an adaptation process.”

Therapeutic modalities are famously complicated to substantiate, and there are plenty of clinicians who think that E.M.D.R. is mostly theatre—exposure therapy bolstered by dual taxation and repackaged as something else entirely. “For trauma, the best treatment, statistically, is exposure therapy,” Bonanno told me. “It’s also the most painful and difficult for both therapist and patient. It involves reliving every moment in a traumatic event, verbally describing it to the therapist, audiotaping it, and then listening to the audiotape repeatedly.” He added, “Understanding what you went through works a lot better if you tell the story. People can’t get over a loss, convince themselves of this distorted view of what happened, that it’s somehow their fault, they did something wrong, they could’ve done more.

Then, when they play the whole event through, it's, like, Oh, it's not my fault."

Gerald M. Rosen, a retired clinical psychologist and professor at the University of Washington, and the author of the 2023 paper ["Revisiting the Origins of EMDR,"](#) expressed distaste for the way the therapy has been sold. "My central concern about E.M.D.R. is that it's what we call a 'Purple Hat Therapy,' " he wrote to me. "Let's take a driving phobia that develops after a car accident. We know that imagining the event while relaxing and finding new ways to think about current threats versus recalled fears helps 99% of driving phobics. Now, we have a person practice all that while they wear a purple hat. When the person gets better, we attribute the benefits to the Purple Hat even though it didn't do anything. We also charge an extra \$250 for the hat. E.M.D.R. uses exposure plus a distracting and novel task like eye movements. We notice that the distraction helps the person stay with the imagery, so it increases exposure. See what's happening? E.M.D.R. is a falsely packaged and trademarked therapy that isn't helping individuals think clearly about the meaning of their loss and the ways to find restorative meaning in what remains."

I wasn't sure whether the path out of grief was, as Rosen said, to "find restorative meaning" in my new life or to stop thinking so one-dimensionally about meaning itself. Mostly, it reminded me of the Fiona Apple song "Paper Bag," in which she sings, "He said, It's all in your head / And I said, So's everything."

Grief forces a kind of radical transformation, for better or for worse. I found it to be a shockingly generative state: I'd never been more pliable, tender, open, or raw. Miracles, catastrophe—it all felt so *possible* in those early months. In that way, grief itself is a psychedelic journey. Shortly before the one-year mark, when I theoretically would have been qualified to seek out a P.G.D. diagnosis, the shape of my grief changed again. It began to feel less like a slowly unfolding apocalypse and more like I'd been handed an invisible shield—as if my intimacy with pain had led to a kind of immunity from it. Some days were still hard, but most days were O.K.; eventually, the hard days were aberrations. Music was listenable again, even the really sad songs, though a few still got me. (The first time I heard [Zach Bryan sing](#)

“Your funeral was beautiful / I bet God heard you comin’,” I had to pull my car off the road.) I developed a new and funny admiration for the ways in which music distilled and centered emotion. I liked that songs, for the most part, took living seriously. I did, too. I found a rhythm to life as a solo parent. I got better at asking for and receiving help. I was more forgiving. The future felt sort of interesting again. Then, incredibly, the future felt almost exciting. What a bold and miraculous thing—to be alive at all.

I was still meeting regularly with my original therapist. Our sessions became less about triage and more about integration. I told and retold the story; she repeated it back to me when I needed to hear it. Eventually, I learned to cultivate an odd kind of gratitude for my grief, and for the very modest miracle of my own survival. It’s possible that E.M.D.R., or some aspect of it, helped me claw my way back from what had seemed, at the time, like the end of my life. Ultimately, I didn’t really care about the therapy’s scientific bona fides. All I had wanted was to stop feeling as though the world was unsafe and everyone I loved was about to die. Besides, what did science really know about death, or what happens afterward?

The primary thing I recall from E.M.D.R. is unrelated to the therapy itself. Often, at the beginning or the end of our session, my therapist would remind me, firmly and repeatedly, to grieve—to suffer. I can’t remember how he phrased it; possibly, it was as simple as him saying, “Let’s make sure you’re really grieving.” It felt bizarre, even sort of grating: all I was doing was grieving! Yet, in retrospect, I understand it as a remarkable kindness. Humans are instinctively averse to pain, conditioned instead to solve and strengthen and maximize, to inure ourselves to hurt. The idea of willingly spending some indeterminate amount of time feeling bad is unthinkable. But that was how I understood his counsel: feel bad. A bad thing happened, and it is reasonable to feel bad. Thrashing against it was both exhausting and fruitless. The experience reminded me of the woven bamboo finger traps I played with as a kid—the harder you tried to free your hands, the tighter and more frightening the whole thing got. To feel better, I had to find a way to value and nurture my grief. To understand it as some invisible but essential system inside me. ♦

[Amanda Petrusich](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker* and the author of “[Do Not Sell at Any Price: The Wild, Obsessive Hunt for the World’s Rarest 78rpm Records](#).”

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The Repo Man Coming for Your Ride

As America's auto debt nears \$1.7 trillion, repossessions are reaching levels not seen since the Great Recession. Inside an industry at the front line of the country's affordability crisis.

By [Paige Williams](#)

June 22, 2026



Matthew Pitman became a repo man in his early twenties and called himself the Ninja. He liked finding cars that drivers didn't want found. Photographs by Mark Peterson / Redux for The New Yorker

Matthew Pitman started in the automobile-repossession industry as a teenager, coiling cables at a tow lot in his home town, Phoenix. This was the eighties. His boss went by Joker and wore a “badge” around his neck, like a cop. Law-enforcement officers are sworn to serve the public; repossessioners work for banks. Pitman justifies conflating the two by saying that a lot of repo guys are “ex-law enforcement, ex-military,” which is true, and that all repossessioners “have to have complete balls of brass.” He became a repo man in his early twenties and called himself the Ninja. The license plate on his first work truck read “GOTCHA.”

Pitman moved to Orem, Utah, to repo there and across the state. He had been in the business for well over a decade when, in the fall of 2006, the Spanish-language scripted series “Operación Repo” became the No. 1 program on Telemundo. A reviewer described the show as “a telenovela on Red Bull” and “Judge Judy with a choke hold”; it depicted a family repo business in the San Fernando Valley whose employees brawled with debtors, and with one another. An English-language version, “Operation Repo,” debuted a couple of years later, teeing up a glut of derivative content. Pitman decided that he could do better than what the popular culture had to offer. He already filmed his repos, for liability purposes, a defensive protocol that was becoming industry standard. In January, 2008, he started a YouTube channel. He applied for a new vanity license plate that read “*REPO N UT*,” for “Repo in Utah.” The plate came back in error, sans spaces—“*REPONUT*.” Pitman kept both the plate and the nickname, reluctantly. “I hated the ‘nut,’ because I’m not nuts,” he told me. “I’m a very grounded, not-crazy person.”

Pitman is six feet tall, with hazel eyes and blond hair, which he keeps buzzed on the sides and floppy on top, or slicked into a stubby pony. He wears wraparound sunglasses with a bandanna or a backward baseball cap, or both. His land speed is a consistent half sprint. He speaks in complete, fluid sentences but, at times, jackhammer fast. No topic escapes his enthusiasm (“I *love* festivals!”) or his powers of observation (the “little lobster-claw hands” of the Starbucks mermaid, the absence of residential surveillance cameras). His autodidactic impulses may lead him to the history of clock towers or to the interplanetary rarity of wood. Absolute is his opinion on the superiority of Dobermans (“Dobies”), which, he believes, don’t shed as much as other breeds. “Dog hair? Forget it,” he said the other day. “If I got a car bad enough, I’ll put a garbage bag over the seat before I’ll sit in it, it’s so gross. After a day of working, you go home, and you literally have a separate hamper for your work clothes. We get grease, we get solvents, we get grime.” Repo, he declared, “is not *quite* as manly as underwater welding, but it’s a pretty manly job.”

Pitman called his YouTube channel RepoNut. GoPro was his camera of choice. He would clamp one to the windshield trim of his rig, point it at himself, and just talk. Each “*INSTANT SEIZURE ORDER*,” issued by a

lender, gave him cause to monologue about the endless variables of his trade. Repoing a BMW X series (all-wheel drive) is different from repoing a Honda Civic (front-wheel drive). A good repo agent adjusts for terrain, weather, angle, blockage, flat tires, dead batteries, locked doors, and human interference. Repo agents have been shot, stabbed, hit by cars. They've been beaten with tire irons, bottles, planks, chains. During the *COVID-19* pandemic, some states temporarily banned repos; when orders resumed, there was a spike in violence against repossessioners. In 2023, at least seven were killed—the highest number on record. This spring, the North American Repossessors Summit (*NARS*), a convention put on by the industry's leading trade group, the American Recovery Association (*A.R.A.*), opened with a harrowing video montage of wounded, terrified repo agents steering out of the line of fire, shrieking, "Oh, my God!" and "Motherfucker!" and "I'm shot, I'm shot, I'm shot, I'm shot, I'm shot! I need help!" One driver, visibly shaking after having narrowly avoided a bullet, screamed, "I can't *do* this shit no more!" People in the audience were crying. The lights came up, and *NARS* awarded medals to two drivers who had sustained gunshot wounds, one in the head. Their peers gave them a standing ovation.

Pitman operated on a core belief that "when people like you, they won't harm you." He disarmed debtors with friendly banter. "Beautiful Jeep!" he'd say. "Did you build that out yourself?" On RepoNut, he once explained, "By the time a repo man shows up at someone's house to take their vehicle, they're oftentimes in bankruptcy, divorce, fighting with their spouse constantly. Financial ruin sometimes, even. Their *life's* falling apart." He recorded and posted anyway.

RepoNut started during the Great Recession. Nearly nine million jobs were lost between December of 2007 and early 2010. Forced to make tough spending choices, many Americans prioritized their car payment over the mortgage, weighing the urgent need for personal transportation—work and groceries, church and medical appointments—against the relatively slow-moving process of home foreclosure. Even so, at the recession's peak, in 2009, 1.8 million cars were repossessed, according to Cox Automotive, an unprecedented number. Pitman's was the face that thousands of consumers saw, or didn't, when the financial system came for them.

Repossessors and tow-truck drivers work different jobs but use the same equipment. The tow truck was patented in 1918 by Ernest Holmes, Sr., the owner of an auto-repair shop in Chattanooga, Tennessee, who pulled vehicles out of ditches using a modified Cadillac and chains. Today's tow trucks, also known as wreckers, are computerized work stations with integrated digital dashboards, camera systems, blind-spot monitoring, and hydraulic rotators. Pitman eventually switched from a wrecker to a "sneaker" unit, a heavy-duty Ford F-series pickup equipped with a steel boom, shaped like a cross, that can be maneuvered with joysticks from inside the cab. He could extend the boom, like a stinger, to "hook" and lift a vehicle's front or back wheels within seconds.

The tactical aspects of repo interested him more than the mechanical. Pitman liked finding cars that drivers didn't want found. He got his taste for "investigating" in childhood, after smelling Burger King on his parents' clothes and watching them lie about where they'd been. Their deception "didn't *hurt* me," he said. "I just found it interesting." He began to figure out, ahead of time, what everyone was getting for Christmas, and followed his older brother when he sneaked out at night, learning that there was power in discovering information, and in withholding it.

When Pitman started in repo, orders arrived by fax; agents used foldout maps. He got ahead by working dead paper. Fresh eyes on an unfulfilled assignment generated leads that lesser repo guys never saw. A target vehicle that went missing from the address listed on a loan account might be parked down the block, or in a friend's driveway or a cousin's garage, or in a storage unit, a church parking lot, a barn. Pitman once tracked a vehicle to a shipping container headed for Hawaii. A debtor's grandparents' house was often a good place to look: older people don't move around that much. Pitman observed that you could tell a lot about a family by how close together everybody lived—data, potentially, for later. Hard-core hidere are called skips, as in skipped town. A skip could maintain spotless op sec and still be undone by an associate's social-media incontinence; Pitman once noticed a license plate in the background of a photo on the Facebook feed of a target's relative, traced the plate to an unchecked address, and drove by the house. There sat his repo.



“As the kid gets bigger, the bag gets smaller.”

Cartoon by Amy Hwang

Once a vehicle is hooked, a reposessor may still need the key—sometimes the emergency brake is on or the car needs to be put in neutral, and an inventory of the car’s contents must be taken, too. Having the key is easier and cheaper than cutting a new one. Asking for it required Pitman to “make contact” with the debtor, which usually started with knocking on a door. If a debtor refused to coöperate, Pitman might ingratiate himself, explaining, truthfully, that having the key sure would help him out, or that, without it, the lienholder would bundle the cost of making a new one into the price of getting the vehicle out of hock. Most people were reasonable. Most repos go smoothly. If the vibe soured, Pitman explained that his job was simply to transport collateral for the lender. One of his rigs had a large decal on the back window: “Why are you pissed at ME? I didn’t miss *YOUR* payment.”

Outside the truck, Pitman wore the GoPro on his forehead, making it clear that he was recording. It is unlikely that the people losing their cars knew that their interactions with him would live forever on the internet, with some of their private information exposed and the repo man getting the final word. In one video, a debtor, wearing a “Ridin’ on Faith” T-shirt, stands in her driveway and denies the true whereabouts of a Land Rover that Pitman knew perfectly well was sitting out back. Pitman floated in text: “Lie #1 . . .” When that same debtor then says, “You’ve been in my back yard why?,” Pitman replies, “When you signed the contract for the title

loan, you gave them the right, if the loan goes into default, for us to come out and pick up the vehicle.” That frame read “Did that answer you snootie question?”

Less well-off people handle repossession better than “rich people,” Pitman told me, because they “know what to expect.” The “nightmare” is the guy who’s “got a Hummer, and his business is tanking, and he’s got a boat, a motor home, Jet Skis, four-wheelers. Those people don’t react well. They’re very entitled. They’re very ‘How dare you?’ and ‘I’m calling my lawyer,’ ‘My brother’s a cop.’ You don’t get any of that from people that are living in a single-wide trailer.” In a video titled “Dealing With People Who Think The Rest Of Us Owe Them Something,” a youngish mom wearing fur-lined boots and a leather motorcycle jacket emerges from a large home, stands at the bumper of her repossessed Jeep Wrangler, and, fists balled in frustration, cries, “Oh!” and “This is what happens when I leave the payments up to my frickin’ husband!” The husband later confronts Pitman in a parking lot. Pitman calls the police. He tends to be obsequious with law-enforcement officers, as if to advance his notion of professional alignment. The responding officer tells him, “You’re *both* guilty of disorderly conduct.”

RepoNut titles became nesting narratives: “Fireman Returns From Call To Find Repoman In Action,” “Almost Lost This One To A Closed Garage,” “It’s Pouring Repos In This Never Ending Recession,” “Another Fun Day Dealing With Upset People,” “You Never Know What You’ll Find Or Where You’ll Find It,” “Load And Go At The Local Horse Park.” A sharky tension hangs over the second most popular installment, wherein Pitman hustles to tow a faded 2001 G.M.C. Yukon from a parking lot before security sees him. As he clears the property boundary, he sighs like a fighter pilot crossing into international airspace. The video was viewed more than 3.2 million times. Pitman suspected that gearhead teen-age boys were a big part of the RepoNut audience. Other repossessioners definitely watched, too, to see how Pitman handled the assignments—and himself.

One night, Pitman had a repo order for a certain BMW, which he spotted at a Chevron station. A young guy was about to get behind the wheel. Pitman, who works alone yet often speaks in the first-person plural, rolled up and

informed him, “We have an order of repossession for this vehicle. You guys want to clean some stuff out of it before we take it?”

The kid wanted to drive the BMW home. Pitman clamped a G.P.S. tracking device to its undercarriage and followed him. At an apartment complex, a distraught woman came to Pitman’s window with a phone and tried to get him to speak with a man on the other end of the line. She said, “He has the money for me to pay two payments!” The repo man’s job is not to accept the handoff of a phone, or to engage explanations. Joker used to say to debtors, “Tell your story on the bus.” Pitman told the woman that there was nothing he could do. “We don’t deal with the money,” he said. “You need to call your bank.”

“Yeah, but can you give me till tomorrow morning? I swear to God, I can’t get to work, and I promise you’ll have it!”

“I can’t give you till tomorrow morning,” Pitman said. “We’re gonna pick the vehicle up right now. You need to understand that.”

“Please. Please! I am a single mom. I’m doing everything I can. Please! I’ll be there first thing in the morning!”

“Ma’am,” Pitman said. “You’ll be able to get your vehicle back, but we are picking it up tonight, O.K.?”

“Please? For God’s sake!”

“Ma’am. You need to get to the point where you understand that we’re picking the vehicle up tonight, O.K.?”

The woman wailed, “What do I do?”

Before long, she was apologizing to Pitman and saying, “I have never had this happen.”

“I see a lot of people trip out,” he told her. She handed over her key. Afterward, Pitman told RepoNut followers, “Through very trained and

controlled verbal skills, we were able to calm her down and deal with the situation. That's how we want all our repos to go."

RepoNut amassed nearly two hundred thousand subscribers. Pitman allowed advertising and ultimately banked a quarter of a million dollars, supplementing his repo income. Lenders pay recovery agents, on average, three hundred and fifty dollars per completed repossession. That rate hasn't changed much in decades, a fact that repossessioners constantly point out. "The cost of doing this business has skyrocketed, but the price that's paid has been stagnant," Vaughn Clemmons, a former president of the A.R.A., told me at the *NARS* conference, in Orlando. "I got a hundred-and-twenty-thousand-dollar tow truck. I have a forty-thousand-dollar camera system and drivers that are sent out to Nashville or Memphis to get hands-on training. Forget the gas—it's the *other* variables that really hurt, when you can't draw a line and say, 'How am I making this money back?' "

One increasingly dominant player in the field is the forwarder, a middleman between lenders and repo agents. If a lender in Maryland needs a car repossessed in Seattle and doesn't know any agents there, a forwarder with a national repo database may manage the job, from assignment to resolution. (At *NARS*, repo agents would have had a chance to express their opinion of this arrangement at a charity Dunk-a-Forwarder booth, but the dunking was cancelled, because of rain.) Forwarders can increase competition among repossessioners and squeeze their margins, forcing them to rely on volume to stay in business. A saying in the trade is "No metal, no money."

The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau was just starting to look into forwarders when President Donald Trump, during his second term, began to dismantle the agency. (The C.F.P.B. has reported that borrowers pay more in repo charges when a forwarder is involved.) The A.R.A., meanwhile, has been arguing for a fee structure that takes the pressure off hooking at all costs. Payment only upon completion can lead to haste, which can generate confusion and mistakes. In some cases, a repo driver has taken a vehicle without realizing that a child was inside. At least one was an infant, asleep in the back seat.

Americans currently owe a staggering \$1.7 trillion in automobile debt—only two in ten new cars, and four in ten used cars, are purchased outright. Last year, repossessions reached levels not seen since the Great Recession. The repos were concentrated among lower-income borrowers, who, on average, pay higher interest rates. Insurance, car parts, maintenance, parking, housing, food—the cost of daily life has been rising. Because of Trump’s war with Iran, the price of fuel recently spiked to nearly five dollars a gallon (and more, for diesel). Wages aren’t keeping up.

In January, I had to sell my own car, because it was too expensive and illogical to keep in Manhattan. I cried as I drove to a CarMax on Long Island, feeling as distraught as I’d been on another morning, many years ago, in another city, when I took an acutely ill pet to the veterinarian to be euthanized. I am aware that comparing the two is ridiculous. CarMax gives you a free Lyft home after the sale. That poor driver had to listen to me snuffle in shameful despair all the way back to the city. A wealthy friend in another part of the country cheerily insisted that I wasn’t stranded—I could always travel by bus! It took me days to realize why this well-intended suggestion was so devastating. Owning a car is not just a logistical issue; it is an identity issue. I have been an obsessively self-sufficient, licensed driver since age fifteen, no matter where in the world I’ve lived. Giving that up felt like a sort of death. Imagine the anxiety, then, for the overwhelming number of Americans who rely on a private vehicle to get to work. The National Consumer Law Center, a watchdog group, has reported that, “for those living on low incomes or in rural or other areas not well served by public transportation, survival often depends upon the availability of a car.”

As in American politics and homeownership, the middle has fallen out. Last September, the average price for a new car surpassed fifty thousand dollars for the first time. Electronics account for nearly half of that cost; each vehicle contains as many as three thousand individual microchips. (These chips, most of which come from Taiwan, are manufactured in semiconductor plants that cost billions of dollars to build and operate. *Car and Driver* has reported that microprocessors and chips have become “practically a commodity in the same vein as steel and aluminum.”) In May, the personal-finance guru Ramit Sethi told the *Times*, “Americans love to

buy gargantuan eighty-five-thousand-dollar trucks. Then they also discover that they don't have a lot in savings.”

Since 2019, the average monthly payment for a new car has risen by about three hundred dollars. One in five new-car buyers is paying more than a thousand dollars a month, and lenders are writing loans for astonishing ninety-six-month terms. “They’ll get you in, whether you can afford it or not,” one repo-industry veteran told me at NARS. Overhearing this, another said, “That’s why I buy *used* cars—with cash.”

Banks and credit unions tend to serve prime borrowers, those with high credit scores; subprime borrowers have fewer options, such as independent finance companies and buy-here-pay-here lots, which typically require weekly or twice-monthly payments, charge higher interest rates, and are quick to repossess. (Subprime delinquencies have reached their highest levels since 2010.) A lender may wait until a borrower misses multiple payments to reclaim the collateral—it is more cost-efficient to keep a driver in a car (and a loan) than it is to repossess, remarket, and resell the vehicle. Yet even a single missed payment can trigger a repo order.



Cartoon by Roz Chast

There is little federal oversight of the repo industry, only adjacent laws on fair lending and privacy. The Uniform Commercial Code (U.C.C.) permits repossessionors to take vehicles without a court order, as long as they avoid any “breach of the peace,” a term so broad that even the A.R.A. is pushing for a standardized definition. Early repo guys were known to intimidate debtors, and sometimes to resort to violence. The history of repo is littered with “all kinds of trickery,” Art Christensen, a New Jersey repo man for the past sixty-six years and a co-founder of the *NARS* conference, told me. I’ve heard about schemes involving pizza delivery, or luring debtors into the open with the promise of free concert tickets. Pitman used to plant spy cams and spoof phone numbers. In “Repo Blood: A Century of Auto Repossession History,” Kevin W. Armstrong, a former repossessionor, writes, “Living the credo that ‘nothing is illegal unless you get caught,’ garage doors and gates were only minor barriers. . . . We got away with murder.”

The U.C.C. is not federal law; it is a legal framework, established in 1952, intended to streamline interstate business practices—a contract signed in New Mexico should hold up in Maine. States use the U.C.C. to draft laws that govern repossession, but, as with guns and cannabis, regulations vary from place to place. That is why it is legal in Utah, but not in Massachusetts, to repossess a vehicle in a driveway, and why California and Florida require state licensing for repo agents but other states overwhelmingly don’t, and why debtors in Kansas, and almost nowhere else, have a grace period of twenty days to resolve an account delinquency before a repo man shows up.

Pitman, who called himself a “security enforcer,” worked in a state with few restrictions and where no special licensing is required. In Utah, it is legal to peaceably repossess a vehicle anytime on public or private property, as long as the repossessionor doesn’t cut a lock or enter an enclosed area. When I asked Pitman who, really, was looking over a repo agent’s shoulder, he said, “The finance company—the ones that send you the money.”

Before RepoNut came into being, Pitman, who was divorced with children, met a grocery-store clerk named Shanda, who was also divorced with children. He tried to impress her by breaking into her car (“I can open up any lock in seconds”) and leaving flowers and a CD, by System of a Down,

on her steering wheel. They got married in the autumn of 2007. Shanda had misgivings about Pitman working nights—which is when debtors, and their cars, tend to be home—and in sketchy circumstances. Yet his income allowed her to quit her job. They lived in a two-story house with a two-car garage, which Pitman turned into a workshop where he parked his Kawasaki motorcycle and liked to fabricate sound systems maximized for the bone-rattling bass of E.D.M. and metal. Shanda, who had dark hair and eyes and a gentle demeanor, kept windowsills filled with plants. She did woodworking and drove a 2008 Ford Mustang painted in grabber orange, with black racing stripes. She occasionally rode along on repos, videoing Pitman. She did not watch RepoNut, though. She told her husband that seeing him manipulate others made it hard for her to trust him.

Pitman had been episodically surveilling a house for a delinquent luxury S.U.V. when, one August weekend, the vehicle turned up, parked askew at the curb and hitched to a trailer that held a ski boat. “It’s been at the lake,” he told the camera. He went home to get his rig and pick up Shanda. Riding shotgun, she asked, “Are they rich people?” Pitman replied, “I don’t know about *rich*, but they’re in a nicer neighborhood.” By “nicer,” he meant an area with sidewalks, and tidy homes and lawns, with no automobiles in states of visible disrepair.

No one was outside when they arrived. Pitman quickly hooked and lifted the S.U.V. by the nose, and unhitched the boat trailer. He rang the doorbell. A woman answered. When Pitman told her what he’d come for, she said, “Well, it’s attached to a boat.” Pitman, who has a talent for sounding like a bystander, said, “The boat’s disconnected now.”

Several people came out of the house. A shirtless man in swim trunks demanded that Pitman drop the car. When he refused, the man lunged at the heavy-duty straps that Pitman had just ratcheted to the hoisted wheels. Pitman went off: “Please don’t touch my straps!” His speech was an unnatural blur. Panting in fury, he jumped into his rig and drove off, towing the S.U.V. “Stop, stop, stop, stop!” Shanda said. “Stop! Stop! Baby, stop!” The debtor was running alongside the rig.

Pitman rounded a corner and stopped in the middle of the street. He jumped out to put dollies beneath the S.U.V.’s rear wheels, to make it easier and

safer to tow. Dragging a vehicle can wreck the transmission and any number of other things. As the debtor caught up, Pitman yelled, "I'll drag this fucker all the way to my yard!," to which the debtor replied, "Dude."

Pitman grew even more agitated. "You start touching my truck, I get pissed," he screamed. "That's my *livelihood*." He kept telling the debtor to go get his key: "*Gogetyourkey, gogetyourkey, gogetyourkey*."

"Don't cause a scene," the debtor said.

"You wanna see a scene? You wanna see a scene?"

"I'll go and get my key."

"Fuckin' *assmunch*!" Pitman shrieked. "Touch my truck again!"

The man returned with a woman, presumably his wife, who calmly told Pitman, "I need to get the car seat out." Her husband jumped behind the wheel of the S.U.V., the front end of which was still raised a couple of feet off the pavement. Pitman later told me, "I took him down to the ground in a choke hold, until he stopped fighting me," but that never happened. After Pitman yelled some more, the debtor got out. Pitman fast-backed the repo rig down the street with the S.U.V. attached and the man, once again, following on foot. "Where's he at?" Pitman asked Shanda.

"He's *on your truck*," she said.

The debtor had jumped onto the running board of Pitman's moving rig and was clinging to the driver's door.

Just then, the police showed up. The man's family had called 911, apparently to report a theft. "It's a repossession," Pitman explained to the responding officers. He rambled about the Fourteenth Amendment and also said, "I was trying to get clear of the scene because the guy was going *psycho*." Shanda was scared. The debtor's wife looked embarrassed. The police eventually found Pitman's paperwork to be in order and let him leave. Driving away, Pitman announced to the camera, "That, my friends, is rich people being stupid!"

Later, his mind clearer, he titled the video “Drunk Debtor Gets Stupid And I Get Stupider How NOT To Be.” In the description, he wrote, “I messed up period.” He attributed his frenzied behavior to fatigue. “Drunk Debtor” became, by far, the most popular video on RepoNut, with more than 4.2 million views.

Not long after the swimsuit repo, Shanda was given a diagnosis of terminal colorectal cancer. She died on April 15, 2016, at the age of thirty-eight. Two days later, Pitman posted a photo montage of their life together, with wistful captions about a boy who met a girl whose cancer “cost him everything.” He went on living in their home, with Shanda’s daughter, Aysia, who was sixteen. Aysia liked to change her hair color and wear a classic cat eye. Pitman called her his daughter, and he referred to Shanda’s father, Paul Pace, as his father, though his own biological father was alive and well, in Arizona. Pace told me, “When Shanda first got sick, Matt would stay home with her and was probably better than any doctor or nurse. We’d go over there after her death, and he’d be curled up in a ball on the bed, with Shanda’s picture.”

Pitman all but stopped repoing. RepoNut became a repository for his musings about loss, juxtaposed with pronouncements about goals—a hundred thousand Facebook friends, a Kickstarter for a “repo academy.” He had already written twelve pages of a curriculum, which would include a primer on repo lingo such as “disco” (a disconnected phone) and “P.O.E.” (place of employment), as well as “boring stuff,” such as “applicable laws.”

Shanda was four months gone when, that August, Pitman posted a video of himself jamming out in his garage. He had dark circles beneath his eyes and sores on his face. A RepoNut follower commented, “I am a parole officer and deal with Meth addict daily. This is a perfect example of what this drug can do to the best of people.” Pitman suggested that he’d been “acting.” Another commenter wrote, on a subsequent video, “Matt, bro two words Drug Rehab.” Under yet another comment, Pitman replied, “Hydrate hydrate hydrate snort repeat lol j/k put down the pitchforks folks,” signing it “Methhew Health Druggy Pitman.”

By October, he was openly wishing for the “karma gods” to give him a “kick in the ass with good luck.” He needed money. His bedroom, where

Shanda had died, was missing “a woman’s touch.” When RepoNut followers criticized his handling of a repossession where he had incorrectly told a debtor that it was “illegal” not to carry identification, Pitman retorted that only “a trained professional” could understand his tactics: “There’s a lot of mind-ninja stuff going on.”



“Hunting was terrible. Luckily, the supermarket had everything we needed.”
Cartoon by P. C. Vey

Viewers watched his home become cluttered, then trashed. The power and the water got cut off. Aysia went to live somewhere else. A woman whom Pitman called “sweetie” came over with a young girl, seemingly her daughter, to help clean up. The little girl, gamely wielding a garbage bag, saw urine everywhere and cried, “It’s all over your floor? Your *walls*?” Pitman plunged a toilet full of dark liquid and called it mud. The Sheetrock had holes in it. He alleged “sabotage,” adding, “This is just about how everybody pictured it going, with my implosion.” Walking into Aysia’s bedroom one day, he said, “Smells like something died down here.” Then, “Is that a *skinskin*?” He’d come across the remains of Aysia’s pet python.

Pitman moved out. Soon, RepoNut followers saw him in a tidy bedroom, backdropped by a framed poster with an inspirational message. (“You are braver than you believe.”) Leaning into his repo-academy idea, he showed a montage of TV news stories about bad repossessions and declared, “Fraud,

violence, wrongful repossession, untrained agents.” He now planned to “expose” the repo industry, calling it “plagued with problems,” which he was “working *feverishly* to correct.” In 2018, RepoNut content tapered off. Followers assumed that Pitman had died.

Early this year, Pitman resurfaced on YouTube. I called him up. He’d been in prison. His life choices had culminated in “a complete state of self-denial and self-sabotage,” he told me. He had stolen, to support an addiction—the RepoNut commenters had been right. He had also been cited for numerous traffic violations: speeding, running a stop sign, driving with an expired registration, using faulty equipment, improperly changing lanes, driving under the influence. The day before the “Drunk Debtor” incident, he had been charged with driving on a suspended license. Shanda, after her diagnosis, had been prescribed oxycodone, which Pitman had been taking. “Once I was on the drugs, it was a downward spiral,” he told me. “It’s like a big magic trick. Everything you own disappears—the people, the things, your credibility. It seemed like every corner I turned I was just getting the crap kicked out of me.”

Pitman had been to prison once before, in Arizona, for theft and fencing: when he was nineteen, he got caught operating a motorcycle chop shop. It was after that incarceration that he became a repo agent. “Having felonies doesn’t keep you from being able to be in this industry,” he said. The National Consumer Law Center has noted that the “ranks of the repossession army are wide open to individuals without the resources, qualifications or ability to pass criminal records checks needed for more attractive jobs.”

That study, published in 2010, highlighted the industry’s lack of oversight, calling repossession “a crude, unregulated and naked exercise of force and guile.” What was true then is largely true today: most states require no special licensing, registration, training, or screening for repossessioners, who work a sensitive job that puts them in direct contact with the public. In the United States, manicurists are better regulated than repo agents.

After his recent incarceration, Pitman lived at a men’s residential facility just north of Salt Lake City called Red Barn Academy, which promoted itself as a therapeutic community where “criminals, the homeless, and

substance abusers can come and reinvent their lives free of charge!” Pitman told me that he had “relearned honesty, integrity, accountability” at Red Barn, calling these “a trifecta” of essentials for “any person that wants to live a good life and be a good, functional, supporting part of society.” He had got back his driver’s license and had fixed up a cobalt-blue F-150 pickup, whose vanity license plate read “*ITHERTZ*.”

He had also returned to the repo industry—to a desk job, issuing seizure orders for a company that deals in industrial equipment for small businesses that do not qualify for traditional loans. Now, though, he was getting back into a repo rig, to drive full time. He had accepted a job and was moving to St. George, a city of about a hundred thousand, several hours south, in the upper Mojave Desert. Aysia, now in her late twenties, lived there, and she was about to have a baby. Pitman, who already had grandkids he did not see, was excited to be “a grandpa.” I flew to Salt Lake City.

Pitman had told me that he’d be packing up his house. This turned out to be a bedroom in a house that he had found on Facebook Marketplace. Strangers lived in the other bedrooms. One Sunday afternoon, I watched him dismantle a curtain rod, remove decorative burlap from the ceiling, and wrap stackable clothing bins in plastic. His bed was made. On the comforter lay a key chain outfitted with kitty knuckles, a plastic, hand-worn weapon with two super-sharp points.

A few weeks earlier, someone had broken into his truck and stolen his things, including a device that fires nonlethal projectiles. Wearing a tactical vest, Pitman had confronted the person he thought was responsible. When I asked who was behind the burglary, he nodded silently at his bedroom wall, implicating the tenant in the next room. I was standing in the hallway, in front of that guy’s closed door, where there was a handwritten sign: “*YOUR ON CAMERA*.”

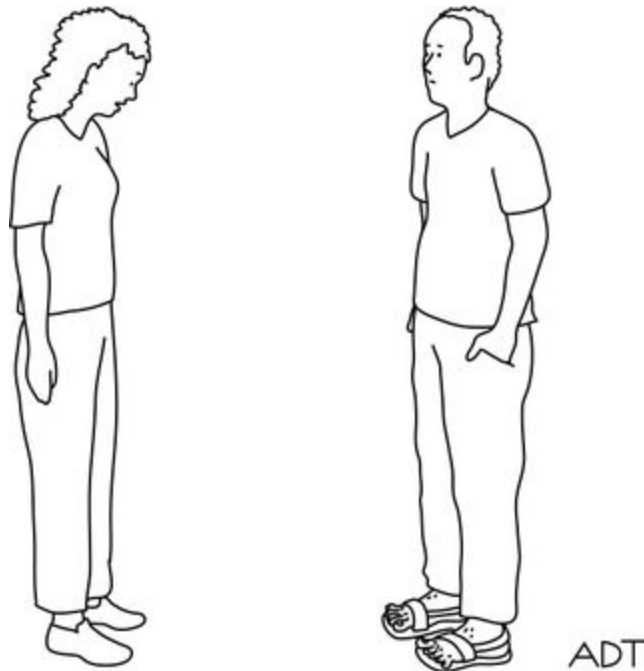
Summer is summer to you and me; to a repo agent, it is a season of scorching metal. Pitman always finds the upside. What the universe delivered in desert heat it tempered with fewer frozen gas caps, and with “year-round motorcycle weather.” Even during his free fall, he had told RepoNut followers, “Change is good, guys!” and “Life happens to *everybody*!”

A few days after I saw Pitman in Salt Lake City, I met him in St. George—red-rock buttes, electric-blue sky. Roses bloomed in creamy peaches and pinks, rattled, in their buds, by an unusual wind. Pitman drove to an industrial part of town, punched in a key code at an electronic gate, and pulled into a gravel tow lot that was partly ringed with abandoned R.V.s, tractor-trailer cabs, and other crusted wrecks. Inside a subplot secured by padlocks and chains sat two rows of recently repossessed vehicles. A semi arrived and deposited an intact tow camper—a 2005 Keystone Montana Mountaineer that Pitman had just bought, on Facebook Marketplace, for six thousand dollars, cash. His new boss was letting him live on the lot, rent-free, as a perk. The Mountaineer had no hookups, but Pitman had worked out a “modular” life plan. He already owned a generator and a microwave. He would join a twenty-four-hour gym, for the showers. He would do laundry at Aysia’s apartment. The repo job came with a gas card. Pitman showed me through the Mountaineer, which was about thirty feet long, with a bed on one end and a kitchen on the other, and said, “If life goes to shit, I’m not homeless.”

The tow lot was surrounded by chain-link fencing threaded with strips of plastic and topped by barbed wire. Pitman, pleased with the new setup, decreed it “security by obscurity.” How great it would be, he said, to put out the Mountaineer’s awning and sit, unbothered, beneath the deep night sky. On one of the fenceposts, someone had stuck a fake head on a pike. A Darth Vader mask hung on the inside of the electronic gate. Pitman decided that it meant either “we’re on the dark side” or “may the Force be with you.”

Pitman had been hired to cover the whole of southern Utah, from Nevada to Colorado. On his first day of work, he wore colorful patchwork pants, red Adidas high-tops, a backward San Francisco Giants baseball cap, and a hoodie that read “*REPO LIFE*” and “I’m addicted to my work. But I’m in recovery so it’s OK.” (His design.) He hadn’t operated a repo truck in years. His work rig was a Ford F-350 sneaker—the kind with the stinger. He mounted his Motorola phone on a vent and placed a mobile router on the dashboard. He set one laptop on the center console and a second laptop on an attached platform that reminded me of a cat tree. “I got a thousand passwords to remember again,” he said. “Having a really good memory makes all that easier.”

The cat tree took up most of the passenger seat, so, for days, I rode nauseously in the back, looking over Pitman's shoulder and trying to avoid the exhalations of his watermelon-flavored vape. One of the laptops ran a digital map; icons, shaped like inverted teardrops, marked addresses that lenders were paying Pitman's company to pay Pitman to check, for collateral. Driving by the teardrops is called running addresses. Southern Utah was covered in teardrops.



"No, I don't think I'm interested in an open-toed relationship."

Cartoon by Adam Douglas Thompson

Each corner of Pitman's rig held an infrared camera whose beams of light bounced off the reflective surface of all visible license plates, reading them. The cameras, not so much hunting as scavenging, fed the numbers and their corresponding locations into a national database owned by a company that sells the information. If one of the scanned vehicles came up for repo later, the software could indicate where and when the plate had been seen. "We're doing all the work," Pitman observed. "We're making *their* database stronger." The camera system is called an advanced license-plate reader, commonly known as an L.P.R. (Law enforcement and toll roads use the same technology, which has prompted debates about mass surveillance.) Each time one of Pitman's cameras read a plate, his laptop went *ding*. Driving around St. George, we heard *ding . . . ding . . . ding*. In crowded

parking lots, *dingding . . . dingdingdingdingdingdingding*. Plate numbers scrolled on his screen, with state abbreviations: UT, FL, MN, MT, NV, TN, DE.

Repossessors themselves are sometimes surveilled. At the *NARS* conference, I met a vender selling a camera-and-software system that monitors distracted driving, fatigue, and acceleration and braking patterns—a better “safety score” can lead to lower insurance premiums. A company called GridShark was demoing a “fleet intelligence” program: on a huge L.E.D. screen, I watched the real-time movements of agents and “spotters,” who drive camera cars, being traced, Pac-Man style, on a digital map of San Antonio. Bosses could see who was doing what, to deploy their drivers more efficiently. A repo-company owner named Paul Howard, thinking of the fuel savings alone, said, “I need this by Sunday night!” He couldn’t wait to use GridShark secretly for a week and then spring its existence on his drivers. Slackers would be outed.

Anytime Pitman’s laptop went *wrrrrRRRR*, it meant that the cameras had found a plate wanted on an active repo order. Those vehicles were to be hooked. On the map, a pink “V” inside a pink circle indicated a volly, or a voluntary repossession. This is when the debtor, aware that his vehicle is in jeopardy, makes an appointment, through the lender, to have a reposessor pick it up. Vollies happen about a quarter of the time. A subset of the volly demographic is the debtor who, per Pitman, “fucks with” the repo agent—glass in the driver’s seat, a razor blade taped to a door handle, sugar in the gas tank. “When they screw with you, they don’t think it through,” he told me. “It’s, like, I know where you *live*.”

For every completed repo, Pitman took and uploaded voluminous photos. He filled out online condition reports and checked off boxes pertaining to keys, battery, mileage, tires. At each fruitless address, he dictated his findings into his phone, updating files: “Single-family home, two-car garage, white Silverado backed in the driveway, not our collateral”; “Mobile-home park, Lexus backed into the driveway, no answer at the door.”

One afternoon, he hooked a Chevrolet Colorado in the driveway of a town house whose garage door stood open, revealing a neat space with an

immaculate floor. Pitman knocked at both the interior door of the garage and the front door. He was just about to leave when a young man in sweats and slides with socks emerged to find the front end of his Chevy up in the air. Pitman brightly asked, “This been a pretty good truck?” The man replied quietly, “Yeah, it’s been amazing.” (Pitman later told me, “I knew exactly where his mind was at, in that moment.”) Pitman waited as the debtor, a construction worker, transferred a reflective vest, a jug of water, a pair of shoes, a backpack, and a sack of nine-millimetre bullets to the garage. He hadn’t been able to make a payment in three months. “Some things went south,” he said. “It is what it is.”

Another time, Pitman got a teardrop for a Toyota Camry. He failed to find it at the address listed on the loan. When he tried another address, his laptop went *wrrrrRRRR*. The Camry was sitting in the driveway of a one-story home whose front door was wide open. Pitman backed up and hooked the Camry, then confirmed the *VIN* on his way to the door.

A pair of industrial vats sat bubbling on the stoop, attached to propane-powered burners. Pitman knocked at the open door and hollered the name on his list. Out came a twenty-two-year-old woman in shorts and Birkenstocks. Pitman told her, “We’re picking up your car for the finance company. Is there anything you need to get out?”

“No. What?” she said.

As the woman followed Pitman to the driveway, her grandmother fell in behind, asking, “*Por qué?*”

“You need to call the bank,” Pitman told her. “They’ll tell you why they had us come out and pick it up.”

The grandmother said, “*Pero ya ha pagado!*”

The young woman gathered some of her things, leaving behind a hair clip, a ceramic mug, a piece of clothing, and invitations for an Easter worship service. This told Pitman that she planned to redeem the vehicle as soon as possible. In his experience, debtors with no plans for redemption either remove everything or leave everything.

Later, I returned to the house to talk to the young woman. She wasn't home, but her mother, Liliana, was. "*Debe mucho todavía*," she told me, adding that she had begged her daughter, who was still paying for college, not to sign a car loan with a high interest rate, which she recalled being nineteen per cent. "She work in a restaurant, she work in the dentist, she make eyelashes," Liliana said. "She tried her best, but, you know, sometimes difficult to get the money that day." Liliana, who is divorced, cleans for a living and sells homemade tamales on weekends. That's what was cooking in the vats.

A Tesla appeared on the map. It was a volly, which goes on a credit report, same as an involuntary repossession, but does tend to save the debtor back-end fees on transportation and storage. At Pitman's tow lot, I met a warehouse worker who told me that a credit union was charging him nine thousand dollars to redeem a Nissan Rogue. He said that he owed less than five grand on the loan itself. Pitman told me about companies that bag up the inventoried contents of repossessed vehicles and charge the debtors twenty-five dollars per bag to get back their own things. "That's extortion!" he said. "That's how these companies fleece America."

He found the Tesla parked where the debtor had said it would be, at a modest house near a golf course. A barefoot young woman in sweats and an anklet came out and told Pitman, "It's gonna need new brakes." Small children crowded at an open window, calling, "Mama!" As the woman went to look up information about the battery, Pitman tried to figure out how the Tesla's doors worked. They raised, like wings.

The car's interior was filthy. Repo agents find all kinds of things in vehicles—needles, poop diapers, sex beads. Some companies require their agents to wear protective goggles and puncture-proof gloves. Pitman operates on instinct. He cranked the Tesla, backed it into the street, and hooked it. Watching from the driveway, the woman told me that she was getting a divorce. "It's a D.V. situation," she said, meaning domestic violence. One of her kids came outside and asked, "Are you gonna miss the Tesla?"

"No," she said. "I am not."

Pitman was looking for a Hyundai in the parking lot of a residential complex when we started talking about whether Utah should require repossessioner licensing. He considers any kind of certification a “badge of honor.” He noted that good repossessioners already “lean on the side of caution, to make sure we don’t get the finance company in trouble and we don’t get our repo company in trouble.” Insurance and bonding hedge against, among other things, what Pitman claims is “a big problem” in the repo industry: “sticky fingers.”

“Since we’re on the topic,” I said, “what were you busted for?”

“Possession of a deadly weapon,” he said. (It was an illegal handgun.) “I got busted with drugs on me while I was sitting in my car, in a parking lot.”

“What drugs?”

“Meth, heroin, pills.”

“This was after Shanda died.”

“Mm-hmm, yep.”

“Weren’t there burglary charges?”

“Mm-hmm. I broke into a storage unit, took some stuff that was not mine. They had video of my license plate. I wasn’t very smart about it.”

“Whose unit was it?”

“Just some random person’s.”

“Did you know something was in there that you wanted?”

“Nope. High on drugs, and I just helped myself to it.”

“How’d you break in?”

“I picked the lock.”

“What’d you get?”

“Sixty-eight hundred dollars’ worth of stuff. Because that’s what I had to pay in restitution. I don’t really remember.”

“What’d you do with the stuff?”

“Sold it. Gave it away. All of the above.”

“For drugs?”

“Yes, definitely,” he said. “I was homeless, living on the streets, and needed money.”

I once asked Pitman his opinion of the societal value of automobile repossession. “It’s a deterrent,” he said. At *NARS*, I continually asked the same question. A forwarder from Texas said, “If cars don’t get picked up and the lender continues to lose money, what do you think happens? How are they going to recoup that money? They’re going to raise interest rates on *everybody*.” Clemmons, the former A.R.A. president, told me, “Repossessions protect your ability to finance a car—if there was no one to retrieve these vehicles, there would be no financing, full stop.”

The *NARS* conference took place at a Hilton resort and convention center with an eighteen-hole golf course and a lazy-river swimming pool. One of the sessions happened outside, on a bricked plaza, where a crowd watched Danny and Sophia Pabon, who grew their business, Florida Repossession Agency, from a single truck to a forty-employee company, lead reënactments of scenarios that repo drivers encounter in the field: what to do if a competitor shows up at the same repo, or if a debtor uses G.P.S. to follow and confront a driver; how to safeguard against fentanyl exposure. Sophia, a Bronx native in her early forties, told me, “I have a lot of respect for this industry, and I feel like people don’t understand the importance of what we do and how it keeps our ecosystem of cars going.”

She disliked that repossessioners were thought of as “the bad guys.” But the reputation is earned; Clemmons, who got his start in the eighties, in Cleveland, by proving himself handy with a slim jim, said, “You name it,

we did it—going into garages, breaking and entering.” He and Christensen, the New Jersey repo man and *NARS* co-founder, are among those who have been working to reform the industry’s outlaw image and, as Christensen put it, push for “better ways to evolve.” Clemmons supports mandatory training in defensive driving, situational awareness, and de-escalation. “I’m not the kind of guy who wants regulation—I don’t want the government telling me what to do,” he said. “But I do believe we can force it upon ourselves. When there’s no standard, there’s chaos.” He liked the sound of bar associations, which censure lawyers for malfeasance. “Right now, in our space, there is no respected authority.”

At one *NARS* session, Al Gonzalez, a reposessor from Texas, asked Danny Pabon, his presentation partner, to name a reputation-killing behavior in their industry. Pabon replied, “Being sloppy on social media. I’ve seen people on LinkedIn be super professional, then you go on their Facebook and it’s a whole different person.” When Gonzalez asked what Pabon tells his employees about posting online, he replied, “They shouldn’t post *anything* online.”

In Utah, Pitman had just posted a new YouTube video, about returning to a repo rig and moving to St. George. Within twenty-four hours, it had more than nine thousand views. A fan welcomed back “the OG.” Pitman had already bought a Bluetooth mike, and he planned to learn St. George’s streets at pavement level, on an electric scooter. He had discovered the thrilling utility of flying a small drone into gated communities, to hover over windshields, capturing *VIN*s. He had gone online and bought a badge that read “*REPOSSESSION RECOVERY AGENT*.” Shaped like a shield, it cost \$39.94 at Agent Gear USA, a website that stands equally ready to serve the credentialling needs of any “*BAIL ENFORCEMENT AGENT (BEA)*” or “*INTERNATIONAL SPECIAL AGENT*.”

Pitman never wore his badge in front of me, but after I left I heard that it was hanging on a chain around his neck. In a small town called Hurricane, between St. George and Zion National Park, someone complained to the cops about a cosplaying repo man. A police detective rang Pitman and warned him about impersonating a law-enforcement officer.

There would be no new repoing on RepoNut, though: Pitman's boss does not permit it. Pitman wasn't even allowed to use RepoNut as his company login. He attributed these restrictions to jealousy, saying that other repossessioners "don't have the confidence or the abilities" to do what he does online. "Either you got the personality for it or you don't." He was stuck posting mostly deep thoughts and scenery. An entire archive of potential reruns—more than eight hundred videos—also lay at his disposal. "There's a lot of people in this industry that absolutely hate the fact that I've done this and put these videos up on YouTube," he once said, adding, "And I actually agree with them!" His most popular content contained "the worst shit shows—they're me at my worst, they're people at their worst." (During the fact-checking process for this piece, Pitman made private most of his RepoNut videos, blaming criticisms from competitors who were "being Karens.")

Pitman, who turns fifty-six in August, cannot see working repo much longer anyway. "At the end of the day, all I'm doing is making finance companies more money," he told me. "The American financial system is broken. We're forced into financial slavery. Even though I've been the pit bull at the end of the chain for that industry for forty years, it's because I'm in my position that I—" Instead of finishing the sentence, he told me that he wanted his next career move to be "balancing the scale."

He plans to turn the living space of his camper into a podcast studio for a new program, "Know Good," where he will talk about everything that he has been through in life, including repo. Maybe he will tow the camper around the country and chat with other repo guys, asking, What's your boss like? What's your pay like? Can you live on that? Or maybe he could do ride-alongs and critique other repossessioners' techniques. He'd never seen New England, or Niagara Falls. Aysia, who is now a stay-at-home mom, told me that she hoped Pitman would not "transition out of repoing too fast," though, because "repoing is definitely cool and fun, and I think he's super good at it." He recently bought Aysia her first car. ♦

Paige Williams, a staff writer, is the author of "[The Dinosaur Artist](#)" and a recipient of the National Magazine Award for feature writing.

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Colson Whitehead's Big Score

As he closes out his Harlem crime trilogy with “Cool Machine,” the two-time Pulitzer winner turns again to the city that made him, and to the private ghosts behind his restless reinventions.

By [Julian Lucas](#)

June 22, 2026



Whitehead's latest novel, “Cool Machine,” completes a trilogy of Harlem crime stories about thieves, hustlers, strivers, and the crooked dreams that make a city run. Photograph by Philip-Daniel Ducasse for The New Yorker

I was standing at the corner of Ninety-third and Broadway, scanning an empty storefront for signs of literary activity, when Colson Whitehead texted: “Behind you.” It was a clear May afternoon. Whitehead had invited me to his office but specified only the intersection; spinning around, I spotted a dreadlocked figure in shades and a suède jacket, slouched on a

bench in the median. Once I'd crossed, he rose to greet me, revealing, on the seat, a plaque that read "Colson Whitehead's Office." He cracked a smile. "Got it for my birthday last November," he said. "No urine or dead animals yet."

Whitehead, fifty-six, has a reddish-brown complexion, hooded, inquisitive eyes, and a lightly salted mustache-goatee, which, along with his locs, brings to mind mail-order portraits of Black Jesus. He's long-limbed but unobtrusive in his movements, like a suave giraffe on the lam, an impression reinforced by his tapering brown Chelsea boots. "It's a weird culture, people who sit on benches," he said, laughing with a snort for punctuation. A thief in his latest novel uses them for reconnaissance, watching Broadway traffic "until every vector of every possible getaway was a filament in my web."

Soon, we were riding the elevator to his apartment, in a prewar building near Riverside Park. Whitehead has enjoyed one of the smoothest ascents in contemporary American literature, from his celebrated 1999 debut, "[The Intuitionist](#)," a mystery novel about elevator inspectors, to his back-to-back Pulitzers for "[The Underground Railroad](#)" (2016) and "[The Nickel Boys](#)" (2019). His ten other, wildly disparate books include two satires of media and marketing and an [elegiac zombie novel](#) set in Manhattan.

Like New Yorkers fighting over favorite neighborhoods, devoted readers often reproach one another for their ignorance of the *real* Colson Whitehead. To some, he's "America's Storyteller," as a [2019 Time cover](#) declared, reckoning with slavery and segregation in novels destined to become fixtures of high-school syllabi. To others, he's a jaded Gen X ironist, who once began a memoir with the words "I have a good poker face because I'm half-dead inside." And, to still others, he's the spiritual cartographer of the city that never sleeps, given to such aperçus as that old apartments are "caretakers of your reinventions." Whitehead himself identifies, improbably, as a slacker. "I'm a really lazy bitch, but I have a punitive superego," he told me. "The two go together."

The elevator doors opened, and we stepped through a vestibule into his apartment. On the walls were art works by [Kerry James Marshall](#), [Rashid Johnson](#), and Ellen Gallagher, and books shelved in colorful modular

storage units. In the living room, a tabby cat with a clipped ear lounged on a velvet couch, her front paws propping open an illustrated catalogue of military aircraft. “That’s Jupiter,” Whitehead said. “She gets ten per cent nicer every year.” His wife, the literary agent Julie Barer, who’d dedicated his bench, was out, as was their twelve-year-old son, Beckett, who’s been coaching his father through the video game *Baldur’s Gate 3*. (Whitehead’s other child, Fig, was off finishing a senior thesis at Vassar.) Video games are Whitehead’s usual palate cleanser between projects, but lately he’s been cutting back. “I was going to take a year off from writing, but then, come December, I was really bored,” he said. “Life is short. How many books do I have left?”

His desk was tucked in a corner at the far end of the room, under windows overlooking neighbors’ rooftops. “Should I report that house?” he said, stroking his beard mock officiously as he pointed out a lavish deck. “Some illegal fun *you’re* having.” The workspace was decorated with framed covers of the *Times Book Review*, a vintage sign for knife-sharpening services, a taped-to-the-wall [headline from Slate](#) (“Colson Whitehead Is Still Just Doing His Weird Thing”), and a poster for “Rififi,” a film noir about a jewel heist.

For the past seven years, Whitehead has been writing a trilogy of New York crime novels. Their protagonist, Ray Carney, is a furniture salesman with a sitcom-worthy family and a sideline as a fence. He’s “only slightly bent when it came to being crooked,” but, in 1959, his cousin draws him into a spectacular robbery. It was meant to be a one-off—as was “[Harlem Shuffle](#)” (2021), the novel in which it takes place. Yet both Carney and his creator kept getting sucked back in. “[Crook Manifesto](#)” (2023) finds Carney tangling with arsonists amid New York’s seventies decline. “[Cool Machine](#),” out next month, closes out the series in the eighties, as punks, yuppies, graffiti artists, and mafiosi face off in a city “malformed across the centuries—a monstrous entity powered by innate miseries, operated by brute will, and held together by pluck, fury, and rebar.” You can almost see the skyline blush.

“I don’t think there’s a lot of other crime novels where the main character is a real wife guy,” Whitehead observed. He talks about his work as though he

were a humble novelty peddler—quite possibly a symptom of impostor syndrome, and a generational horror of coming off like a poseur. But his disavowed intensity finds expression in the monkish professionalism of his characters, whose jobs are at once means of self-avoidance and keys to hidden patterns in the world. More than twenty years ago, he described New York as a city that “multiplies when you’re not looking,” and, in the trilogy, he pursues this idea on a grand scale. The novels are a time-lapse panorama of a metropolis perpetually reshaped by its inhabitants. Whitehead is one of them, and the trilogy is an archeology of his own foundations.

Whitehead was born in 1969, the year that construction began on the World Trade Center’s South Tower. His mother, Mary Ann, came from a prosperous family of New Jersey undertakers, and taught in New York City’s public schools. (One ancestor, William M. Colson, was a merchant who died in Liberia after a feverish bout of correspondence; in the words of an associate, “His love for writing proved fatal.”) Her husband, Arch Whitehead, came from a less privileged background. Born in Harlem, he put himself through Dartmouth by singing in night clubs, and eventually founded a headhunting firm. Gregarious but stormy, he had frustrated literary aspirations, writing poetry and a screenplay entitled “A Werewolf in Harlem.”

Chipp, as Whitehead is known in the family—his full name is Arch Colson Chipp Whitehead—was the third of four children. He arrived after two sisters, Ann and Lynn, and just ten months before a younger brother, Clarke. The family moved constantly, including, once, into the apartment of an upstairs neighbor who’d jumped to his death. “They were still hosing the guy off the sidewalk, and my dad was, like, ‘So, is 11-A available?’ ” Whitehead said. He spent most of [his childhood](#) on the Upper West Side and every summer in Sag Harbor, where his mother’s family had a beach house.

“I wouldn’t say *nerdy*, but he had his hobbies,” Ann said of the young Whitehead, whom she recalls reading comic books and duelling their brother with a toy lightsabre. He and Clarke “were basically the same person until puberty,” Whitehead said, when Clarke emerged as the more

“distracted and rascally” of the pair. Lynn told me that Colson shared his father’s moodiness, if not his stifling conservatism. “He kind of stopped in the fifties,” she said. “Not once did I see him in a pair of bluejeans.” He was also prone to fits of rage, especially when he’d been drinking, but he expected stoicism from his children. “Talking about feelings just wasn’t done,” Lynn said. “And we all have a bit of that in us.”



Colson Whitehead (right) and his younger brother, Clarke, on a family vacation in Barbados, in 1976. Whitehead says that the two were “basically the same person until puberty.” Courtesy the author

Television was the household’s unifying passion. “Every Saturday on HBO, we’d watch, say, a Sugar Ray Leonard fight or an inappropriate movie like ‘A Clockwork Orange,’ ” Whitehead recalled. “Then, at eleven, George Carlin or Richard Pryor.” Horror was the genre of choice, from George A. Romero’s zombie films to [John Carpenter’s “Halloween.”](#) Whitehead fought Clarke for the paperback novelizations of their favorites, and began his study of narrative in the pages of [Fangoria](#).

His ambition was to write for Marvel, or to become “the Black Stephen King.” At Trinity, his illustrious prep school on Broadway, such interests could be isolating, though he eventually fell in with a group of friendly stoners. (In a yearbook photo, he appears in a Joy Division T-shirt under a quote from Joseph Conrad: “We live as we dream, alone.”) Lynn showed him a more expansive New York, turning him on to post-punk and no-wave bands—ESG, Gang of Four, Liquid Liquid—and the *Village Voice*. “I became this teen-age culture maven,” he told me, regularly going out to see New Wave films or to dance at the legendary downtown club CBGB. In a

senior-year English class, he read Gabriel García Márquez's "[One Hundred Years of Solitude](#)" and realized that literary fiction could be as wild as "Carrie" or the X-Men.

In 1987, he went off to Harvard, where he enraged his father by studying English. " 'You gotta take economics,' " he recalled being told. "I was, like, 'No, Daddy, I want to *sing!*' " His parents saw him as a future lawyer; instead, he took up smoking and skipped class. Coursework introduced him to [Thomas Pynchon](#), [Nathanael West](#), [Samuel Beckett](#), and [Ralph Ellison](#), all lasting influences. He also improvised his own curriculum of postmodern theory and pop-culture criticism. Whitehead wanted to write, but workshops rejected him and the cliquish undergraduate literary scene put him off. "I'm not really a joiner," he said. "The idea of auditioning? Screw you."

Coaxing out his talents fell to a more politic peer. [Kevin Young](#)—now *The New Yorker*'s poetry editor—was a year behind Whitehead, but already a campus prodigy. He'd taken it upon himself to revive a Black student literary magazine, *Diaspora*, and a co-editor introduced him to Whitehead. "He was wearing a white T-shirt, jeans, and Chuck Taylors, and I was wearing a white T-shirt, khakis, and Chuck Taylors," Young said of their meeting. "I felt instantly that we were kin." He published Whitehead's first short stories, and spent a break living with him in Manhattan, where they saw [Afrika Bambaataa](#) d.j.'ing at the Nuyorican Poets Café. Young was fascinated by his ability to find an open diner under any circumstances: "It was like watching a human computer."

Another classmate was the future director [Darren Aronofsky](#), who cast Whitehead as a zombielike "video junkie" in his senior-thesis film. Whitehead didn't write a thesis, though a friend who worked for a TV director landed him a gig writing a feature film. "It was a teen sex comedy that was a mix between 'Risky Business' and 'House Party,' " he recalled. "The person who hired me, her notes were, like, 'Can we have a scene where he has to rap his way out of trouble?' " After graduation, he spent six months watching television in Sag Harbor, where he, his parents, Lynn, and Clarke—who "drank and drugged his way to getting kicked out of

Dartmouth”—were crowded into the same small house. “Basically, it was insane,” he said.

All that television proved useful at the *Voice*, where he secured a job as an editorial assistant and then, in short order, as a TV columnist. “TV criticism was really frowned upon,” he said. “Only jerk-offs did it.” Still, he threw himself into the role, skewering the “invented New York realness” of gritty police procedurals and the ersatz Harlem of a Bill Cosby-backed series filmed on a Disney studio lot “at the corner of Dopey Drive and Minnie Avenue.” Whitehead also wrote for the *Voice Literary Supplement*, ridiculing David Foster Wallace’s foray into rap studies, musing about the affinity between cigarettes and spite, and, for a lark, giving a rave review to “[Knitting with Dog Hair](#),” a novelty craft book that he praised as the antidote to “our hyper-cyber times.” His boyishly knowing voice could tip into outright fiction, as with the Prufrockian spin he gave an invented LL Cool J memoir: “I grow old. I grow old. Shall I wear the bottoms of my baggy jeans rolled?”

“The nerve of this kid,” Jeff Salamon, his editor at the *Voice*, fondly recalled thinking. “Sometimes he’d say, ‘I’m writing about this show,’ and what would come in was basically a fictional character’s *experience* of the show.” Whitehead was a regular in the smoking lounge of the newspaper’s Cooper Square office, often arriving in a porkpie hat or an “E.T.”-themed beanie. “Everybody was just fucking cool, really on top of it,” he said. “It was before pop-culture criticism broke into the mainstream, and these incredible knights”—[Robert Christgau](#), [J. Hoberman](#), [Greg Tate](#)—“were writing about comics and Foucault and Toni Morrison and Run-DMC.” Whitehead started dating a colleague, Natasha Stovall, who wrote about punk music, and they moved in together in Fort Greene.

There were crackheads in the neighborhood, and, once, his landlady’s dog was injured by gunfire. But rent was cheap, and Whitehead had ample time to write fiction between columns. His literary aspirations had solidified on a solo trip through Brazil in the summer of 1994. “I had copies of [the Odyssey](#) and Joyce’s ‘[Ulysses](#)’ and read them back-to-back, sitting on the beach in my Converse and my cutoff jeans,” he said. “I was, like, ‘O.K., I’m twenty-five. Maybe I should start.’ ”

His first attempt was a satire about a former child actor inspired by Gary Coleman, the star of “Diff’rent Strokes,” imagined as the target of a sinister media company. It was largely an exploration of stereotypes and Black masculinity, Whitehead recalled, and “more theory than story.” An agent was interested, but dropped him when she couldn’t find a publisher. “A lot of people thought I was on a fool’s errand,” he said of his ambitions. “But there’s nothing else that was going to make me whole.”

Vocational commitment was the subject of his [début novel](#), conceived after he spotted a study guide to the elevator-inspector exam at the library. The topic was irresistible: surely no one else had built a mystery around elevator inspection. It also gave him a way to link the rhetoric of Black uplift to the rise of skyscrapers and to millenarian dreams of ascension. His protagonist was Lila Mae Watson, the first Black woman elevator inspector in an unnamed metropolis, who is framed for a catastrophic fall. She belongs to the Intuitionists, a controversial faction of inspectors who communicate with elevators “on a nonmaterial basis.” They await a wondrous “black box” that will bring about the “second elevation,” while their rivals, the Empiricists, scheme to bring them back to earth.

Whitehead drew on Thomas Pynchon, with his infrastructural conspiracies; [Ishmael Reed](#), whose “[Mumbo Jumbo](#)” also turns on a racialized metaphysical schism; and [Ralph Ellison](#), with his vision of a marginalized figure illuminating the modern metropolis. “I think my words to him were ‘You’ve written “[Invisible Man](#),” ’ ” Young, who was the first to read it, recalled. He was impressed by the novel’s noirish atmosphere, its deadpan approach to the fantastical conceit, and its wit, which stopped short of cynicism. “All his books have a layer of irony, but that’s to get you there at the table,” Young explained. “He’s always feeding you more.”

Whitehead recalled his father’s gruff skepticism: “How many elevator inspectors are there in the world? Who’s gonna buy it?” Yet the novel found a publisher quickly. A friend encouraged him to send it to Nicole Aragi, a young agent who also represented [Junot Díaz](#), and she placed it at Doubleday. (He’s remained with both agent and publisher ever since.) In 1997, Stovall had persuaded Whitehead to move to San Francisco, where he found a dot-com-boom job writing copy for *CNET*. But California didn’t

agree with him, and they moved back to Fort Greene just before the novel appeared. It was so successful that Whitehead had to improvise an extended book tour. Back in San Francisco, he said, “the only friend I had left was a dominatrix, so I slept in her dungeon.”



*“The Lord works in mysterious ways, but down here I like to keep things pretty straightforward.”
Cartoon by Tom Toro*

“The Intuitionist” arrived amid a new critical appetite for so-called literary genre fiction. That same year, Doubleday published Jonathan Lethem’s “[Motherless Brooklyn](#),” another mystery novel whose deeper subject was the soul of urban life. “What binds us together is that we both remember specific, sacred, weird details about New York in the seventies and eighties,” Lethem said of Whitehead. “Sometimes I feel like our books are messages to each other.” The two were often paired at readings and became fast friends, frequently seeing each other at a poker night of Brooklyn writers that also included [Nathan Englander](#) and [Heidi Julavits](#). Whitehead’s cool, exacting voice reminded Lethem of Rod Serling hosting “[The Twilight Zone](#)”: “The real Colson is there but standing to one side.”

His second novel was as encyclopedic and freewheeling as his first had been enigmatic. “[John Henry Days](#)” (2001) was inspired by the myth of the Black railroad worker who’d died after beating a steam drill in a race. The folk hero makes a few elliptical appearances, along with the bluesmen, scholars, and Tin Pan Alley tunesmiths who shaped his legend. But the main action takes place at a John Henry festival in mid-nineties West

Virginia, where J. Sutter, a hack journalist who lives in Fort Greene, has been sent by a content-hungry website. Sutter is trying to break his friends' record for consecutively attended publicity events, the idea being that he, too, is locked in a death match with technology. The novel sprawls, sometimes awkwardly, but its media satire is mordantly hilarious, and it cemented Whitehead's wunderkind status. In 2002, he received a MacArthur Fellowship, a windfall that prompted him and Stovall, who had married at the turn of the millennium, to start trying for a baby.

Not everyone was taken with his cleverness. Infamously, the novelist [Richard Ford](#) spat on Whitehead at a party, as payback for a pan in the [Times Book Review](#). (Whitehead had mocked the older writer's adulterers as less sinful than whiny.) Whitehead himself was panned by James Wood in *The New Republic*, who described "John Henry Days" as "full of noise and irrelevant intensity" and corrupted by "the mad fluency . . . of email." Eight years later, Whitehead answered him in *Harper's*, parodying the critic's fastidiousness in an essay that declared "He lifted the cup" a perfect sentence: "Aha! cries the famished reader. This is minimalism at its well-marbled finest." But Wood had also charged Whitehead with avoiding introspection, echoing an assessment that the novelist—who'd developed a self-protective reserve in childhood—was also beginning to reach. Whitehead had been toying with a fabulist reimagining of the Underground Railroad but decided that he wasn't yet mature enough to do it justice. Before he could write about slavery, he would have to risk something of himself.

Later in May, I met Whitehead in East Hampton, where he and Barer have a house. It has two white cubical wings connected by a sky bridge, where I could see his silhouetted figure setting the table for lunch. "It's not *officially* a gumbo, because there's okra, tomatoes, and no roux," Whitehead explained upstairs, tying back his locs to stir a pot of piquant-smelling stew. A passionate cook, he makes most of his family's meals, specializing in smoked ribs, pork vindaloo, and fried chicken of every nationality, a dish to which he once devoted an essay. Grilling was his father's *métier*, and a highlight of their summers in Sag Harbor, though Arch approached it more austere. "He literally only made chicken," Whitehead said, and took offense at requests for barbecue sauce.

[A Pavement song](#) played as he dished out two servings, apologizing for an excess of salt I struggled to detect. He seemed more guarded than before, and I changed the subject from his father to his son. “I thought if we named him after someone depressive and serious, he might become a happy-go-lucky jock or a stockbroker,” Whitehead said. Yet Beckett seems to be taking after his father, immersed, as Whitehead once was, in the worlds of “Star Wars” and D. & D. He’s also a military-history buff, and this summer the family will celebrate his bar mitzvah with a trip to see the D Day beaches in Normandy. “We’re going to rent a shuttle bus,” Whitehead said, “and I picture it as a sort of ‘Little Miss Sunshine’-type thing, where everyone has an arc over the course of five days.”

For now, there was another fraught beach to revisit. After lunch, we set out for Sag Harbor in Whitehead’s black BMW X5, which he carefully piloted, hands at ten and two, down empty roads half hidden by scrubby Long Island pines. (He earned his driver’s license during the pandemic, in a Zoom class where all the other students were teens.) There was little to see until we reached Azurest, one of three historically Black enclaves on Sag Harbor’s outskirts. Whitehead took a right at a sign depicting a dozing fisherman, continuing up a shady road toward the bay.

Sag Harbor, an old whaling port, was once known as the “Unhampton,” for its relative quaintness. In the nineteen-forties, it became one of the first towns in the area where Black families could acquire beachfront property. Whitehead’s maternal grandfather, T. Colson Woody, bought in early, and generations of his family have vacationed there since. Mary Ann came there as a girl, then with her schoolteacher friends on summer breaks, and then with her husband and children, who played with her friends’ children on the beach or in the woods between developments. “Chipp and Clarke and their gang of boys would build forts on the beach and shoot off bottle rockets,” Lynn recalled. “We had free rein.”

Whitehead wrote his 2009 novel, “[Sag Harbor](#),” to memorialize those bygone days, largely erased by the area’s “Hamptonization.” Its colorful mid-century houses have increasingly given way to metal-roofed McMansions and, with them, a much whiter population. Seven years ago, a group of Black families had the old developments inscribed on the National

Register of Historic Places, hoping to hold back the tide. By contrast, Whitehead was fatalistic. “That’s just the way of things, the ebb and flow of populations,” he said. “I love this place, and, also, I don’t have to live here.” In East Hampton—which his teen protagonist envisions as a land of “pterodactyls wearing ascots”—there’s more privacy, he said, and fewer of the “ghosts and toxic emanations” that he wrote “Sag Harbor” to exorcise.

It was a novel he wasn’t ready to write until he was almost forty. After “John Henry Days,” he began another satire, “Apex Hides the Hurt,” about a “nomenclature consultant” tasked with renaming a small town out West. Yet he felt unable to continue after the [Twin Towers fell on 9/11](#), which he watched from Fort Greene Park. Like millions of New Yorkers, he felt that something had been torn not just from the skyline but from his psyche. “I thought they’d always be there standing over me,” he recalled telling his therapist, who brought him to tears by responding, “Like your parents?”

He pivoted to a book of essays, drawing its title, “[The Colossus of New York](#)” (2003), from one of the sci-fi monsters of his childhood movie nights. They’re playful, intimate sketches, each sentence an errant transmission from the city’s collective consciousness. In the essay “[Port Authority](#),” Whitehead eavesdrops on the dreams of eager new arrivals; in “[Morning](#),” on the unspoken indignities of the daily commute. “You are a New Yorker when what was there is more real and solid than what is here now,” he writes in the introduction. Later, he adds, “New York City does not hold our former selves against us. Perhaps we can extend the same courtesy.”

The slim volume marked the beginning of a transformation, though several years passed before it ramified. In 2004, Fig was born, and Whitehead took the first of several teaching jobs to provide for his family. He struggled to finish “[Apex](#),” which appeared in 2006 to a lukewarm reception. Tired of being a remote puppet master, he began to consider the traditional novel of origins his younger self had eschewed.

We pulled up to a cherry-red bungalow on an exposed cinder-block foundation, with a deck overlooking the bay’s placid expanse. It was the house of Whitehead’s adolescent summers. He climbed its peeling steps to the deck and stared at the water, his back to the door. “Do you want to go

inside?” he asked a minute later, with a resigned, knowing look. I felt like one of the hacks from “John Henry Days.” (But of course I said yes.)



Whitehead photographed in New York on May 12th. “Being precise allows you to make things up,” he says of his approach to fiction. Photograph by Philip-Daniel Ducasse for The New Yorker

Dated brown couches huddled in musty silence. A slender kitchen island, once his father’s liquor cabinet, stood near a refrigerator laden with sun-bleached photo magnets. No one has lived there since Mary Ann died, three years ago; in 1990, she and Arch left New York and moved in full time—for her, the beginning of a glorious retirement, for him, the acknowledgment of a professional setback. His firm had never recovered from the [Wall Street crash of 1987](#), and his heavy drinking continued.

“His anger was a ruling force in my life for so many years,” Whitehead told me, recalling “volcanic” fights over everything from his writing career to the profanity in Prince’s “Sexy M.F.,” which Whitehead dared to play at Christmas. “One day, he was unloading on me, and I was, like, ‘I’m thirty-two. I don’t live here anymore.’ I just walked out.” They stopped speaking.

We walked a few blocks inland to the family's other house, a stolid white saltbox built by Mary Ann's father in the nineteen-forties. In the mid-two-thousands, Whitehead periodically rented the house from an aunt, hosting friends on nostalgic trips that spurred him to write about the place. "It used to be much more secluded," he said en route, as we stepped aside for contractors' trucks and vans. Once there, he led us to the back yard, pointing at a trio of windows above a porch mottled with lichens. It was the bedroom where he and Clarke had stayed in as boys. "He had his blue bike, and I had my yellow one," he said. "We'd set off in the mornings and not come back till the lights came on."

Their childhood's twilight is at the core of "Sag Harbor," which he wrote at the house in 2008. On the surface, it's a Gen X coming-of-age comedy, satirizing the postpubescent neuroses of "black boys with beach houses" in the street-obsessed eighties. Benji, the protagonist, who narrates from adulthood, is fifteen and determined to distinguish himself from the brother who's always been his double. He roams the developments with a group of boys whose priorities include girls, cars, BB-gun fights, and mastering the "assorted field exercises of black boot camp." ("Everybody was faking it," Benji triumphantly concludes after watching two friends fumble a handshake at the beach.) Yet the book is also about the disappearance of time and places, with summer's end presaging more permanent losses. "Ask, How long are you out for? and a cloud wiped the sun," Whitehead writes. "The question trailed a whiff of autumn."

Another cloud is adult dysfunction. Benji's father is a volatile patriarch who grills during blizzards and hits him for failing to manfully respond to a classmate's racist slight. The father is occasionally charming, even tender, but also an alcoholic, whose afternoon cocktails portend such upheaval that Benji learns to play dead when he hears the click of the kitchen island's magnetic lock. When the novel was published, in 2009, Whitehead called it semi-autobiographical. Seventeen years later, he didn't mind admitting that he'd changed little other than the names.

Arch died less than two months before the book's publication. He'd spent a bucket-list year writing in Ecuador, then returned to enter hospice, sick with a cancer that he'd hidden from his children. "I didn't want to be the jerk

who didn't talk to their dying dad," Whitehead said, but when he visited his father he was angrily rebuffed. "He said, 'It's too late to apologize,' and I said, 'I'm not here to apologize. I just wanted to say goodbye.' " Mary Ann signed off on the novel, and Clarke—who, after a series of odd jobs, had just earned a master's in teaching—was touched by how much his brother had remembered. "For me, that book was 'I'm gonna let it all hang out, and it'll be good for me as a writer and as a person,' " Whitehead said, adding that he probably couldn't have written it if he and his father hadn't been estranged. "It was part of becoming a grownup."



"They kept the big house for themselves, of course."
Cartoon by Liana Finck

He was relieved to have written a character so like himself without readers "recoiling in terror." But one person had reacted differently than he'd hoped. For years, he and Stovall had been divided over their future. They split up a few months after "Sag Harbor" was published, and though neither was anxious to discuss the circumstances, an aside in Whitehead's fried-chicken essay hints at the final straw. "I sent *Sag Harbor* to someone who'd read a lot of my previous work, and she was taking her time getting back to me," he writes. The reticent reader turns out to be his wife, who, when confronted, admits that she prefers the protagonists of his other books. " 'You know the main character is basically me, right?' " he asks her. Then,

en route to a reflection on collard greens, he adds, “We’ve gone our separate ways.”

We ended the afternoon with a walk to Sag Harbor’s downtown, a stretch of restaurants and boutiques which terminates in a long wharf. There was the ice-cream shop where he’d worked as a teen, and the century-old grocery store that inspired [a novel by John Steinbeck](#). Whitehead sat down on a bench in front of the Five and Dime, a general store with a red-and-yellow awning. He draped his arm over the backrest and stretched out his legs, looking relieved to have cleared the day’s gantlet. “There’s a lump on my back, and I thought, Maybe it’s my last interview. Do I have any famous words to impart?” he’d said on the walk. “But then I went to the doctor, and he was, like, ‘It’s just a lump of fat.’ ”

Whitehead’s family would be joining him the next day in East Hampton, and he was awaiting an Uber when a man in a hat and shades introduced himself as a photographer. “I’m doing a project on the famous authors of Long Island,” the man said, scribbling down his number. “Maybe we can take some frames?”

Five hundred people had signed up to see Whitehead speak at the Teton County Library, in Jackson Hole, Wyoming, and a few dozen had gathered backstage in its auditorium for a reception.

“Two Nobel Prizes!” an elderly woman exclaimed, clasping the author’s hand in hers. She evidently meant his Pulitzers, but he smiled gamely, telling her that he was “working on the peace one.”

“Congratulations on your literary successes!” another woman said.

“Thanks!” he replied. “I have no hobbies.”

He floated among the tiny tables, nursing a lime LaCroix and picking at finger foods. Some fans wanted to tell him where they’d once lived in New York City. Others expressed surprise that the author of such harrowing novels seemed to radiate inner calm. The vast majority were older white women. (So was the reader who, a week earlier, had seen me on the subway

with a copy of “The Nickel Boys,” and demanded to know why I wasn’t in tears.)

Whitehead took the stage at around seven, rocking at the hips like a boxer readying himself to deliver a quick knockout. “Howdy-do,” he began, to immediate laughter, then embarked on a mock recitation of his life story. “I was born a poor Black child,” he said. “I remember the days sittin’ on the porch with my family, singin’ and a-dancin’ down in Mississippi. Or maybe that was someone else. Steve Martin in ‘The Jerk.’ ”

He continued in that spirit for the next forty minutes. Whitehead has long cultivated a faux-naïve persona in book talks and opinion pieces. At one point, he brought up the Gooch, an A.I. assistant he’d invented for [an essay in the Times](#)—who pings him, he claimed, whenever he loses his butt. He might have made a good comedian, and he briefly considered writing a novel about [Richard Pryor](#), whose portrait he keeps behind his desk. But humor also helps him evade the projections people make about his work. Whitehead has been labelled a “genre bender,” an embodiment of Obama-era “post-Blackness,” and an emissary of “literary Brooklyn.” He has deftly escaped these pigeonholes, in part by insuring that each of his books is radically different from the last. That got harder when he won American literature’s most prestigious awards for back-to-back novels about slavery and segregation.

Afterward, he was asked about race and politics almost exclusively, a narrowing of his work that often chafed. Onstage, he preëmpted such expectations with a joke. “ ‘I thought you said they were bringing that slavery guy,’ ” he said, pretending to be a member of the audience. “ ‘He’s up there talking about Gary Coleman and Neanderthals!’ ”

Whitehead always knew he’d eventually write a “slavery book,” he’d told me earlier. “Everyone does.” But he postponed his for many years. During his divorce, he wrote “[Zone One](#)” (2011), a novel that is set in the shaky aftermath of a zombie apocalypse and follows a crew of bored, traumatized “sweepers” as they purge Manhattan of the remaining undead. Next was “[The Noble Hustle](#)” (2014), a comically abject memoir about competing in the World Series of Poker. In 2013, he was about to embark on a novel

about a Brooklyn writer's midlife crisis when he told Barer, then his fiancée, about an idea he'd had for a literalized Underground Railroad.



"Swim? No, I just meant stand in the water and chat."
Cartoon by Sarah Kempa

Kevin Young had introduced the pair in 2009, at a tenth-anniversary conference for the Portland literary magazine *Tin House*. Two years later, they crossed paths again when a mutual friend's change of plans left them alone together at drinks. "It was clear that he was interested," Barer told me. They bonded over growing up between the Upper West Side and Long Island. Whitehead was also struck by Barer's seriousness about her work as an agent—commitment to one's calling being the signature quality of his protagonists. The trait was on display when he mentioned his idea. "I was, like, 'Please drop everything and write that book!'" she said. By the end of the year, they were married, Beckett was born, and Whitehead was writing "[The Underground Railroad](#)."

The joy of new marriage and renewed fatherhood helped him through the darkest story he'd ever told. Cora, the novel's heroine, is a slave on a Georgia plantation, where she's stigmatized because her mother escaped when she was a child. After her master dies, she, too, runs away, and the heretofore realist narrative takes a speculative turn. She travels via subterranean tunnels and train stations to the Carolinas, Tennessee, and Indiana. Each state evokes a different phase of white supremacy and the unending battle against it, folding events as disparate as the Tuskegee syphilis experiment and the Exoduster movement into a panoramic allegory patterned on "[Gulliver's Travels](#)."

The prose had more fleetness and gravity than anything he'd previously written, while the structure conveyed the ironies of history without the showy encyclopedism that had bogged down "John Henry Days." In one scene, Cora is hired to reenact her enslavement at a living museum. "Old Colson would have been, like, 'Who's the curator? What's the theory?'" he said. "But I no longer had the need to catalogue so thoroughly." The novel's success was seismic. Oprah selected it for [her book club](#); at her compound in Montecito, Whitehead was so nervous that her staff insisted on blow-drying the damp patches of his dress shirt before they were introduced. A few months later, he won the National Book Award for Fiction. The ceremony was just eight days after Trump's election, which, uncharacteristically, moved Whitehead to issue a rallying cry from the lectern: "Be kind to everybody, make art, and fight the power."

Whitehead has never avoided politics; he joined [Zohran Mamdani's inaugural committee](#), and he has weighed in on everything from the way A.I. threatens human creativity to the mistreatment of pro-Palestine activists. Yet he'd always kept political agendas from determining the course of his imagination. Even so, America's latest white-supremacist turn propelled him toward another dark history: the discovery of a mass grave on the grounds of a shuttered Florida reformatory called the Dozier School for Boys. Surviving former residents alleged that rape and torture had been routine there for decades, especially under segregation, when Black boys bore the worst of the abuse.

"The Nickel Boys" fictionalizes their unspeakable experiences. As in "Sag Harbor," Whitehead's subject is a community of adolescent boys, a pair of whom illustrate divergent paths—not, this time, out of paradise but through an inferno. Elwood is a promising, almost unbelievably innocent young man whose pastimes include reading the encyclopedia and listening to Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., on vinyl. He aspires to join the civil-rights movement. Then, after hitching a ride from a stranger in a stolen car, he's sent to Nickel Academy, where he befriends Turner, a boy of similar age whose misfortunes have left him more worldly-wise. Their entwined struggles pose questions about the utility of righteousness in a system of inhuman cruelty, which come to a head, years later, in a dramatic reversal.

Both “The Underground Railroad” and “[The Nickel Boys](#)” inspired screen adaptations, by Barry Jenkins and RaMell Ross, respectively. Jenkins had been pursuing Whitehead since he first read “The Intuitionist,” in 2010. “I was, like, ‘A Black woman is basically Luke Skywalker?’ ” he told me. “ ‘Sign me up.’ ” Years later, [the success of “Moonlight”](#) emboldened him to try for “The Underground Railroad,” and this time he managed to earn the author’s trust. Jenkins lavished attention on the cinematography of his series, which came out in 2021: “We created an entire lighting scheme around the way he described the Great Spirit.” Ross’s film, which came out last year, was shot from the boys’ points of view in colorful hues that belie their situation’s brutality. Whitehead, who’d praised Jenkins’s adaptation at the podium in Wyoming, was evasive when asked about Ross’s. “For me, ‘The Nickel Boys’ is a story of psychological realism, and the adaptation was a little ethereal,” he said. A woman in my row turned to her companion and hazarded a translation: “He hates it!”

Obscured by the film’s unusual perspective is the novel’s third-person remove, which gives space to the question of why one boy makes it out alive and the other doesn’t. Midway through writing “The Nickel Boys,” Whitehead lost his brother, Clarke, who was only forty-eight. Like Arch, Clarke had become an alcoholic, and was unable to shake his addiction even after he found a stable career in teaching. In the years before his death, he was in and out of rehab, relapsing despite his siblings’ efforts to keep him sober.

“Around Thanksgiving in 2017, his landlord called and said, ‘Your brother’s dead,’ ” Whitehead had told me. “I was in shock.”

It fell to Whitehead to enter Clarke’s apartment, above a pizza parlor in Bay Ridge. Since “Sag Harbor,” he had been processing their drift apart through his fiction, and he had already begun to give something of their bond to Elwood and Turner. But, once the medical examiners had left and the necessary calls had been made, Whitehead, alone in his brother’s bedroom, could see that Clarke had never really left their tandem youth. “We did everything together,” he told me, laughing softly as his eyes welled. “And he still had all of our childhood totems, like the poster for ‘Escape from New York.’ He never outgrew them.”

Light filled the uptown 1 train as it climbed onto the elevated tracks. “They were green in the seventies,” Whitehead said of the seats, unlike the orange and yellow of today’s car, itself soon to be retired. As children, he and Clarke liked to press their noses to the windows and look down the tunnels: “Soot would powder us.” In the nineties, he remembered late-night trains where everyone—including him—would smoke, until a police officer put an end to the “cocktail party.” Best of all, he said, was finding himself in a car that was completely empty, as though headed for “some weird ghost-map alternative universe.”

From theoretical elevators to abolitionist undergrounds, Whitehead has always drawn metaphors from the mysterious mechanics of transport. The subway is his urtext, and a key inspiration for his trilogy was the 1974 heist film “[The Taking of Pelham One Two Three](#).” Four men hijack a subway and demand a million-dollar ransom, setting off a chain of events that touches every stratum of city life. Passengers swear and cry in multiple languages; at Gracie Mansion, an unpopular mayor hesitates to address the public for fear of being booed. “Everybody is just, like, an angry New Yorker,” Whitehead said. “They’re sweating and bickering in great outer-borough accents, and there’s a schlumpy existentialism, too.”

His trilogy is, likewise, a straphangers’ gallery of metropolitan oddballs, from Zippo, a pyromaniac turned blaxploitation filmmaker, to Uncle Rich, a master criminal who stages a daring raid on the Waldorf-Astoria from a disused train tunnel with the help of a homeless army. Like “Pelham,” the novels map New York through the endlessly ramifying consequences of crime, which illuminate its workings like radioactive tracers in a monster’s bloodstream. At its heart is one relentless imperative—to rise.



Clarke (left) and Colson Whitehead celebrating Clarke's birthday, in 1990. Courtesy the author

From the 1 stop at 137th, we made our way to Strivers' Row, a stretch of limestone- and terra-cotta-fronted town houses known since the Harlem Renaissance as the most elegant block in the area. Whitehead remembered attending a Jack-and-Jill event in one of the houses: "Considering how run-down the rest of the neighborhood was in the seventies, it was really stark the way they glowed." In the trilogy, Ray Carney and his wife, Elizabeth, raise their two children on the block, just steps from her own childhood home. "After what I put Cora and the Nickel boys through, having someone who could scheme and win and not be totally defeated by racism and capitalism was intoxicating," Whitehead explained. Yet Carney's journey is fraught with Odyssean dangers, which he faces with uxorious determination: "What else was an ongoing criminal enterprise complicated by periodic violence for, but to make your wife happy?"

Carney is not only a clean-cut and charismatic salesman—"If that sofa you're resting on is familiar, Mrs. Williams, that's because it was on 'The Donna Reed Show' "—but the son of a violent criminal. His spectre haunts Carney, particularly because his father's ill-gotten gains were his store's seed capital. His sideline as a fence compounds this unsteady compartmentalization; a bridge between legitimate and illegitimate worlds, he sees his job as facilitating "churn," or the "natural flow of goods in and

out and through people's lives." At the start, he limits himself to helping Black thieves in Harlem sell stolen electronics to the merchants of Radio Row, in the Financial District. But his wayward cousin Freddie constantly inveigles him into more serious mischief. At the end of "Harlem Shuffle," Freddie aids the junkie scion of a corrupt Manhattan Dutch real-estate dynasty in pilfering the family safe, forcing Carney to deal with the aftermath.

The caper unfolds amid the Harlem riot of 1964, dramatizing the differential treatment of impoverished looters and the bigwigs who "notarized their misdeeds or engraved them into bronze plates for building façades." Its climax is a thrilling chase through midtown; skilled at wringing texture from tension, Whitehead makes every close shave an excuse to animate the city, at one point inventing an entire Broadway show—critical reception included—in the time it takes Carney to sprint through its exiting audience. But the novel's spiritual conclusion is the demolition of Radio Row to clear the way for the World Trade Center. "The buildings of the old city loomed over the broken spot, this wound in itself," Whitehead writes. "If you bottled the rage and hope and fury of all the people of Harlem and made it into a bomb, the results would look something like this." The passage echoes Whitehead's response to 9/11, as Carney mourns the neighborhood that the Twin Towers would supplant.

Earlier, we'd cut across St. Nicholas Park, with its steep stone stairs and outcroppings of exposed bedrock. "Atop the unchanging schist, the people replaced each other, the ethnic tribes from all over trading places in the tenements and townhouses," Whitehead writes in the second installment, "Crook Manifesto." It's the nineteen-seventies. New York is bankrupt and Harlem is aflame, as slumlords torch buildings for insurance money in cahoots with politicians pushing "urban renewal." Paralleling this fiery drama is a slower accretion of changes to the city's fabric, which convey an almost tectonic sense of time's passage. For research, Whitehead trawled the front pages of every New York *Times* from the period, read mayors' memoirs and the autobiography of a mobster's widow, and watched strangers' digitized 8-mm. footage on YouTube. "Were they wearing hats?" he said. "How much was a tongue sandwich? For me, that's gold." Realism

and fantasy go hand in hand, he told me: “Being precise allows you to make things up.”

We passed the Harlem Y.M.C.A. at 135th and Seventh—across the street from its original site, where [Langston Hughes](#) once lived. (Whitehead’s next novel, which centers on New Yorkers before, during, and after the First World War, features a character who stays there, though Whitehead declined to say more about the book: “Right now, it’s just mine.”) The trilogy also follows in a long tradition of Harlem fiction, including Chester Himes’s detective novels and the more recent mysteries of Walter Mosley. But they’re even more indebted to Donald E. Westlake, whose Parker novels, under the pseudonym Richard Stark, persuaded Whitehead to write about criminals rather than detectives.

“If Elmore Leonard had been alive, he would’ve fucking loved them,” Graham Yost, the showrunner of an FX series based on a Leonard novella, said of Whitehead’s trilogy. He’s working on a “Harlem Shuffle” adaptation for Apple TV, to be produced by Barry Jenkins, and praised Whitehead’s decision to focus on a small-time criminal. (At one point, Carney struggles to hold a gun.) The pilot will dramatize the trilogy’s opening heist at the Hotel Theresa on 125th, a thirteen-story tower with a striking white façade once known as the Waldorf of Harlem.

“It was really glamorous seventy years ago,” Whitehead said when we reached the building, now an office complex with a White Castle on the ground floor. A neighborhood history marker detailed its glorious past, under the ominous heading “While We Are Still Here.” The eternal question of who belongs in New York comes to the fore in “Cool Machine,” as the slicker but no less corrupt city of the eighties rises from the ashes of burned tenements. The book’s relatively gentrified heists involve the art market, the profitable advent of cable television, and various criminals’ suburban retirement plans—underscored by repeated allusions to John Carpenter’s dystopian thriller “Escape from New York.” The movie’s eye-patched protagonist, Snake, lands a glider atop the World Trade Center, tasked with rescuing a kidnapped President from a city that has descended into anarchy.

Not everyone can “make it here,” at least not forever. The book’s second novella—each installment of the trilogy comprises three—is told from the

perspective of Carney's accomplice Pepper, a stoical enforcer and friend of his father's of whom we had been told, "Any smile that broke out on his face was a mutiny swiftly put down." A brooding sideman in the first two books, Pepper emerges as the most sympathetic character of the third, aging in a city he no longer recognizes. He swigs Pepto-Bismol for relief from what might be stomach cancer. Yuppies have taken over his favorite bar. On the hunt for a stolen African mask, he falls in with a young restitution activist whose arty downtown world seems to him like a foreign country. "What the hell was a Liquid Liquid?" he wonders after a punk concert. "Sounded like the complaint of an angry janitor." It's the New York of Whitehead's CBGB youth, seen through the eyes of a relic from the days of street preachers and dream books.

At last, we reached the northeast corner of 125th and Morningside, where a streetwear store occupied the ground floor of a four-story apartment building. "So here we are," Whitehead said grandly—Carney's Furniture, his hero's hard-won slice of the city. Last year, after a "Harlem Shuffle" walking tour, he happened to pass by the shop with extra copies. "I was, like, 'Here, I wrote about this address in my crime book,' " he said, doing jazz hands and affecting a needy-author voice. At the register, two "twentysomething dudes on their phones" gave him blank, pitying stares. "They were a little wary, like, 'Is this a religious pamphlet?'" He laughed-snorted at the memory. Then he rounded the corner to the building's other side, where a door's outline was faintly visible under thick red paint. It was Carney's side entrance and portal to the underworld, whose inexorable gravity is described as a "sickness drawing everything into itself."

At least in their professionalism, Whitehead's protagonists have always had an element of self-portraiture. But in Ray Carney—a man whose relentless striving brings him only closer to the past—he's invented an unusually perfect double. What's a novel but a big score of details burgled from the world? And what's a novelist but a fence, furnishing imaginary scenes with choice pieces of reality while obscuring their provenance? Over the years, it becomes clear that he does what he does not just for the money, or even for the thrill, but because it makes him part of the churn, a safe for the secrets of a city so quick to change that, as Whitehead writes in "Colossus," "we can never make proper goodbyes."

Near the end of the trilogy, Carney and Elizabeth dine at Windows on the World, the luxury restaurant that once looked out from the North Tower's uppermost floors. It's another reference to "Escape from New York," which Whitehead watches annually in honor of Clarke: "If I don't do it, who will?" ♦

[Julian Lucas](#), a staff writer, began contributing to *The New Yorker* in 2018.

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Shouts & Murmurs

- **[The Pied Piper](#)**

By Simon Rich | The man with the fife was good at getting rid of Hamelin's rats. What, the townspeople wondered, could he do with the children?

[Shouts & Murmurs](#)

The Pied Piper

By [Simon Rich](#)

June 22, 2026



Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

In 1284, the story goes, the Pied Piper visited the German town of Hamelin. He offered the residents a deal: for a thousand guilders, he would rid their town of rats. The townspeople agreed, and the piper began to play a lively tune upon his fife. He lured all the rats from their nests and led them to the river, where they drowned. But, when the Pied Piper asked the people of Hamelin for his fee, they would not pay. And so, to get revenge, he played a new tune on his fife. This time, however, it wasn't the townspeople's rats who flocked to him; it was their children. They danced toward him, unable to resist his haunting melody. He led a hundred and thirty boys and girls out from the town's walls, and they were headed for the river when they passed a McDonald's.

"Can we get McDonald's?" a red-haired boy with freckles asked.

"No," the Pied Piper said, between fife puffs. He assumed that would be the end of it, but the other hundred and twenty-nine children had heard the

word “McDonald’s,” and though they were still dancing—captivated by his wife’s spell—they were also now all begging for McDonald’s.

“There’s no way we’re stopping,” the Pied Piper said. “We wouldn’t even fit inside the restaurant.”

“There’s a drive-through,” said the kid with freckles, whom the Pied Piper was beginning to despise. And the children all chanted “McDonald’s” for so long that the Pied Piper eventually decided that the easiest thing would just be to fucking take them to McDonald’s.

“A hundred and thirty four-piece McNugget Happy Meals and a large black coffee,” he said into the intercom. He turned to the kid with freckles: “Do you realize this puts me in the negative for Hamelin? I was supposed to make a thousand guilders—now I’m down a thousand.” The kid ignored him. He’d already grabbed the first Happy Meal out of the window and was ripping it open with his grimy hands.

“I don’t like my toy,” he said.

“That’s not on me,” the Pied Piper said. “I don’t control which toy comes in which box. It’s random.”

The child began to cry.

“O.K., look,” the Pied Piper said. “If you don’t like your toy, just trade with someone.” But he immediately regretted saying that, because now all the children were running up to him, asking him to adjudicate their trades, like, was it fair to trade a Super Mario figurine for seven French fries, or a sticker sheet for barbecue sauce.

“I’m not the trade police!” the Pied Piper said. And then the freckled kid started to cry again, because he’d traded a Bowser for a McNugget but had since eaten the nugget, leaving him with nothing.

“That’s what happens when you eat something!” the Pied Piper said. “It goes away! That’s how food works!”

And the kid cried harder. A lot of kids were crying, actually. Even though he'd bought them all McDonald's.

The Pied Piper wanted to drown the children more than ever. But they were still miles from the river, and he was getting sick of playing "Baby Shark" on his fife. And so he led them back to Hamelin, where the townspeople were waiting for him—with his thousand guilders!

"Thanks for taking them for a few hours," the mayor said. "It felt so good to get a break. I went to the gym, took a shower. It was unbelievable."

"We had sex," the freckled boy's parents said, looking startled. "Unplanned. It was like being on acid. We just did it spontaneously. Then we cleaned our kitchen for the first time in a year." And a lot of other townspeople said a similar thing: that they had used the time to clean, because their homes were filthy.

"That's probably why your town had all those rats," the Pied Piper said.

"What rats?" the mayor said.

"The ones I lured away," the Pied Piper said. "Remember? Yesterday?"

And the townspeople confessed to the Pied Piper that they had such mental fog from parenting stress and sleep deprivation that they were losing the ability to form memories.

"If you don't remember hiring me," the Pied Piper said, "then what's the thousand guilders for?"

"We want you to be our regular babysitter," the mayor said.

"I don't think I'm qualified," the Pied Piper said. "I'm a ratcatcher. I also just tried to murder all your children using magic."

"O.K., two thousand," the mayor said. The Pied Piper agreed, and the parents were so happy that they stayed up singing and dancing until 9 *P.M.*

Most people believe that this story is just a myth. It's impossible, they say, that the people of Hamelin could have lucked into such an affordable babysitter situation. Because, if you do the math, it works out to, like, fifteen guilders a kid. And he's luring them out of town, which means they're getting exercise. And there's music, too, so it also counts as enrichment.

We'll never know if the Pied Piper truly came to Hamelin. But if you visit today you will see a stained-glass window depicting two middle-aged parents having unscheduled sex in the afternoon. Some say it really happened. And, if that's true, who knows? Maybe, just maybe, it could happen still. ♦

[Simon Rich](#) is the author of the Broadway play "All In: Comedy About Love," and his books include the story collection "[Glory Days](#)."

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Fiction

- **[“The Readers”](#)**

By Ben Lerner | It would be one thing if I wrote fiction about Cromwell or aliens, but, given that my protagonists resemble me, how could I know you weren’t mixing us up?

[Fiction](#)

The Readers

By [Ben Lerner](#)

June 21, 2026



Illustration by Jack Smyth

Early in my treatment, we decided that you wouldn't read my work. If you had an intense reaction to my writing of whatever sort, I'd worry it might influence how you related to me, but if you were more or less indifferent to it, I would feel devalued, misunderstood, rejected. Your response, from my perspective, could only be too much or too little, and I'd always suspect your feelings about my writing, no matter how effectively you concealed them, had bled into your questions, your silences, your advice. And all these problems are heightened by the fact that my books involve biographical material, altered versions of my formative experiences, traumas, fears, contradictory desires (I always want too much and too little). It would be one thing if I wrote fiction about Cromwell or aliens, but, given that my protagonists resemble me, how could I know you weren't mixing us up?

You've always maintained that you don't believe that reading my work would actually influence how you relate to me, but that I'd always wonder if it did, which would have its own effects. And besides, you've said more than once, what's important is that I bring the "raw material," the complex of emotions and desires and inhibitions *behind* my writing, into our sessions; that's better than your reading my edited attempts at mastery. (Is that what this is?)

It didn't take long for us to agree that this structure of feeling—the sense that everything is too much or too little, that the only options are overwhelming intimacy or abandonment, that you can only merge with a person or be rejected by them—characterized many of my relationships, especially with women. We've traced this to childhood experiences, particularly, of course, with my mother. "Have you read my mother?" I remember blurting out, as I scanned your shelves, during our initial consultation, one of three we'd scheduled to determine if we were a "good fit." (Hearing myself ask this question, I thought of that classic children's book my kids loved where the baby bird goes around asking other animals—and various inanimate objects—"Are you my mother?" I hate that book.) What would it mean for you, you responded, if I have or haven't read her work?

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

When you were recommended to me by a friend of a friend, both of whom are novelists, I Googled you and learned that you're British, that you trained at the Tavistock, and that you're a writer, too. Your web page lists a few short stories and works of "creative nonfiction." I resolved never to read them.

But then I thought: I'll give in eventually, I'll be too curious at some point, I have no self-control, and so I decided I should look in advance of starting treatment, just to make sure there was nothing obviously disqualifying about your writing. I know all sorts of brilliant people who are bad writers; it must be possible for a brilliant therapist to be such a person, and yet I felt that if your prose were horrendous it would make it impossible for me to trust you.

One night, as Charlotte slept beside me, I furtively opened an essay of yours on my phone. Neither "reading" nor "skimming" is the word for what I did; I was both looking at the language and trying to protect myself from it; I was attempting to engage these things you'd made (and made available to everyone) from a great distance with the hope of confirming only that they did not cross whatever threshold would make our relationship impossible.

The essay was published in a magazine called *Thirteen Ways*. It was about your complicated pregnancy in lockdown; there was a long passage about goldfinches. I wasn't attracted to your sentences or repelled by them; it was good enough prose (the way Winnicott speaks of the "good enough mother"). I decided to make an appointment, although I was slightly uneasy about a therapist publishing such personal writing online, where her patients might find it.

During that first consultation, after I explained the problems—insofar as I understood them then—that had brought me to therapy, and after I inquired if you'd read my mother, I asked if you knew my "work," making the barely perceptible pauses around the word which indicate scare quotes. You responded, of course, by asking how I would feel if you did or didn't know it, how I thought that might affect my treatment, should we decide to continue. I said I'd feel fine about your reading or having read my poems, but that I was conflicted about the novels. And yet, I said, because I don't have any sense of myself apart from my writing, banning it from therapy

feels weird, withholding, dishonest; I wouldn't be showing up with my "full self," to deploy a cliché. (Reading me or not reading me: a catastrophe either way.) You were quiet for a long moment, probably while you decided whether you would answer my question with another question, and then you said: "I've read some of your poetry, but I've never read your fiction."

I'd thought that might be the answer I wanted, but I'm ashamed to tell you—which is why I'm only telling you here—that I felt rejected, or at least deflated. I thought a psychologist around my age interested in literature living in New York would have read at least one of my novels. I must have had an exaggerated sense of the reach of my literary reputation. But you had books by my friends and rivals among the psychoanalytic texts on your shelves. It seemed improbable to me that you hadn't at least tried to read some of my prose. "I've never read your fiction" must mean "I find your fiction unreadable." Surely you had started one of my stories in this magazine—which is among the magazines in your waiting room—and then *abandoned* it?

Podcast: The Writer's Voice

[Listen to Ben Lerner read "The Readers."](#)

If we do agree to work together, I asked, would you then read more of my writing, past and future? Would it become a topic of discussion; might it in some way inform my treatment? You said that was something we'd talk about over time, something we could "play with"; we could explore what your reading or not reading my work (no implied scare quotes when you said it) meant for me, or would come to mean. Certainly you weren't going to read further in advance of those conversations, and, should you encounter writing of mine in a magazine in the interim, you would simply "look away." (I doubt you actually used the phrase "look away," but I vividly remember your using it; I've come to realize that what I remember most vividly is often false, the way the hyperreality of a deepfake might be the tell.) You explained that you didn't have a general theory of whether a therapist should or shouldn't read her patient's writing: "It's something that needs to be decided on a case-by-case basis."

This "case-by-case" talk troubled me—not in the moment, but on the F train home; it was usually on the F that something you said began to trouble me

—because I took it to imply you had many other writers as patients, each a special “case.” Maybe your patients were mainly writers; maybe you were steeped in the literary demimonde, which would damage our treatment, make it impossible, because so much of what I needed to address was my confusion about boundaries, a confusion in part traceable to the milieu in which I grew up: my parents are both shrinks and all their friends were shrinks and everybody was in therapy with their friends or enemies or supervisors. My earliest sense of therapy was that it was troublingly porous, that nobody was holding the frame, keeping the wrong things from touching (I was a kid who wouldn’t let distinct foods touch on his plate, a weak attempt at mastery), which was why I was only now, in my late forties, truly entering therapy.

I badly needed you to hold the frame, in other words, and to teach me how to hold the frame, but you probably had—I decided on the F—various poets and novelists as patients, and we’d know one another or at least of one another and talk about one another and pollute one another’s treatment, because I believe a therapist’s relationship with one patient must invariably bleed into her relationship with the next.

When I brought this up to you in our second consultation, how the “case-by-case” talk had made me concerned that your practice involved too many writers, too much overlap and possible contamination, you assured me that none of your patients knew me personally—but how could you be sure? It would have been a boundary violation to ask them—and that, if we ended up working together, you would not take on anyone with whom I had an arguably significant relationship. You understood how that would compromise my treatment, especially since, as was already quite clear, the question of boundaries is intense and overdetermined for me in ways we would explore. I was reassured.

On the F, I was troubled. It was *too much*—too much that you would decline to work with anyone I might know, who might know me, too much that you would adjust your practice to protect me from this worry. I took it as an implicit admission that, if I did have some relation to another of your patients, their speech would seep into my treatment. Worse, I feared (insanely) that your willingness to make such a promise might reveal that

you were overinvested in me. Maybe you'd read my mom's books and they mattered so much to you that you desired, consciously or unconsciously, to have me as a patient? Or maybe you hated her books and wanted to punish her through me? Or maybe you had read much more of my work than you'd admitted and you loved it or hated it and so you were willing to alter your practice in order to entrap me because I was the object of your cathexis—your cathexis would smother me, it was a kind of inappropriate touch, just as your seeing lots of writers would be. Either way, it was a catastrophe.

Third consultation: I brought up my concern that your making decisions about whom to see based on protecting me felt like too much. You explained, almost successfully suppressing a smile, that you were describing a general policy of not taking on clients who know one another. You suggested that these worries I had about reading and not reading, too much and too little, contamination, bad touch, holding the frame, and so on, were things that you could help me with, help me investigate and get a handle on. You also suggested that these strong reactions and forms of resistance I was experiencing in response to the prospect of embarking on therapy might in fact bode well for our work together. Indeed, perhaps we'd already embarked? It was then I decided to confess that I'd looked at (and away from) some of your own writing, but could not.

Do you remember (of course you remember) how I believed that I'd told you all about my aortic root, about the potentially aneurysmal dilation of my aorta where it attaches to my heart, something that had been incidentally discovered fifteen years before I became your patient, and how I was startled and upset when you revealed your ignorance of my medical situation. "This is the first I'm hearing about this," I recall you saying. "Can we slow down and start again at the beginning?"

By this point, I'd been coming to you for nearly a year and I was convinced that I'd given you this medical history early on and you'd failed to retain it. In reality, I'd never mentioned it, which was in part a sign of how much I'd accepted my cardiologist's reassurances that, given my aorta's stability across the years, it was less and less likely I'd ever need an intervention, let alone drop dead from aortic dissection. Now I believe my confusion also arose because I wrote a novel in which this aortic pathology (and the

prospect of death or open-heart surgery) is central, and, though you'd of course told me that you'd never read my novels, I must have still felt on some level that you *had* read them, and from those fictions had extracted central facts about me, and so, according to some magical and distorted logic, by failing to remember my ambiguous cardiac condition, you were forgetting my life and my literature simultaneously, which was annihilating.



Cartoon by Chris Gural

I probably unconsciously withheld all this medical information so I could stage this particular version of abandonment—withheld it until my cardiologist told me that there were some new tests that could help distinguish aggressive aortic pathologies from idiopathic and often benign conditions, and that I might as well go ahead and do the tests for peace of mind. Given so many years of stable measurements, he felt the results would be reassuring, but I was anxious, and mentioned the testing to you, which turned out to be the first time I'd brought any of this up. Anyway, all they needed to do was swab my cheek, and in a couple of weeks my mind would be at rest.

And in a couple of weeks my mind was shattered. You know the specifics; I shouldn't put them here. Suffice it to say, the results meant, among other

things, that my aorta was almost sure to dilate further, and, regardless, I was at a heightened risk of it rupturing even at a relatively small and stable measurement (stable until it suddenly, catastrophically, wasn't). In light of this information, the cardiologist ordered new imaging, CTs and MRAs with contrast, not low-res 2-D echocardiograms. Thus they discovered that all my previous measurements had been radical underestimations, that I had been walking around for fifteen years with a massive aortic aneurysm well past the surgical threshold—that what I'd feared might happen in the future had long been my present. In response to all these tests, these horrendous redescriptions of my vascular tissues, I collapsed.

You would stop me here and say: You continued to parent well, even in the worst moments; you managed endless appointments with radiologists and cardiologists and surgeons; you convened a wonderful community of support, and so on. You would want me to say even in this fiction you can't read (at least without compromising my treatment, breaking our contract) that I did not utterly collapse. Despite my suffering and episodes of mental disorganization. I did not throw myself in front of the F, even though I fantasized constantly about stepping in front of it as it entered the station at West Fourth, if only it could look like an accident, or like I'd been pushed.

The instant I'd clicked on the results from the swab, our work together changed. No more exploring my conflicting desires and their origins, my versions of Eros and Thanatos, my ambitions and tendencies toward self-sabotage, my complaints about my marriage ("Charlotte doesn't respect my 'work'!"), my tendency to ask both humans and objects, "Are you my mother?," my ambivalence about therapy itself, etc. No, now therapy was about how I might get through the next few hours, survive the night. In the session before I clicked on the test results, we'd talked about how hard it was for me to cry, how I'd certainly never been able to cry in therapy and probably never would; in the session after—and in so many sessions after—I wept convulsively. I remember much of this in the third person, can see myself begging you between sobs to reassure me that I'd be here to watch my boys grow up, which you did. I longed for my old problems, but they belonged to another world; certainly I was now utterly unable to recall caring about something as trivial as whether you had or hadn't read my books.

I think you supported me by simply—but why do I say it’s simple—being able to *take it*, by witnessing and receiving all my upset and terror, and by accompanying me, by making me feel accompanied without losing your composure as I unravelled; although sometimes your color altered and your face would flush red when I was in extremis, your expression remained otherwise unchanged. During that time we not only saw each other several times a week, but you also had me write to you every morning, something I never imagined I’d be doing. I would extract myself from bed and take my beta-blockers and write you a message of despair and you would write back within an hour, write something simple and steadying. “I hear how hopeless you’re feeling, but there is every reason to be hopeful, and I can help carry hope for you right now, even if you can’t access it. I will see you in the office on Tuesday, but call me if you need to speak to me before that.” I don’t know why these messages helped me, but they did, at least a little—and a little help in such moments is a lot.

Once the surgery was scheduled, I began to stabilize. It was grounding to have a concrete plan in place; it helped that Charlotte and I had talked calmly to the kids and they weren’t as terrified as I’d feared, that we’d managed to hold the terror for and from them; it of course helped that I felt the full force of my skilled and loving “team” of doctors, friends, and family. I began to have some moments when I watched the wind move in the leaves and felt, for minutes at a time, no agony. I dealt with the bureaucracies of insurers and universities; I managed to look through proofs of a couple of essays I’d written when I was still capable of writing; I rescheduled events far into the future as if there were one; I put my will and financial documents in order; I made sure that I was laughing around the kids at dinner; I made sure that I was eating dinner; I deleted manuscripts and most of my e-mail correspondence, which only now strikes me as parasuicidal; I told everyone I loved how much I loved them. I was afraid of dying or never fully recovering and I was horrified by the intense and well-documented depression that often follows significant heart surgery, a postpartum-like condition known as the cardiac blues, but, in the final session before the surgery, when you said that even if I experienced such a depression, you and my “team” would help pull me out of it, I think that I believed you. You said that soon I would be on the other side of this, and that I would write about it. I recall you said that I would write about it

“beautifully,” but you have no way of knowing if I’m capable of writing beautiful prose.

At the appointed hour, they opened my chest, placed me on bypass, arrested my heart, cut away my diseased aortic root but preserved my native valve, which they sewed into a Dacron graft, from which my coronary arteries now branch, then the graft was joined to my ascending aorta and they restarted my heart, closed me up. Something like that.

Two and a half weeks after the surgery, I wrote an essay about my experience. It was published almost immediately in this magazine. The issue in which it appeared featured an illustration of a human heart on its cover, which I thought of, which I still think of, as an image of my heart. I was proud of this work, no scare quotes: it felt real, whatever that means, and it felt like getting it all down quickly was quickening, on the side of life, part of my survival and early recovery, proving I didn’t have permanent cognitive deficits from the bypass machine (now I’m much less sure), proving that I was still (or for the first time?) able to take the full measure of life with language. In my imagination, writing and publishing the piece was a defense against the cardiac blues.

You and I resumed our sessions in the second week of my recovery, processing the “controlled trauma” of the surgery by phone since I was in pain and exhausted and far from capable of taking the F, but after seven weeks my profoundly changed body returned to your office near West Fourth, and I found myself carrying a copy of the magazine with me, a little security blanket made out of words. As I tentatively reentered the world, I would often reread the piece as if to prove to myself the reality of what I’d gone through, the fact that I’d survived. I was part Frank O’Hara—“My heart is in my / pocket, it is Poems by Pierre Reverdy”—and part that guy in “The Magic Mountain” who carries his chest X-ray with him at all times, showing it to everybody, saying, I can’t believe they touched me *there*. (I remember this character vividly, so I might be making him up.)

At some point I realized that I was also coming to your office with my heart piece in my tote bag because I wanted to give it to you. This felt different from what we’d discussed long before my diagnosis and crash, different from my poems or novels; this was a work of nonfiction—even if I made up

some composite figures—this was describing the care I received and the resilience I hoped I was evincing, and was documenting a still unfolding experience in which you played a role. I found it easy to bring this all up in a session—more evidence, I reasoned, that my desire to give it to you was unproblematic. I didn't feel that your reading it might be too little or too much; I wasn't interested in tracking your response; I just wanted to share this work that I felt captured—insofar as it was capturable—what I'd gone through. And perhaps, I suggested, this calm, clear feeling constituted progress? Maybe, in this small way, I'd defeated the structure of too much or too little?

You didn't say, "No, I'll never read it," but you did say that we should slow things down: "We should take our time talking about the experience and not its representation," a distinction I wasn't sure I could really make. "Let's keep talking about what it all means." The fact that I didn't treat your hesitation as rejection—not even on the F after that session—reaffirmed my sense that you *should* read the piece eventually, as clearly I'd overcome, at least in this instance, my neurotic relation to your relation to my writing.

Several sessions passed without my mentioning the heart piece again, though it was always rolled up in my bag. Needless to say, there were plenty of other things to talk about given what I'd been through, was going through. I was seeing you fewer times a week now, and was no longer wanting to die on the tracks; I was capable of more various thoughts and feelings. But, as sessions passed, I began to feel, precisely because I was exhibiting such maturity around the heart piece, that it was a little unfair or ungracious of you to refuse it, and by refusing to accept the essay—even if we never talked about it again—weren't you refusing to recognize my progress?

One night, while Charlotte slept beside me, I realized in a flash, with the force of insight: I shouldn't be asking for permission as if I were a child. I must just give you the magazine. You could read it or not, we could talk about it or not, but I wanted to present it to you, full stop. Surely you would approve of my owning the decision, exercising my agency, something we often discussed. In fact, it was possible this was precisely what your hesitancy was intended to produce—the conditions in which I would be

forced to act decisively, to present it to you and then let it go. I needed to rise to the occasion you'd helped prepare for me.

I intended to do this immediately upon entering your office at our next appointment, for it to be the first thing I did upon sitting down, but you had a scheduling question for me, and then we found ourselves talking about other things, and the clinical hour evaporated, and so it was only when our time was ending that I found myself reaching into my bag.

I opened my mouth to eloquently inform you of my decision but instead I heard myself mumble something about my progress as I rose from the chair. I had never walked toward you before; the exit was to the right of where I was seated. But now I was suddenly—suddenly but slowly—lurching toward you like some kind of Frankenstein, like Frankenstein O'Hara with his heart in his hand and not his pocket, this monster whose heart had so recently been arrested and re-started. I involuntarily recalled all the tubes and wires I'd been attached to in the hospital, imagined they were trailing from me as I blundered toward you like an axe murderer, wielding an axe that bore the image of my heart, violating your personal space, violating so many kinds of space, saying weird shit about agency, about ownership. Something had been set into motion that I was powerless to stop; I wanted to flee the office but couldn't alter my path. There was nothing to do but close the distance between us and give you my heart piece or bludgeon you with it, but as I finally drew near—only seconds had passed, but it felt like I'd been approaching you for minutes, like I'd been approaching you for forty-seven years—you raised both of your hands, palms toward me. I froze. I stopped, as they say, dead in my tracks. The blood pounded in my ears. While your expression remained calm, your face flushed red. You said, "Let's wait and talk about it on Friday. Please hold on to that for now." Right, I said, of course, and fled.

We didn't talk about it Friday, or the following session, or for several weeks, but I found myself reflecting on the fact that I had made a scene, staggering toward you as our session expired, confused about what I was doing, and I assume your silence was intended to spur such reflections. I could see how my behavior was "expressive," undercutting the notion that I had an uncomplicated relation to your reading (or not reading) my heart

piece, but I wondered if you hadn't produced some of the complexity by refusing to accept it graciously when you'd first had the chance—which was refusing, among other things, to mark my arrival at the other side of the surgery, to see how I'd converted suffering into writing. If it was too much to have walked toward you with the magazine, I was driven by your failure to take it in the first place, which was too little.

By this time, I was trying to write a new story, a story unrelated to my heart—although what doesn't involve the heart—but whenever I tried to get down to work I'd find myself looking up from the page or the screen, distracted by the image of your raised palms: you were stopping me—stopping me from making life and work despite the diagnosis. Yes, O.K., we needed to revisit the conversation about reading or not reading, and I perhaps needed to account for why I came toward you in that disorganized manner, but surely you also had some reflecting to do: Might you, via your inability to receive the heart piece, be expressing your unconscious resistance to my treatment, our exchanges, expressing ambivalence about the very question of exchange, what I'm allowed to give, what you can take? Maybe you were unconsciously sending me the message: “I can't take it.”

And that's why, when I did finally return to the topic of my fumbled attempt at delivery, I framed it in a perhaps not entirely neutral way, by saying in one session, as if I were the therapist and you were a recalcitrant patient, “I was thinking we should revisit your refusal to accept my essay,” which made you laugh.

“Laugh” is too strong a word: you made a sound, a very British sound, which I took to be a clipped laugh, an almost successfully stifled laugh, although I guess it could have been more a noise of acknowledgment, of mild surprise plus interest, but it was at least laugh-adjacent. A while passed before you said anything, and then you asked: “Why do you want me to read the essay?”

I found this question—its willful naïveté and simplicity—exasperating. Do you have amnesia? How could this require further explanation, let alone starting over from the beginning? I'd collapsed, you'd seen it, you'd helped me, I'd had open-heart surgery, remember, did you need to see my

sternectomy scar, the exit wounds from the chest tubes, do you need me to unbutton my shirt right here and show you? I walked into the operating room on my own two feet and I survived the surgery and I wrote it all down, I got it down in writing in the midst of pain and arrhythmia, the heart piece was part of me, writing was the better part of me, writing it was part of getting better, everybody on my “team” had read it, etc. But all I said was:

“What do you mean, why do I want you to read it?”

“I mean just that: Why is it important to you that I read this particular piece? That we revise our agreement?”

“This is different.” I suppose my speech in therapy tends to be abbreviated, the opposite of my writing.

“Can you tell me again why it’s different—why it’s different from, say, giving me a copy of your new novel?”

“You want me to repeat all the reasons? For one thing, it’s short, it’s nonfiction.”

“Say more about why it matters that it’s nonfiction?”

“But we’ve already talked about all this.”

“It’s happened more than once that you think you’ve told me something or explained something to me when in fact you haven’t. And then you feel dropped when I don’t have it in mind. And I don’t want to make assumptions here. So I think it’s worth—”

“It’s documentary. I want you to know what it was like.”

“But you can tell me what it was like. And the feelings that come up as you tell me might be more important than my reading your essay, where you already gave it shape.”

“Why can’t it be both—why can’t you both accept this piece of writing and we talk?”

“I’m interested in this word ‘acceptance.’ What I can accept from you, but also, perhaps, your own process of accepting the reality of all—”



*“Which do you want to hear about first—the moons of Jupiter or who I can see naked through this?”
Cartoon by Sophie Lucido Johnson and Sammi Skolmoski*

“You don’t even have to read it, I just wanted you to take it, to have the option.”

“What would it do for you if I took it, accepted it, but didn’t read it? Didn’t exercise the option of reading?”

“It’s a gesture.”

“And I’m suggesting we unpack the meaning of the gesture.”

“I feel like the presumption is all wrong here. Why is the burden on me to explain why I would want to share something so obviously important? Isn’t it on you to explain— Why isn’t the burden on you to say—” My face felt hot.

“Do you think of yourself as burdening me? That there’s a limit to what I can take?”

“No.” Yes.

“There is nothing you can say in our sessions that’s too much for me.” That sentence was too much for me. “What I’m putting pressure on is the notion that your writing should get between—”

“O.K., let’s forget it.”

“What’s the ‘it’ we’re forgetting?”

“That I wanted to—” You had confused me. I started scanning your bookshelves as if something there might help. “I don’t know why I’m getting emotional. I guess I just wanted—”

Here you made a silence that was the sound of the frame itself.

I vaguely remembered the opening passage about how they turn brown and gray in winter, how you thought they must migrate, while in fact they’re here all the time; they molt and change color in spring, their seasonal color shift is extreme, so you were waiting for the goldfinches to return when they were already here.

The essay says you have a small back yard, so I assume you live in Brooklyn, probably near Green-Wood or Prospect Park, given the bird traffic you describe. Although maybe this was when you lived in London? I’d never encountered the phrase “warbler fallout” before. The first time I was only sampling your sentences, to see if they were good enough, but now it’s hard not to project myself into your building, to float over one of those curved metal balcony railings on Twenty-third, for instance, and look at the toys strewn on the white carpet and the books on your shelves and the frames on your walls. (See the Frankenthaler print.) It is hard not to open the fridge, closets, and medicine cabinets, to see how you live, what circulates inside your house and body, to know too much. Weird that you have the same slowly rotating mobile above the crib—those bird silhouettes in warm colors—that we used to have in our kids’ room. We put it on the street one spring; maybe you picked it up.

Then your husband walks right through me. He has earbuds in, I think he’s speaking Korean, he sounds anxious, he’s putting on a black KN95 and leaving the apartment in a rush. I wonder what’s in his bag, what small

comforts you asked him to bring. Do you know the feeling when someone passes through your watery presence in the little waking dream of reading, overreading? I wasn't sure it could still happen now that my aorta involves plastic, but it does.

I don't know if all that time ago I had stopped reading or if I repressed what I'd read: that you gave birth during lockdown and that your baby needed surgery. The implication is that the problem involved the heart. Maybe a hole? Charlotte's colleague has a child who had that repaired a few months after birth. But if they operated immediately things must have been critical, especially given that the hospitals were overrun.

You write that they told you that her lungs were the size of plums, that her heart was the size of a walnut (the heart of a goldfinch is the size of a lentil); you don't specify what they had to do, maybe to protect her future privacy or yours, maybe it didn't involve the heart at all, maybe they were just draining fluid with a needle, which is routine, but, in my fiction, the procedure is open. And even if I'm briefly in the O.R.—they're playing soft cello music—I'm not going to look, I'm not going to breathe on anything, there's no risk of contamination. I can tell us apart; she's not my daughter; I'm not your son.

At the end of your essay, things seem O.K.: a babbling toddler helping you put the Nyjer seeds into the feeder. But I'm thinking about your color, the few times it changed when I described all that I was sure would go wrong with my surgery, all the permanent damage I feared, when I enumerated every possible catastrophe in my panic. I'm remembering how that day, before I approached you with the magazine, you'd had to talk to me about scheduling. Maybe you had to take your daughter for her scans? Sometimes the effort to keep things from touching causes vasodilation of the small blood vessels in the face. But I don't know and don't need to know. I've come to understand your gesture differently, how you stopped me with your palms. "Please hold on to that for now"—what a beautiful thing to say. You stopped me so that I'd go on. I left it on the train. ♦

[Ben Lerner](#) is the author of the novel "[Transcription](#)," among other books.

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Why the Odyssey Keeps Defeating Filmmakers

Full of violence, desire, monsters, and magic, Homer’s epic has tempted directors for decades. Can Christopher Nolan’s new adaptation survive the voyage?

By [David Denby](#)

June 21, 2026



In preparation for the Sirens’ song, Aldo Pini ties Kirk Douglas to the mast in Mario Camerini’s 1954 schlockfest, “Ulysses.” Photograph from Cola Images / Alamy

In Book XIII of [the Odyssey](#), which is both the most familiar and the strangest of great epics, Odysseus comes home at last. After ten years at war and ten more at sea, he is borne back to Ithaca by his gracious hosts the Phaeacians, who have feasted him and delighted in his tales. They lay him in the stern of a ship, where he remains through the voyage in a sleep “like death,” and unload him with great delicacy:

They disembarked, and lifted from the ship
Odysseus, wrapped up in sheets and blankets.
They set him on the sand, still fast asleep.
They unpacked all the presents he was given
by the Phaeacian lords to take back home,
Thanks to Athena's care. They heaped the things
beside the olive tree, so no one passing
would do them damage while their owner
was sleeping. Then they rowed away back home.

A tired warrior needs his goods, but most of all he needs sleep. Homer's homecoming epic is full of such lovely touches. The poem that precedes it, [the Iliad](#), is a cruel and beautiful work, the ultimate story of war; the Odyssey has its warlike passages, but its central energies seem almost commonplace beside the merciless fury of Achilles. In Ithaca, Odysseus' wife, Penelope, is besieged by insolent young men, freeloading suitors who want her to choose one of them. Homeless, his body torn, Odysseus needs to get back to her and Telemachus, his anxious son, and to clean up the mess. Along the way, when he's lucky, he enjoys hot baths, a proper bed, carnal companionship, and gut-busting meals of spitted sheep, cow, stag, or pig. Few great works have been so devoted to physical pleasure and pain.

Odysseus is a warrior with wit and intellect, a con man and fabulist who constantly reinvents himself. Yet this complicated man wants only what any of us would want after terrible troubles—recovery and consolidation. Perhaps that is why he is the most beloved of heroes, and his story the most imitated of forms: a model for James Joyce's word-drunk one-day Dublin epic, "[Ulysses](#)," but also for "The Wizard of Oz," for Charles Frazier's "[Cold Mountain](#)," and for countless other works, large and small, of adventure and return. The three-thousand-year-old poem is always with us, and always distant from us. The chaos in Ithaca may be political and ethical—a violation of custom—but stretches of the poem are barbarous and wild, beyond civilized life altogether. The foundational coming-home story is also the birthplace of science fiction and of horror. In the Odyssey, you swim for miles or drown at once; you attain knowledge or lose your mind; you eat or are eaten. None of Odysseus' men make it back to Ithaca with him.

At the moment, the media is awash with storm-tossed boats and tufted bronze helmets. Christopher Nolan's version, which reportedly cost two hundred and fifty million dollars and stars Matt Damon as Odysseus and Anne Hathaway as Penelope, opens on July 17th. I haven't yet seen it, and I wonder: Do we need a big movie of the Odyssey at all? Filming it is like filming the Bible, or "[Huckleberry Finn](#)"—books so closely woven into us that some part of us doesn't want to see them externalized as spectacle. The epic has been adapted many times, but the stiffness of most attempts makes one wonder whether the difficulties aren't insurmountable. In recent years, Nolan has produced pop-sadistic fantasy ("[The Dark Knight](#)"), self-referential movie puzzles ("[Inception](#)," "[Tenet](#)"), and real-world political and scientific drama ("[Oppenheimer](#)"). He likes to take chances, but he is now competing with a masterpiece in another form. It's a death-defying risk.

Nolan and the cinematographer Hoyte van Hoytema, wielding heavy *IMAX* cameras, shot their picture across the Mediterranean and beyond, in caves, castles, beaches, black-sand wastes, and open water. Nolan seems to be striving for geographic realism interspersed with violent and fantastic episodes. A spectacular travelogue with thrills, however, will not be enough. We want some equivalent to what Homer provides—not just a sense of awe at natural and supernatural events but also a profound realization of the physical sensations of men and women. And maybe we want something harder to articulate: a movie that answers the needs of a sorely troubled national culture. The Odyssey has stuck around for three thousand years in part because every era takes what it wants from it.

The problems begin with the gods. What to do with them? Leisure-world swells, lustful and violent, they play favorites, altering the appearance of those they love, punishing those who have injured them. Athena, the goddess of wisdom, protects Odysseus, but she promotes mayhem and at times seems more interested in power than in any human being. Nolan has indicated that he mainly kept the gods off camera, signifying their presence through nature, yet he has cast [Zendaya](#) as Athena. Good luck to her: gods do not come off well in movies. In "L'Odissea" (1968), an eight-part Italian TV miniseries, conversations among Zeus and the other gods were heavily intoned offscreen, while the camera, in a series of jerking zooms, landed on

statues of the immortals—highbrow kitsch. In “The Odyssey” (1997), an American TV series directed by the Russian Andrei Konchalovsky, Hermes, the messenger god who advises Odysseus on how to handle the temptress Circe, is a barely clothed young man butterflyflying around the Aegean. The gods belong to poetry, not to cinema.

Every filmed version of the poem takes on the sea god Poseidon, who is furious at Odysseus for blinding his monstrous one-eyed son Polyphemus (a.k.a. the Cyclops). In retaliation, Poseidon whips up the ocean, shredding sails, cracking oars, sweeping Odysseus and his men overboard. We’re eager for whirlpools and squalls, for “white calm” and mists. Homer does great weather. Yet Nolan has often expressed his [wariness of C.G.I.](#), which is the easiest way of roiling the elements. In the past thirty years, weightless digital imagery—exacerbated algorithms contending in nowhere space—has invaded everything from grand adventure stories to late-night commercials for S.U.V.s. Reality, in movies, has become fungible; nothing stays itself. Nolan’s distaste is palpable, up to a point. The visual distinction of his [Oscar-winning “Oppenheimer”](#) was enhanced by his sparing use of C.G.I. (The test detonation at Alamogordo was a real, non-nuclear explosion.) As he has recently remarked, he likes to work “in camera,” using sets, miniatures, and puppets—traditional special effects—before, inevitably, the C.G.I. boys get to work repainting the image.

When Odysseus and his men are trapped in Polyphemus’ cave, they blind the Cyclops with a red-hot stake—the sharpened end of an olive tree. The scene is discomforting in any version. How to make the moment scary but watchable, disgusting but entrancing? Homer at his most explicit can be unnerving. In Book XII, navigating between the twin female menaces Scylla (a six-headed sea monster who eats men) and Charybdis (a whirlpool who swallows ships), Odysseus loses six crew members:

. . . In agony they cried
to me and called my name—their final words.
As when a fisherman out on a cliff
casts his long rod and line set round with oxhorn
to trick the little fishes with his bait;
when one is caught, he flings it gasping back

onto the shore—so those men gasped as Scylla
lifted them up high to her rocky cave
and at the entrance ate them up—still screaming,
still reaching out to me in their death throes.

Agony is hard to watch in a movie. As for the simile of the little fishes, the cinema can hardly match it; the medium is mostly wedded to what it shows. An image may resonate with deeper meanings (that's what great directors can bring about), but the compression and displacement that make the simile devastating on the page have no cinematic equivalent. Sometimes poetry leaves the cinema behind, gasping for breath.

Ravenous nymphs, cannibals, spirit-draining drug peddlers, the shadowy dead with their sorrows and rages: all threaten manhood, or life itself. Earlier movie versions have managed the story's most frightening moments with the limited technology available at the time—much plastic and spongy stuff; monsters in process shots looming over little men; papier-mâché boulders flung from hilltops. With ready sympathy and the best will in the world, we are forced to complete the magic in our minds.

The film “Ulysses,” from 1954 (“Ulysses” being Odysseus’ Roman name), has Kirk Douglas’s overwhelming zeal, his big chest and big teeth, but not much else. At times, the movie almost turns into the sword-and-sandal Italian schlock of the late fifties. “L’Odissea” is much more serious. As the camera roams the ruins of Troy, we get a stern historical lecture, followed by heavily populated scenes of actors standing around talking or gazing out to sea. The moviemaking is faithful, literal, and dead. The actors speak their own language (“I feel responsible for their lives—do you understand, Circe?”), which was then dubbed into the language of the countries where the series played. Dubbing universalizes mediocrity.

The 1997 American TV series was at least beautiful—a plenitude of sea, air, rock, and beach. And blissfully material, too: pewter and clay, burnished swords and golden flesh. The thickset Armand Assante was a phlegmatic Odysseus, but Greta Scacchi, as Penelope—who has so little to say in the poem—became the physical embodiment of anger, and Isabella Rossellini was a teasing Athena.

The most recent version, the nearly wordless, extremely violent “The Return” (2024), with Ralph Fiennes and Juliette Binoche, dispenses with gods and monsters altogether and gives us Odysseus as a ruined man: gaunt, silent, washed ashore like debris, barely able to account for himself. A silent Odysseus? He’s the chattiest man in literature. “The Return” is a fashionably severe reduction of the poem, but it links up with the kind of analysis that can be found in the writing of the psychiatrist Jonathan Shay, who has worked extensively with Vietnam veterans. In his books “[Achilles in Vietnam](#)” (1994) and “[Odysseus in America](#)” (2002), Shay asserts that Homer’s heroes suffer from a form of P.T.S.D. he calls “moral injury”: the shame of having witnessed or taken part in acts that violated their conscience. P.T.S.D. produces fear; moral injury produces guilt. All of these men, in this view, have experienced a collapse of “social trust,” which would explain Achilles’ withdrawal from the community of warriors and Odysseus’ habitual trickiness and dissimulation, even with his own family.

But moral injury, formidable as the idea is, doesn’t apply to Odysseus, who suffers from neither shame nor guilt. He weeps over his men who have died, but what he feels is grief, the misery of bereavement. Dr. Shay, I believe, has focussed on the wrong patients: the Greek warriors in the epics are rarely troubled by conscience, and the audience for their exploits did not expect them to be good; it expected them to be hardy and ruthless. The question is which Odysseus Matt Damon will give us—a man who has suffered damage and acts strangely, or a man whose violence is inseparable from the ancient code of honor that makes him a hero.

Adaptations of the Odyssey are always fleshy affairs, with half-naked men lying happily or forlornly on beaches. Going through earlier versions provides an archeology not only of special effects but of gym-bunny culture developing through the decades. Earlier suitors were sometimes flabby; the crew was not always in tip-top shape. But in “The Return,” for all its austerity, the suitors are so muscular that they could have been cast in a London CrossFit. By necessity, Matt Damon and Anne Hathaway also submitted themselves to the rituals of transformation. In his mid-fifties, Damon eschewed gluten and did many pullups. Hathaway does three-minute planks and eats lean proteins. Filmmakers can be as high-minded as

they like, but they must display the idealized bodies of warrior and queen or the story loses its aura of splendor.

Every adaptation violates Homer, but it's worth remembering that adaptation was essential to creating the poems. Of [Homer's existence](#) there is no possible assurance. Was he one poet? Or two, each writing an epic, the first fierce and concentrated, the second world-embracing? Or was there no master poet at all? There is general agreement that, in the seventh century B.C.E., itinerant oral performers, later known as rhapsodes, entertained private and public audiences by reciting heroic histories and myths from an earlier age, when men were braver and women more beautiful. The poems still bear the marks of that world and its oral delivery: repeated epithets, stock scenes, formulaic phrases, and rhythmic units that helped a singer summon the next line while holding an audience in thrall. Playing to the house in front of him, cutting here, embellishing there, each rhapsode reshaped what he had received. The bards were the first adapters.

In the sixth century B.C.E., the Athenian tyrant Pisistratus turned the Panathenaea into a grand civic festival, with public competitions in athletics, music, and the making of beautiful pots; he sponsored contests among bards, too. I would like to believe that the tyrant said, "We can't have these fellows reciting different versions at each performance. Let's get the thing written down." He was, in effect, a studio executive, demanding a locked script. Three centuries later, the librarians of Alexandria took charge of the text, collating competing versions, marking doubtful lines, imposing a measure of order on the teeming verses. Their heroic labors produced the versions that, copied and recopied on papyrus and later on parchment, arrived at last at a printing press in Florence. In 1488, the Odyssey became a book. The survival of the epics feels at once overdetermined and magical. They rise from the past, unappeasable and unstoppable, like one of Homer's fantastic creatures. Perhaps a two-hundred-and-fifty-million-dollar movie is simply the most skilled, extravagant, creatively inspired (crazy, one hopes) event in the sequence.

Since the fifteenth century, most adaptations of Homer have taken the form of translation, which has never been easy. Homer wrote a very long line of poetry—dactylic hexameter, with its six beats, and as many as seventeen

syllables. Daniel Mendelsohn, the most recent translator of the *Odyssey*, preserves that scheme, writing a detailed, luxuriant, often beautiful line. Nolan, however, has seized on Emily Wilson's celebrated 2017 [translation](#). As poetry, some readers may prefer Mendelsohn's version, but for a movie made now Wilson's seems the natural choice. She compresses the poem by about thirty per cent, writing a much shorter line, and produces a version—the one I've been quoting—that is direct, clear, tough-minded, even bracing.

Wilson strips away the heraldic formality of earlier translations and brings the dialogue closer to contemporary speech, in ways Nolan has reportedly drawn on. The dialogue in Homer adaptations has always been an excruciating problem for filmed adaptations. The story is legendary, and told in verse; if the characters onscreen speak to one another in Jersey Shore or Standard Southern British, say, they bury the project in absurdity. It's a Scylla and Charybdis affair: speech that is grand and stately is laughable on camera; speech that is too present-day comes off as [a "Saturday Night Live" parody](#).

Wilson also makes plain the power and property arrangements of Greek "palace societies," like Ithaca. She calls the housemaids in Odysseus' palace "slaves." Ithaca a slave society! However modernized in language and attitude, the *Odyssey* can never be carried fully into our world. It remains distant from us in its insistence on hospitality as an absolute moral commandment, and in its extreme ruthlessness in war, where victorious armies kill the defeated men and carry off the women and children. And, of course, in the literature of the West, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* unfurl the proud banner of patriarchal order.

Consider, among other things, the inequality of pleasure. On the island of Aea, Odysseus encounters "beautiful, dread Circe," a minor goddess with pharmaceutical powers. She drugs his men and turns them into pigs. Odysseus makes a bargain with her: if she swears not to destroy his manhood, and if she turns the swine back into men, he will join her in bed. Which he does, for a year, while the men sit around feasting. Later, he lands on the luscious island of Ogygia, where the nymph-goddess Calypso reigns amid alder, poplar, and scented cypress. It is the most sensual episode in the

poem: “A ripe and luscious vine, hung thick with grapes, was stretched to coil around her cave.” Odysseus spends seven years under Calypso’s spell. When we see him near the end of his captivity, in his twentieth year away from home, he is sitting on the shore, where he “wept sweet life away, in longing to go back home, since she no longer pleased him.” Yet he still performs dutifully at night.

The enthralled husband enjoys the sexual companionship of women, while Penelope remains chaste, fending off the suitors with tricks and sheer denial. Homer approves equally of the man’s satisfactions and the woman’s chastity. But is it cynical to wonder how badly Odysseus wants to get home? Is it implausible that Penelope is more than a little inconvenienced by her years of celibacy? In “Ulysses,” Kirk Douglas looks miserable when he is captured by Circe, and his misery is deepened by the movie’s one smart idea: Circe and Penelope are played by the same beautiful actress, Silvana Mangano. Douglas looks tormented, though he does give in. It is hard for an actor to convey dismay and delight at the same time. Will Matt Damon suffer in his captivity, or enjoy it? Suffering in bed might look strange, even perverse.

For the past thirty years or so, feminist scholars and critics have returned insistently to the two epics, and their work helped make Wilson’s translation possible. Her version restores to the poem what many earlier translations softened or disguised: the brutality of power and the costs of heroism to those who serve its imperatives. It also makes clearer how much the poem already understands. All those female mouths and caves! Circe and Calypso, for instance, are fantasies of pleasure and captivity, projections of men’s fear of losing control; Odysseus’ abandonment of them is part of his return to command. Wilson’s achievement is to bring these meanings forward without flattening the poem’s strangeness or grandeur.

Under this light, Penelope emerges as exemplary, cunning, wounded, and trapped by the male order that praises her. In “[The Penelopiad](#)” (2005), Margaret Atwood, the author of “[The Handmaid’s Tale](#),” gives us a Penelope speaking from beyond the grave. Her voice is sour, derisive. Her girlhood in aristocratic Greece, it seems, was a sordid farce: “I was handed over to Odysseus, like a package of meat. A package of meat in a wrapping

of gold, mind you.” The marriage is a kind of tepid suburban arrangement; Odysseus won’t shut up after sex. This Penelope is knowing, gossipy, disabused. While Odysseus is gone, a story drifts back to her that the Cyclops was actually a “one-eyed tavern keeper . . . and the fight was over non-payment of the bill.” Atwood’s demystifying wit is sometimes fun, though it has its cost: legend and heroism shrink, and the epic’s wild poetic pleasure shrinks with them.

Relying on Wilson, Nolan may have produced a feminist Odyssey, but the text, however argued with, cannot be thrown overboard. Penelope may look at first like the original trad wife, but Homer makes her intelligent, guarded, and manipulative, almost as wily as her husband. When Odysseus returns to Ithaca, he moves through the kingdom disguised as a ragged old beggar, with Athena’s help, testing his servants and his wife, who seems not to recognize him. Or is she only pretending? Is she teasing him, holding herself back, devising a test of her own? After twenty years apart, their extreme wariness feels absolutely right. It also presents a challenge for Nolan, Damon, and Hathaway. Working close in, the actors could produce a heartrending, second-by-second progression of fear, denial, suspicion, awareness, and perhaps, finally, joy: a recognition of each other and of themselves. The cinema may be king after all.

Joyce told his friend Frank Budgen that Ulysses was the most complete man in literature: “Hamlet is a human being, but he is a son only. Ulysses is son to Laertes, but he is father to Telemachus, husband to Penelope, lover of Calypso, companion in arms of the Greek warriors around Troy and King of Ithaca.”

Yet he is not always, in current moral terms, a good man. As a movie hero, he fits awkwardly into the popular culture of the past decades, especially that of the multiplex blockbuster: the “Star Wars” franchise, the Hogwarts enterprise, a dozen or more Marvel movies, and just about every other series in which good forces fight against evil forces. The good guys versus the bad guys—that’s the “moral” basis of modern commercial mythmaking. Yet it was not the way of the older cultures, and particularly not of the late Bronze Age Greek civilization that produced the stories of Troy and its aftermath. One of Homer’s greatest strengths is his evenhandedness, his

palpable sympathy for both sides of a conflict. In an [essay](#) in *Aeon*, Catherine Nichols noted that “neither Achilles nor Hector stands for values that the other side cannot abide.” They are Greek and Trojan warriors asserting themselves, not protecting civilization.

In Ithaca, the suitors have been eating up Odysseus’ livestock and harassing his wife for years. Undisguised at last, and with help from Athena, Telemachus, and a few loyal servants, Odysseus kills them all, a hundred and eight men. In Greek terms, they have persistently violated the laws of hospitality, and they deserve to die. Odysseus also gives the order to kill twelve young house slaves who have been sleeping with the suitors. Although Homer does not say so, enslaved women in a royal house would scarcely have had the power to refuse male visitors, even so surly a bunch as the suitors. Yet Telemachus, a young man of perhaps twenty, and hardly an authority on sexual matters, hangs the women with a ship’s cable. Which leaves Christopher Nolan with two enormous difficulties: How do you stage the slaughter and execution as movie spectacle without producing revulsion, and, even more centrally, how do you portray Odysseus? We cannot, to be sure, simply impose our notions of good and evil on an ancient aristocratic warrior culture. But a slaughter of all the men, without distinction among them? Easy moralizing would be wrong, but moral indifference might be impossible. In the Greek world, honor isn’t tethered to morality. Order is restored not by the triumph of values but by a man, neither good nor evil, doing terrible things.

On Ogygia, Calypso makes Odysseus an extraordinary offer: if he will stay with her, she will grant him immortality and eternal youth. He refuses, choosing to return to his aging wife and to the certainty of death. If Socrates is the intellectual hero of the ancient world, and Jesus the spiritual hero, Odysseus—hardened, brutal, grief-struck, determined to reclaim his home—is the human hero, the whole man. He accepts death, and that’s one reason he remains essential to us. Nolan faces the challenge of creating a hero for the multiplexes who is ruthless and at times cruel. The audience faces the even greater challenge of accepting a man far more complicated than any superhero of recent years. What’s called for in successfully adapting the *Odyssey* is a great director and—how else can one put it?—a movie audience capable of courage. ♦

[David Denby](#) is a staff writer at The New Yorker. His books include “[Eminent Jews: Bernstein, Brooks, Friedan, Mailer](#)” (2025) and “[Lit Up](#)” (2016).

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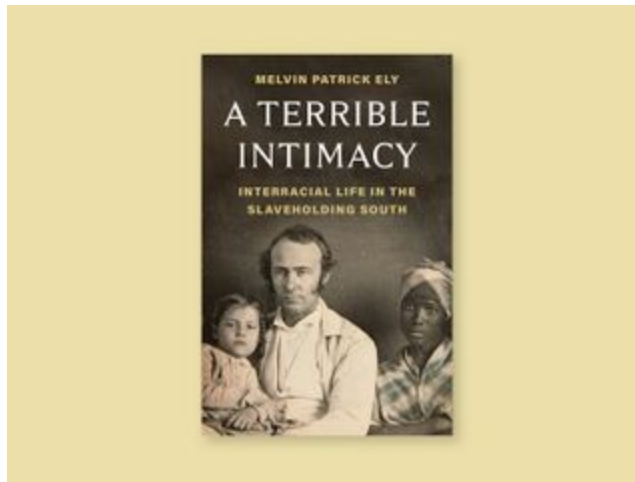
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[Books](#)

Briefly Noted

“A Terrible Intimacy,” “This Is Not About Running,” “The Summer Boy,” and “The Children.”

June 22, 2026



A Terrible Intimacy, by Melvin Patrick Ely (Holt). This history, by a Bancroft Prize winner, analyzes six trials that took place in Prince Edward County, Virginia, between 1825 and 1861, illuminating the complexity of interracial relationships in the slaveholding South. Ely calls upon a wide range of sources to illustrate the ways in which physical proximity between enslavers and enslaved people created “crosscurrents of community life,” including moments of recreation, socializing, trade, and sex. His most compelling observations arise from smaller details he teases out of the trials’ testimony, which capture the texture of the everyday—from how people travelled at night to the manner in which they kept time.



This Is Not About Running, by Mary Cain (HarperCollins). In the U.S., running is a sport marked by the achievements of female teen-age prodigies, who set impossible records and then disappear. In this memoir, Cain, arguably the greatest high-school runner of all time, recounts how her success led to bullying from teammates and their parents and online attacks from men who dissected her prepubescent sex appeal. She also details the abuse she faced at the hands of Alberto Salazar, the now disgraced former head of Nike's distance-running program, whom she left her high-school team to work with when she was sixteen. As Cain describes her decision to walk away from the sport, the book becomes a rejoinder to the fifteen-plus years of vitriol she faced during her career.

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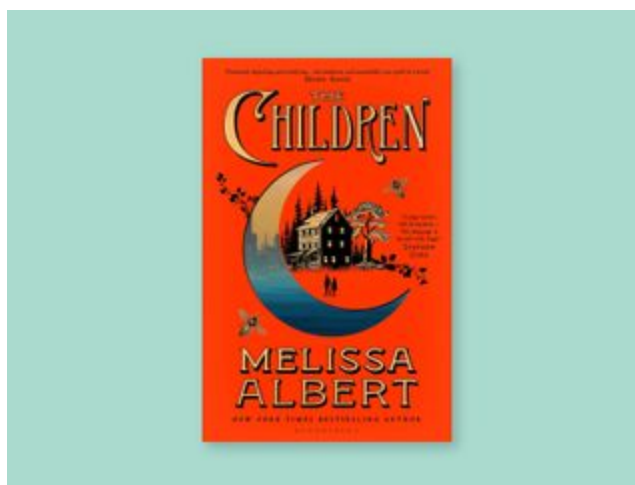


Illustration by Henri Campeã

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The Summer Boy, by Philippe Besson, translated from the French by Sam Taylor (Scribner). “I have a feeling that nothing will ever be the same again, that my adolescence is over,” the eighteen-year-old protagonist of this bildungsroman, Philippe, remarks as he and his parents descend upon the island where they summer each year. Though the terrain is familiar, uncharted interpersonal dynamics emerge among Philippe and his vacation friends as they navigate budding love and the sense of imminent loss. Philippe observes that he and his cohort are “so preoccupied with our own pleasure, our own worries” that they often fail to heed other people’s “distress signals.” For the first time, Philippe and his peers face the consequences of their egocentrism, and begin to understand “the darkness of the human soul.”



The Children, by Melissa Albert (Morrow). As this lightly speculative novel begins, its protagonist, Guinevere Sharpe, has just published a

memoir about being the daughter of an enigmatic children's-book author, who died before she could complete a celebrated series of novels about a shadowy figure who extracts children's dreams to create fantasy worlds. The launch coincides with news that Guinevere's brother, from whom she has long been estranged, will soon open an art installation titled "Mother" at a gallery. Albert's prose sometimes strains for lyricism, but the mysteries embedded in the novel—creative, familial, and supernatural—exert a powerful draw.

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[Books](#)

What's the Point of Sex, Anyway?

The world's life-forms reproduce sexually in a bewildering variety of ways, even though scientists still aren't sure why they bother.

By [Elizabeth Kolbert](#)

June 22, 2026



Across the natural world, reproduction takes forms that are ingenious, perplexing, and often brutal. Nature is long on precedent, and short on moral instruction. Illustration by Lydia Ortiz and Patrick Rafanan

Darwin found sex a mystery. He was perplexed not by the practice—he and his wife, who also happened to be his cousin, had ten children—but by the point of it. Darwin spent the last part of his life experimenting with plants, and he was particularly intrigued by cowslips, whose flowers come in two very different forms. Each form can fertilize itself, yet each requires the services of the other in order to be, in Darwin's words, "perfectly fertile." Why should nature insist on such "intercrossing of distinct individuals?" he asked. And why bother with sex at all, when, via processes like budding or fission, it was evidently possible to multiply without it? "We do not even in

the least know the final cause of sexuality,” [Darwin lamented in a paper](#) he published on cowslips in 1862. “The whole subject is as yet hidden in darkness.”

In Darwin’s day, of course, the processes by which gametes are formed and then fused had yet to be discovered. As more was learned about genes, chromosomes, and meiosis, [the mystery of sex](#) only deepened. In the nineteen-seventies, the British evolutionary biologist John Maynard Smith [wrote an entire book](#) about the puzzle. In it, he proposed a thought experiment. Suppose a chance mutation in a species granted a random female the ability to reproduce all on her own, through parthenogenesis. (Many lizards do, in fact, reproduce this way.) This single mom would give birth only to daughters, who would produce only daughters, and so on. By dispensing with sons and lovers, the tribe of sexless females would double its rate of reproduction and so, quite quickly, take over. Maynard Smith labelled this the “twofold advantage of parthenogenesis”; it’s often, more provocatively, referred to as the “twofold cost of sex.” Given the math, sex must confer some important advantage. But what is it?

Among the possibilities Maynard Smith considered is Muller’s ratchet, a theory named for the Nobel Prize-winning geneticist Hermann Muller. According to Muller’s ratchet, sex persists because it counters the buildup of damaging mutations. Another theory—the Red Queen hypothesis—argues that the big advantage of sex is that it helps species stay one step ahead of their parasites. The so-called tangled-bank hypothesis holds that sex allows for a more efficient use of resources: genetically diverse offspring have broader tastes and so don’t all compete with one another. The wonderfully named Vicar of Bray hypothesis posits that the genetic mixing that comes with sex enables species to adapt more quickly to environmental change. All of these theories have a certain appeal, yet all have been found wanting. Maynard Smith confessed that, like Darwin, he was flummoxed: “On the most fundamental questions—the nature of the forces responsible for the maintenance of sexual reproduction and genetic recombination—my mind is not made up.”

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Recently, the study of sex has undergone a sexual revolution of its own. Sex's history, its forms, and its uses all turn out to be far stranger and more various than biologists had imagined. And what's been learned about the birds and the bees (not to mention the baboons and the beetles) has, in turn, given rise to a new sort of natural-history book, one so racy that it would have made Darwin raise a bushy eyebrow.

["On the Origin of Sex: The Weird and Wonderful Science of Reproduction"](#) (Basic), by Lixing Sun, is among the latest entries into this indecorous yet edifying genre. Sun, who is a biologist at Central Washington University, begins his story with a protozoan called *Tetrahymena thermophila*. *T. thermophila* are tiny—just a twentieth of a millimetre long—yet can reproduce two different ways: by splitting themselves in half or, when they're starving, by engaging in a kind of proto-sex called conjugation, in which two cells briefly fuse and swap genetic material. The protozoa come in seven distinct "mating types," which means that there are twenty-one possible pairings. "That's one wildly complicated dating pool for a single-celled organism!" Sun observes. He includes a photo of two *T. thermophila* caught in the act; the creatures, magnified many times, look like hairy jelly beans that have started to melt into each other.

Lots of organisms engage in conjugation, and not a few of them enjoy multiple erotic options. The common white-button mushroom—the sort found on grocery shelves—comes in eighteen mating types, the fairy inkcap mushroom a hundred and forty-three, and the split-gill mushroom an astonishing twenty-three thousand three hundred and twenty-eight. In organisms that reproduce via the union of types—this group also includes yeasts and slime molds—partners are functionally equivalent and the exchange of genetic material is symmetrical, an arrangement called isogamy.

The way Sun tells it, the shift from isogamy to sex as we know it began with a cheat. Some “crafty” creature figured out a way to game the system by skimping on its reproductive contribution. A two-sided scramble ensued. On the one hand, an edge could be gained by pumping out ever smaller, nimbler gametes; on the other, there was an advantage to be had in manufacturing fewer, larger gametes for the small fry to vie for. Eventually, Sun writes, “a minor size gap” turned into an “uncrossable divide.” The “go-smallers” evolved into sperm-makers; the “go-largers” into egg-bearers. (In humans, an egg has something like ten million times the volume of a sperm; among large birds, like ostriches, the ratio can run to the hundreds of billions.)

Evolutionarily speaking, organisms serve their gametes rather than the reverse. Since eggs represent a big investment, it stands to reason that females should be picky about their partners. For males, the difficult part is gaining access to eggs, which are always going to be in short supply. Here it helps to be flashy or aggressive or both, a pressure that’s widely expressed across the taxa. Male cardinals sport bright-red feathers, male three-spined sticklebacks bright-red bellies. In any number of species—elephant seals, red deer, rattlesnakes—the privilege of mating is settled by a fight. In some species—lions, for instance—only one male and his closest buddies get the chance to sire offspring. When the alpha is dethroned, his replacement typically does in his predecessor’s cubs so that the females in the pride will breed again. Mountain gorillas behave similarly; when a new male takes charge, he frequently kills the babies fathered by the previous silverback. Infanticide, Sun writes, is “surprisingly common, especially among carnivores and primates, often driven by the brutal logic of mate competition.”

Sun lays out the pattern, but he is at least as interested in those species in which the stereotypical sex roles are flipped. Take, for example, jacanas, also known as Jesus birds, which are waders found in the tropics. In most species of jacana—there are eight in all—the males sit on the eggs and the females do the murdering. Not infrequently, a female jacana will kill another bird’s chicks, mate with the male who was tending them, and leave him to raise a new clutch. “Cold?” Sun writes. “Absolutely. Effective? You bet.”

Neotrogla is a genus of bark lice native to Brazil. The lice live in dry caves and feed predominantly on bat guano. Male *Neotrogla* produce capsules of sperm, known as spermatophores, which also contain a protein-rich fluid. Even for a louse, it's tough to make a go of it off bat shit. And so female *Neotrogla* have evolved a penis-like appendage, which they poke into their mates and use, like a straw, to suck up spermatophores, thereby combining sex and snacking. There is so much competition for spermatophores among females, Sun reports, that it "often leaves males with little time between copulations."

Nathan H. Lents is a biologist who teaches at John Jay College, in New York. In "[The Sexual Evolution: How 500 Million Years of Sex, Gender, and Mating Shape Modern Relationships](#)" (Mariner), he reads the long history of coupling as a fable for our time. Specifically, he contends, the current surge in [sexual experimentation among humans](#) is best seen as a biological throwback, a "rediscovery of the much more expansive relationship with sex" that "other animals enjoy."

Lents opens with the example of clown fish, of "[Finding Nemo](#)" fame. Clown fish, which hide out among the tentacles of sea anemones, live together in tight-knit, highly regimented groups known as queues. Every queue has exactly one female, who is the biggest fish in the group and runs the show. Next in line is her mate. He's the second-largest fish and the group's only sexually mature male. The rest of the fish are stuck, Peter Pan-like, in a state of arrested development. If a queue loses its female, it rearranges itself. Her partner undergoes a sex change and takes on the role of the breeding female. His position is assumed, in turn, by the largest of the immature fish, who, thanks to the tragedy, finally gets to grow up. Were "Finding Nemo" true to life, when Nemo's mother is eaten by a barracuda, his father, Marlin, would begin to transition. By the time Marlin and Nemo are, at long last, reunited, the change would be complete, and, in the absence of a larger male, Nemo would mate with his now-female father. "It's probably a good thing that Pixar wasn't striving for biological accuracy," Lents observes.

Clown fish, which are known as sequential hermaphrodites, obviously challenge the notion that sex is fixed. So, too, do simultaneous

hermaphrodites, a collection of creatures that includes most species of land snails, slugs, and earthworms. When two earthworms hook up, they arrange their body parts for mutual insemination—the annelid version of sixty-nining. The sex can last for hours, and though it may be fun for all involved, it's also a test. Sometimes, a worm will offer sperm but refuse to accept it, presumably because it has found that partner wanting. (Why waste valuable eggs on a vermicular loser?) “One might have thought that one giant annoyance that hermaphrodites are exempt from is the ‘battle of the sexes,’ ” Lents writes. But, “alas, they are not so lucky.”

There is no generally accepted definition of gender in the biological sciences, so Lents crafts his own, adapting ideas first proposed by Joan Roughgarden, a professor emerita at Stanford and the author of [“*Evolution’s Rainbow*”](#) (2004). Animal genders, Lents suggests, are “patterns of behavior” that are “tied to reproduction.” By this definition, a great many species exhibit some version of gender fluidity.

Consider the sunfish. Bluegill sunfish are common to lakes east of the Rocky Mountains. They are about ten inches long, with flat bodies, dark eyes, and angry, underslung jaws. According to the heteronormative version of bluegill courtship, mating season begins when males start building nests—basically, bowl-like depressions in the lake bed. When a female spots a nest she fancies, she rubs up against the nest-builder and deposits her eggs. While she’s laying, he squirts sperm in the eggs’ direction. He then defends the nest until his offspring are ready to swim off.



“All I do is wake up, play word games on my phone, go to work, and go to sleep. Then the games reset, and I wake up and do it all again.”

Cartoon by Ali Solomon

But not all bluegills swing the same way. Rather than build a nest to attract a female, some males woo other males who have already built nests. The process involves a writhing dance that looks a lot like the dance that male and female sunfish perform with each other prior to breeding. Once two males are bonded, they hang out together until a female shows up. If she's game for a throuple, she releases her eggs and both males release sperm. "Given two nests of equal quality, females actually prefer to mate with a partnered duo over a male who is working alone," Lents reports. There is yet another kind of male, known among ichthyologists as a "sneaky mater." This type dispenses altogether with nest-building and partnering and simply darts around squirting. By Lents's reckoning, bluegill sunfish come in four genders, one of which is female and the other three male. "This rainbow of reproductive diversity is part and parcel of what it means to be a sunfish," he writes. He believes that sunfish, whose habits have been well studied, are closer to exemplary than exceptional: "The general trend in animal behavior is that every species that we observe thoroughly is way more complicated than it appears at first blush."

["Poking the Squid: What We Can Learn from Animal Sex"](#) (Norton) might be described as a work of graphic graphic nonfiction. Its author, Perrin Roosevelt Ireland, is an artist and an environmentalist (and also a great-granddaughter of F.D.R.). She opens her opus with a drawing of herself gazing through binoculars. Nearby, two spotted hyenas go at it. "Well, would you look at that," Ireland quotes herself saying.

Spotted hyenas long baffled naturalists. Aristotle debated whether they were hermaphrodites, though, in fact, there are no hermaphrodites among mammals. The confusion was due to the hyena's anatomy. Females sport elongated clitorises that look like penises, and fused labia that resemble testicles. In order to have sex, a female must retract her clitoris into her body. "Think about turning a sock inside out," Ireland writes, quoting a Canadian biologist named Carin Bondar. Lacking a vagina, hyenas use their clitoris as a birth canal. Studies have shown that up to ten per cent of first-time mothers die in childbirth, as do more than sixty per cent of firstborn cubs.

“Poking the Squid” captures many species engaged in sex, the more outré, the better. Bedbug intercourse is technically known as “traumatic insemination.” Male bedbugs don’t bother with vaginal penetration; using a sabre-like appendage called an aedeagus—the arthropod equivalent of a penis—they simply stab females in the abdomen. Male fruit flies use their aedeagi to pierce their mates’ vaginal wall and inject peptides into their bloodstream, possibly to reduce their interest in other mates. Dragonfly males are so importunate that some females play dead to avoid their advances. Others change coloration to look male, becoming a kind of third sex. “The percentage of the population that has the third sexual type has to remain below a certain threshold, otherwise the males catch on,” Jessica Ware, an entomologist at the American Museum of Natural History, tells Ireland.

Darwin comes in for a good deal of ragging in the panels of “Poking the Squid.” He is chided for his opinions on race and for believing that women have less brainpower than men. Ireland proposes that [Darwin’s views](#)—and the views of the many male biologists who followed him—skewed the study of sex for more than a century. “Science is never outside of culture,” she observes. For her part, Ireland relies almost exclusively on women scientists. Often, the work she cites shows that, as with the color-changing dragonflies, females have evolved ingenious ways of resisting male aggression. Mallard drakes, for example, are notorious rapists: even though the ducks pair up for mating season, up to forty per cent of their sexual encounters are coercive. Male mallards have long, corkscrew-shaped penises; in response, females have developed vaginas with cul-de-sacs into which unwanted sperm can be shunted. Even if female mallards “are being forced to copulate,” Patricia Brennan, a biologist at Mount Holyoke, says, “they have evolved a system to maintain sexual autonomy.”

Just as biologists long overlooked (or downplayed) female agency, so they overlooked (or downplayed) widespread evidence of queerness. Same-sex behavior has by now been observed in species as varied as field crickets, Humboldt squids, garter snakes, and Japanese macaques. Ireland reports that at least fifteen hundred species are known to [engage in same-sex behavior](#), often shortened to S.S.B., and probably this says more about how many species have been closely observed than it does about the prevalence

of the behavior. Of the twenty-two mammalian species that are the subjects of long-term field research, S.S.B. has been observed in eighty per cent.

From a narrow Darwinian perspective, same-sex behavior appears at least as perplexing as sex itself. To the extent that it's genetically encoded, it would seem hard to pass on, and if all the members of a species engaged exclusively in S.S.B., then that species would, in short order, cease to exist.

But seen through a wider lens, S.S.B. is a lot easier to explain. A growing body of research shows that animals have many reasons to have sex with one another besides procreation. They do it to promote social cohesion, to fool rivals, to gain favors, and—surprise, surprise—for the sheer joy of it. [A 2019 paper](#) in the journal *Nature Ecology & Evolution* which Ireland cites argues that the prevalence of S.S.B. across the phyla suggests it must have emerged as early as sperm and eggs. The authors of the paper propose that the very first male and female animals engaged in “indiscriminate sexual behaviour,” and that this anything-goes attitude proved adaptive enough to persist through the ages.

One of the ways that people have tried to police sex is by labelling some acts “natural” and others the opposite. In the English-speaking world, “crimes against nature” were long understood to include oral and anal sex, along with bestiality. For centuries, such infractions carried heavy penalties; in England, well into the eighteen-hundreds, “the vice of buggery” was, on paper, punishable by death. (The last execution for the vice, of James Pratt and John Smith, took place at Newgate Prison in 1835.) Today, statutes outlawing “crimes against nature” remain on the books in several American states, though these laws are now unenforceable in cases involving consenting adults.

It is hard to read “On the Origin of Sex,” “The Sexual Evolution,” and “Poking the Squid” and still believe that there are forms of sex that offend nature. If there's a configuration you can think of, almost certainly some other species has beaten you to it, and there are many creatures out there whose sex lives test the limits of the imagination. Take, as a final example, the triplewart seadevil anglerfish. When a triplewart seadevil male locates a female, he burrows into her flank and hijacks her circulatory system. From this point on, he will not leave her side. Having nowhere to go and no

reason for sight, he will slowly go blind. Quite literally, he and his mate will become one.

To varying degrees, Sun, Lents, and Ireland are writing against the sex police. The vast array of mating strategies that have evolved, Sun observes, provide “a wealth of evidence” for “breaking down biases.” Ireland closes her book with a drawing of herself in a submersible, surrounded by sea creatures, including an anglerfish, who, in word bubbles, say things like, “You, too, have a role to play in pushing back against harmful, reductionist rhetoric about what’s ‘natural.’ ” Lents writes, “Since *diversity wins* is one of the overarching lessons of life on Earth, who are we to argue?”

Lents takes the diversity thesis one step further in a long and fascinating section devoted to the mating habits of *Homo sapiens*. Here, too, the range of behaviors is stunning. The Kreung people of northeastern Cambodia build huts for their adolescent daughters to use for erotic liaisons and encourage them to have as many of these as possible before choosing a husband. The Simbari people of Papua New Guinea’s eastern highlands separate boys from their mothers around the age of nine. The boys spend the next several years interacting only with the tribe’s men, on whom they are expected to perform fellatio repeatedly. (The Simbari, Lents writes, “believe that boys are not born with semen but instead must imbibe it.”) In some parts of the Himalayas, parents marry off their oldest son; then, when his younger brothers come of age, they join the marriage and share the wife. No one knows which brother is the biological father of any child that results from these unions, and, it seems, no one particularly cares.

From this great variety of sexual practices, Lents draws the altogether reasonable conclusion that, when it comes to sex, humans are singularly flexible. “We are diversity-generating machines,” he writes. Still, Darwin’s question—why bother, when budding will do?—hangs out there. The new natural histories map the forms of sex in lavish detail without resolving why there is any.

Meanwhile, there remains the matter of moralizing. If the problem with the sex police is the way they selectively invoke nature to back up their prejudices, a similar criticism could be levelled against Lents et al. Presumably, the Kreung and the Simbari don’t see themselves as sexual

adventurers, and it seems more than likely that they would bridle at being invited to switch customs. In the United States, even at this moment of heightened sexual experimentation, there aren't a lot of people who are going to speak up for fellatio from nine-year-olds. And the problem grows only more acute when we look to the animal kingdom. For every charming story of sex and gender fluidity among other taxa, there are any number of stories involving rape, harassment, incest, traumatic sex, and infanticide. The natural world may be mesmerizing, but it doesn't offer a reliable guide to what is—or should be—socially acceptable. While copulating, female praying mantises often kill their mates and eat them. I understand the impulse, but I try to stop myself. ♦

*[Elizabeth Kolbert](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 1999, won the 2015 Pulitzer Prize for general nonfiction. Her books include “[Life on a Little-Known Planet](#)” (2025).*

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The Curious Career of “the American Dream”

How a phrase coined during the Depression became a national creed, a global brand, and a vessel for disillusionment.

By [Hua Hsu](#)

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The American Dream has long promised mobility and reinvention. Its future may depend on whether we can learn to dream differently. Illustration by Joan Wong

James Truslow Adams was born in Brooklyn in 1878, the son of a struggling Wall Street broker who had himself been born in Caracas, Venezuela. Adams grew up with a sense of fallen expectations and diminished fortunes: his family history was filled with high-living bankers and merchants engaged in international ventures, but by the time he was a child that prosperity had ebbed away. His early career was respectable; he learned bookkeeping and typing, eventually joining a brokerage house. Then, at thirty-five, he left Wall Street to pursue his true passion: history. He was awarded a Pulitzer Prize, in 1922, for “The Founding of New England,” the first book in his three-volume account of the region. In 1931, he published “The Epic of America,” a Book-of-the-Month Club selection

that was translated into a dozen languages, sold half a million copies, and injected a potent new formula into the culture.

Adams was not the first to suggest that Americans held an optimistic faith in tomorrow, but, in “The Epic of America,” he did come up with the catchiest way of describing it: “that American dream of a better, richer, and happier life for all our citizens of every rank.” This was not a dream of “motor cars and high wages merely, but a dream of a social order in which each man and each woman shall be able to attain to the fullest stature of which they are innately capable, and be recognized by others for what they are, regardless of the fortuitous circumstances of birth or position.” A reviewer counted at least fifty passages in which Adams alluded to the American Dream, a motif that connected the struggles of the present with those of the intrepid settlers, rugged frontiersmen, and self-made successes of the past.

It’s strange to realize that such a term has a history, since faith in upward mobility seems embedded in the American consciousness, like an operating system we notice only when it glitches or needs an update. Yet Adams himself had reason to feel the fragility of that faith, having inherited a story of decline and lived one of reinvention. And his study of America’s historical arc, written in the early years of the Great Depression, clearly had a restorative aim. He was naming the dream to point out its precarious state and its need for fortification. He believed that “the great business leaders are likely to lead us astray rather than to guide us,” and that America had lost sight of the communal spirit that once inspired ordinary people to new heights. “Can we hold to the good and escape from the bad?”

In the decades that followed the publication of “The Epic of America,” the American Dream became one of the nation’s great exports, an advertisement for a prosperous, socially mobile way of life unavailable elsewhere. The members of America’s postwar population boom came of age during one of the greatest periods of economic expansion in human history. From 1945 to 1975, the U.S. economy more than doubled, accounting for roughly a third of the world’s industrial output. These gains were shared across socioeconomic strata, as people moved from farms to cities and from cities to suburbs. Working Americans had access to

affordable homes, college educations, and jobs that provided a clear path to middle-class stability. People grew accustomed to the expectation that each generation would surpass the horizons of their forebears. According to a 2016 study led by the economist Raj Chetty, Americans born in 1940 had a ninety-two-per-cent chance of earning more than their parents had.

The idea that anyone could bootstrap their way to affluence had profound effects on how people treated one another, something Adams noted in “The Epic of America.” He wrote of a Frenchman visiting New York City who expressed astonishment at “the way that everyone of every sort looks you right in the eye, without a thought of inequality.” Rich and poor, he thought, shared a kind of dignity.

These opportunities were not equally distributed, of course. As America’s middle class underwent an unprecedented expansion, African Americans remained subject to discriminatory housing, employment, and banking practices. In 1965, William F. Buckley, Jr., and James Baldwin debated the proposition “The American Dream is at the expense of the American Negro” at the Cambridge Union Society. Buckley argued that African Americans had not fully taken advantage of the opportunities available to them. Baldwin’s own success, he said, was evidence that one could rise above one’s circumstances, and he cited the advances Black Americans had made since emancipation. “The most mobile society in the world is the United States of America,” Buckley proclaimed, “and it is precisely that mobility which will give opportunities to the Negroes which they must be encouraged to take.”

Baldwin’s position was that the centrality of slavery and racial subjugation in American history could not simply be reversed by legislative fiat. “I picked the cotton, and I carried it to market, and I built the railroads under someone else’s whip for nothing,” he said. “For nothing.” What Baldwin described was not only the denial of economic opportunity but the discovery that America had not, “in its whole system of reality, evolved any place” for Black Americans. He recalled the “great shock” of realizing, as a child watching a Gary Cooper movie, that he had more in common with the Indians than he did with the cowboys. Baldwin did not dismiss the American Dream as a fiction. But, he argued, until the nation reckoned with

how deeply the enslavement and continued degradation of Black people had shaped its history and prosperity, “there is scarcely any hope for the American Dream, because the people who are denied participation in it, by their very presence, will wreck it.” The students at the Cambridge Union, asked to decide the debate’s winner, voted overwhelmingly in Baldwin’s favor.

The debate captured another dimension of the American Dream, related to its core vision of economic opportunity but harder to measure. Martin Luther King, Jr., in his 1963 address at the March on Washington, called it “the dream deeply rooted in the American Dream”—the prospect that the nation might finally “rise up and live out the true meaning of its creed.” This was a dream in which Americans would “achieve our country,” as Baldwin put it, seeing themselves as full members of society, entitled to all that America promised.

The American Dream has always had its skeptics, and not just among those who have been institutionally marginalized. Rags-to-riches stories are often described as “Gatsbyesque,” a reference to F. Scott Fitzgerald’s 1925 novel, “The Great Gatsby.” Some people forget that Fitzgerald took a dim view of the extremes to which a young striver might go in the name of reinvention. Perhaps this was the underside of what Adams’s Frenchman described: an insatiable appetite for more, coupled with a lingering paranoia that your place within this social order would never be securely fixed. When anything is possible, can anything be enough?

In the nineteen-sixties, for example, some questioned whether material possessions alone could make you feel as though you’d arrived. As a 1967 New York *Times* op-ed put it, middle-class people had now begun to “dream hip,” craving a kind of authenticity that money could not buy. (Around the same time, another *Times* writer observed that rising levels of anxiety and insomnia had led some to believe that the “American dream today is to sleep.”) As a character in Edward Albee’s scathing 1961 play “The American Dream” laments, “That’s the way things are today; you just can’t get satisfaction; you just try.”

Perhaps the problem arose from the extravagant expectations of American life, the sense that bad luck will always be chased by good fortune and that

the poor man is merely someone who has yet to strike it rich. The American Dream is at once a story of unyielding, collective progress and something we experience individually. Success is relative, and failure is easily internalized as our fault alone. However free we are to pursue our potential, we can struggle to accept that our potential might take us no further.

By the late nineteen-seventies, as the manufacturing economy declined and wealth became increasingly concentrated in the financial sector, traditional pathways to middle-class prosperity began to narrow. Chetty, the economist, observed that the likelihood of outearning one's parents gradually fell from ninety-two per cent among those born in 1940 to about fifty per cent among those born forty years later. In the nineteen-eighties, Barbara Ehrenreich described the "fear of falling" at the heart of American middle-class life—the anxieties bred by a hypercompetitive society in which people fretted about their individual status at the expense of class-based politics. The historian Studs Terkel encountered a similar skittishness while conducting interviews for his 1980 book, "American Dreams." One interviewee, a Mexican American businessman named Stephen Cruz who had immigrated with his family as a child, explained that the American Dream amounted to little more than "power and fear." Even though the Cruzes were a classic immigrant success story, he felt that it simply meant he had more to lose: "The dream is *not losing*." By the nineties, George Carlin would crack, "The reason they call it the American Dream is because you have to be asleep to believe it."

For all that, the American Dream remains, a century after "The Epic of America," the intoxicating idea on which our national identity rests, capacious enough to rationalize every form of ambition, from the modest to the megalomaniacal. It describes the scholarship student who is the first in the family to attend college as well as the billionaire touting a self-made empire. It remains, too, a durable brand: the American Dream is the name of a racehorse, a mall in New Jersey, the world's longest limousine, a family-run nut-butter company in Indiana, a meme coin currently trading at \$0.00002, and an initiative recently launched by JPMorgan Chase to help small businesses.



"He's like a character in something bad no one ever saw."
Cartoon by Bruce Eric Kaplan

Whether we still wholeheartedly believe in it is another question. The phrase has become a convenient shorthand for pollsters and pundits seeking a vibes-based understanding of our views on the future. In 2024, the Pew Research Center reported that forty-seven per cent of Americans no longer trusted the American Dream's promise of success through "hard work and determination." Those who still held these beliefs skewed older and more conservative. (As recently as 2011, a similar Pew survey had shown that sixty-three per cent still felt that they could get ahead if they applied themselves.) This year, a Wells Fargo poll suggested that most parents with children between the ages of eighteen and twenty-eight have to provide substantial financial support for them. Studies indicate that Gen Z's hope is for a kind of bare-bones stability, for a debt-free life rather than one filled with riches.

On a drizzly spring day, I went to Washington, D.C., to visit the Milken Center for Advancing the American Dream. The center is part of the Milken Institute, a nonprofit founded in 1991 by the businessman Michael Milken. (I am of the generation introduced to the idea of white-collar crime when Milken, the so-called junk-bond king, was indicted for securities fraud, in the nineteen-eighties.) The center opened, last September, as a kind of museum of American exceptionalism, and its décor channels distinctly Trump-era gaudiness. The main entrance—called the Hall of Generations—features a gilded, iridescent tree decorated with "leaves" containing handwritten stories of struggle and triumph left by visitors. In an adjoining room, the stately moldings and coffered ceiling of this former bank building remain intact, but now a giant L.E.D. installation hangs from the ceiling,

featuring illuminated panels emblazoned with American Dream buzzwords, like “*PRODUCTIVITY*,” “*WEALTH*,” “*ACCESS*,” “*HOPE*,” and “*POTENTIAL*.”

Displays were dedicated to financial literacy and the power of entrepreneurship, alongside explainers about compound interest and “finance as a force for good.” A wing devoted to the power of education showed John Legend’s yearbook, Sonia Sotomayor’s undergraduate thesis, and Michael Milken’s high-school spirit-squad uniform. A wall of inspirational quotes included Amanda Gorman and Lin-Manuel Miranda. Given the current Administration’s war on “wokeness,” I was surprised by the Milken Center’s embrace of diversity.

I decided to spring for something called the Perpetual Story Machine. With other visitors, I followed a docent into an enclosed room. The walls and ceiling lit up, and suddenly we found ourselves inside a computer-generated network of gold pipes and valves, with white orbs pinging every which way. It felt like being in a steampunk-themed escape room. A disembodied voice explained that each orb represented someone’s American story; we needed to help them by manipulating the interactive screens to insure that none of the pathways were clogged.

Once we’d assisted enough story-orbs, panels swung open to reveal another room, where a series of animated stories played out across the walls and ceiling. There was an Eastern European immigrant who fought to become a doctor in nineteen-twenties New York; a Hispanic family that turned a passion for surfing into a well-known surfboard brand; an African American teacher who, unable to become an astronaut himself, encouraged others to chase their dreams. Afterward, a QR code appeared, in case we wanted to learn about the real-life people who had inspired these stories.

The use of immigrant avatars signals how central immigration remains to sustaining the narrative of the American Dream. In the 2022 book “*Streets of Gold*,” the economists Ran Abramitzky and Leah Boustan used large-scale data analysis to show that U.S. immigrants from relatively poor countries like Mexico, Guatemala, and Laos are “more upwardly mobile” than children of native-born Americans raised in families with a similar income level. The authors also found that immigrants today scale the

economic ladder at the same pace as European immigrants did in the early twentieth century. Recent polling indicates that seventy-nine per cent of Americans view immigration as good for the country.

As I left the museum, I glanced at a map and realized that I was just a few hundred yards from the White House. But I couldn't make out where it was through the thickets of barricades and security checkpoints. The militarized feel of central D.C. called to mind the images of *ICE* patrolling city streets and the way those immigration crackdowns seemed to symbolize the “shredding of the American Dream,” as Andrew Gounardes, a New York state senator, told a reporter when *ICE* officers began appearing in his Brooklyn district. “How many immigrants come here because they want to give their children a chance to get that golden ticket, to pursue that American Dream?”

I wanted to see the White House, and a woman in a Secret Service vest directed me to an intersection that was a ten-minute walk away, where I could get an unobstructed view. I knew that I'd arrived from the presence of a lone protester holding a sign about the Epstein files and live-streaming the reactions of passersby. I looked past him, through a series of fences, but was so far away that the White House was little more than a speck on the horizon.

The American Dream may not be making a comeback, but the argument about how to revive it certainly has. In recent years, writers, thinkers, and podcasters have advanced rival prescriptions for restoring the economic mobility that twentieth-century Americans came to see as their birthright. In “Ours Was the Shining Future,” David Leonhardt traces today's “rough-and-tumble” individualism to the decline of labor unions. In “The Socialist Manifesto,” Bhaskar Sunkara argues for renewal through taxation and wealth redistribution. Ezra Klein and Derek Thompson, in “Abundance,” propose a less regulatory progressivism, betting that technology can deliver prosperity. Marc Andreessen and Ben Horowitz struck a similar note in a recent podcast conversation—though calling for even less regulation—and described the revival of the American Dream as “an easy problem to solve.” Other writers have emphasized repair at the social level: A. Mechele Dickerson has written of a “middle-class New Deal” that might reimagine

everything from the length of the K-12 school year to forms of non-wage compensation for workers; Alissa Quart has urged the burned-out to seek opportunities for communal care and interdependence. Chetty's recent research offers support for the idea that mobility is improved by friendship and contact across class lines.

Many of these accounts are notable because they come from liberal or progressive circles, where faith in the American Dream is often dismissed as gauche and conservative. After Zohran Mamdani won the 2025 New York City mayor's race, the activist and former Democratic National Committee co-vice-chair David Hogg remarked that Mamdani's election was about "making the American Dream possible again." Mamdani, proud of his socialist values, had developed a language for communicating a collective, interdependent vision of city life through his consistent emphasis on affordability. For progressives like Hogg, Mamdani's campaign showed a way to address the Democratic Party's so-called American Dream problem: the way left-leaning politicians struggle to talk about a more prosperous future. It's one thing to point out that the *MAGA* movement draws on a troublingly distorted or bigoted version of the nation's past. It's another to offer something equally sweeping and seductive in its place.

Despite America's wealth and relative stability, numerous metrics suggest a country in distress, lagging behind other affluent nations in everything from life expectancy to results on surveys of global happiness and well-being. The American Dream once presumed a steady, patient faith in merit and hard work. Now, with the internet as our window onto the world outside, people fantasize about exponential, rather than linear, accumulation. Influencers cash in on viral fame, startups fear that this is the last age of human innovation, and people seem increasingly hungry to seize what they can before the old systems, and the values that sustained them, disappear. The rise of cryptocurrency and online prediction markets signals a deepening loss of faith in the visions of middle-class stability that once powered American life. For some, upward mobility feels more attainable in Canada or Western Europe than it does in the U.S. A recent *Wall Street Journal* article made clear that "the new American dream, for some of its citizens, is to no longer live there," with a record number of Americans choosing to move abroad. There's even the recent social-media trend of

“Chinamaxxing,” in which Americans with no obvious connection to China fetishize and marvel at the futuristic life style and opportunities available there.

A couple of years ago, I began teaching a class on the American Dream, mostly because I noticed that more and more of my college students were voicing curiosity about it. Some of them invoked it ironically, but many genuinely wondered whether it used to be real, and what it meant to inherit this foundational idea at a time when norms seemed in constant flux. It sounded like a fragment of language from another world, and yet they recognized how they had internalized its enchanting logic, the belief that there is something virtuous in the relentless pursuit of material achievement. What I realized was that they were in search of a meaningful future, since the one that had compelled so many of their forebears dutifully forward no longer seemed possible.

My students grapple with what horizons remain meaningful today. We’re taught to believe that hard work insures a good outcome, even as the stepping stones to a secure life grow harder to find. Where does one look for models if élites and powerful decision-makers seem to have ascended through nepotism or greed rather than through merit? How can homework and grades possibly matter in the age of A.I.? One student, reflecting on the relentless demand for productivity and output, wondered if the American Dream was delivery on demand or having the time to cook for yourself. Earning a college degree or owning a home was once not just a status marker but an investment that promised material returns. Today, people amass unmanageable debt simply to keep faith with a story that feels increasingly detached from their reality.

Inevitably, our discussions turn to what else might draw us onward, if not the white picket fence. The American Dream, as James Truslow Adams explained, was never just about cars and salaries. Even if many who debate his phrase today have no idea who he was, Adams’s own career can prompt us to ask what, exactly, we are seeking. After all, he left business to devote himself to history and to thinking about what it might mean for America’s future. He believed that the collective spirit of self-improvement was symbolized best not by the nation’s wealth but by the reading room of the

Library of Congress, open to rich and poor alike. My students and I try to imagine a version of the American Dream that becomes something altogether different. Is the answer to be found in Fitzgerald or Baldwin, in a politician or a viral star? We still haven't figured it out, but no one has given up yet. ♦

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[Pop Music](#)

Olivia Rodrigo's Early-Twenties Lament

On her new album, “You Seem Pretty Sad for a Girl So in Love,” the singer inches away from frisky pop-punk and toward the velvety yearning of New Wave.

By [Amanda Petrusich](#)

June 15, 2026



Rodrigo is beginning to figure out how to merge her countercultural influences with her Disney pedigree. Illustration by Nada Hayek

“They say modern love’s a cruel endeavor,” Olivia Rodrigo sings on “u + me = <3,” a lush, desperate new song from her third album, “You Seem Pretty Sad for a Girl So in Love.” She adds, “And to that I say, ‘*Fuck it*,

whatever.’ ” Insouciance has always been Rodrigo’s abiding philosophy when it comes to romance. If her discography has a single repeating theme, it’s that love is ruinous, a surefire path to acting like a ding-dong. Once again, Rodrigo shrugs off concern. What else would she do—stay home?

Rodrigo began her career as a child actor. By age seven, she’d had her first role, in an Old Navy commercial; by thirteen, she was starring in her own Disney Channel series—but she didn’t become a superstar until 2021, with the release of “Drivers License,” an indignant, slow-burning anthem about the humiliation of desiring someone who betrayed you. Her [first two](#) albums, which contain a mix of moody, stricken ballads and springy, punkish romps, remind me of Taylor Swift and Avril Lavigne, with a hint of Ashlee Simpson thrown in: poppy, highly confessional, sometimes slapsticky songs about how love pushes even the best of us to the precipice of insanity. Rodrigo’s always had cool taste—she collaborated with David Byrne; Blondie introduced one of her performances on “S.N.L.”; Robert Smith, of the Cure, is a guest vocalist on a new song, “What’s Wrong with Me”—but she’s just beginning to figure out how to merge her countercultural influences with her Disney pedigree.

On “You Seem Pretty Sad for a Girl So in Love,” Rodrigo, who is twenty-three, is inching away from frisky, impish pop-punk and leaning more toward New Wave, with its melodic synthesizers and velvety yearning. (There’s also a good dose of angsty nineties alt-rock here, including tracks that sound inspired by Weezer, the Smashing Pumpkins, and the Breeders.) Rodrigo has a disarmingly powerful soprano, and she’s a charming, determined performer. I still recall, with a mix of horror and reverence, [a viral clip](#) of her tumbling into an open hole in the stage during the “[Guts](#)” tour, bouncing back out, and proceeding to finish the show.

The first side of “You Seem Pretty Sad for a Girl So in Love” is about the euphoria and terror of new love. But the back half is a heady object lesson in the limits of partnership—how even the right person can’t fully quell whatever torment lurks in the recesses of one’s consciousness. “I know everybody changes, but I hope that we don’t,” Rodrigo wails on the chorus of “u + me = <3.” It’s a lyric destined to make elders in the room grimace. Change is inexorable; better to hope that you evolve in compatible ways.

That idea—love as a failed panacea—reaches its apotheosis on “The Cure,” a tense and melancholy song about hoping a new relationship might liberate you from your worst impulses. She sings:

Used to play a game in my head when I’d date a guy
Tally up the girls that he fucked ’til I start to cry

Envy and uncertainty are not new terrain for Rodrigo, but I was nonetheless struck by the grimness of the line. The track recalls the drama and mournfulness of two songs by the Smashing Pumpkins: “Disarm” (about abuse and resentment) and “Tonight, Tonight” (about trying to outrun yourself). Rodrigo’s fans are young—some very young—and her music is perky, composed, and telegenic in a way that can distract from how much darkness and loathing lurk within it. Now she is perhaps exactly at the age in which a person realizes how often those things come to coexist.

In May, Rodrigo performed at a Spotify event in Barcelona, wearing a puffy floral top and matching bloomers, an ensemble that resembled a baby-doll dress, or, more specifically, the kind of dainty frock a Victorian toddler might have donned to waddle the gardens under her nanny’s parasol. It led to some pearl-clutching about Rodrigo’s supposed self-infantilization—a concession, perhaps, to a culture of predation on young women. Rodrigo eventually countered that her detractors were blaming the wrong person. “I just think it just shows how we normalize pedophilia in our culture,” she told [the Times](#). “It’s just this rhetoric that we’re fed as girls since we’re so little, which is like, don’t wear that because then a man is going to sexualize your body and it’s your fault.”

Rodrigo said that the outfit was inspired by nineties alt-rock icons such as Courtney Love and Kathleen Hanna, who often wore baby-doll dresses onstage, though back then the styling was generally gnarlier (ripped tights, unwashed hair, smeared makeup), which made the whole look feel cheeky and subversive. Hanna, who founded Bikini Kill—and, by extension, is a primary architect of riot grrrl, a subgenre of punk that centers feminist rage—often weaponized fashion, performing with the word “slut” written across her belly, or in hot pants with a little bush peeking out, or in a tomato-red go-go dress that featured the phrase “*KILL ME*” in ironed-on white letters. Even more pointedly, Hanna occasionally put on a Girl Scout uniform, a

caustic homage to being sexualized as a young girl; Love once wrote “*WITCH*” on her arm in red lipstick while wearing a white baby-doll dress with a stuffed doll dangling from the hip.

I came of age in the late nineteen-nineties, and worshipped Love and Hanna (also [Kim Gordon](#), Kim and Kelley Deal, Juliana Hatfield, [PJ Harvey](#), and [Björk](#)). Part of what fascinated me about their presentation was not only their refusal to kowtow to male desire, which for decades had a stranglehold on rock aesthetics, but a concomitant disavowal of commercialism. For Hanna and her cohort, the idea was not so much to court popular attention but to repel it.

Unlike her riot-grrrl idols, I would not describe Rodrigo as radical, exactly, but she is not apolitical. In June of 2022, during Rodrigo’s Glastonbury début, a day after the Supreme Court [overturned Roe v. Wade](#), she and Lily Allen performed Allen’s song “Fuck You.” Rodrigo dedicated the performance to the five Justices who voted in favor of the decision, and called them out by name. “They truly don’t give a shit about freedom,” she said. (On tour the following year, she partnered with the National Network of Abortion Funds.) Last fall, when the Trump Administration used “All-American Bitch,” a song from “Guts,” in a video valorizing *ICE* agents, Rodrigo reacted with outrage, calling the footage “awful and barbaric and cruel.”

In general, the rub with pop music is that it almost invariably babies and defangs its practitioners; the best pop songs are about big, dumb, adolescent feelings (an overwhelming crush, a cataclysmic breakup, getting zooted and having a blast). It’s never been the right medium for nuance or rebellion or cataloguing the endless, wretched banalities that actually make up an adult life; as such, it’s not particularly easy for pop stars to age or evolve. This is doubly true for women, who are more likely to get mired in the quicksand between coquettish ingénue and grande dame, and who are given far less leeway when it comes to the rules of growing up.

“You Seem Pretty Sad for a Girl So in Love” is germane to Rodrigo’s age, transitional in the way one’s early twenties can feel provisional and wildly unpredictable. On “Drop Dead,” the opening track, Rodrigo toggles between girlish hopes (there are lyrical nods to chewing gum and holding

hands) and more mature wants (“And then maybe we could make, make out / Clothes off and fall to the ground”). Yet, by the end of the record, Rodrigo sounds less like a love-struck teen. On “Expectations,” the album’s eighties-inspired penultimate song, she sings about learning how to temper her hopes and dreams, or at least to stop looking for love in all the wrong places:

So I hit the new year like a single girl at a Vegas bar
Rocking my mini dress with a vodka cran and an open heart
Yeah, I’ve got hope, yeah, I’ve got drive, I will not lose my faith
Don’t think my future husband’s at this bar in Silver Lake. ♦

[Amanda Petrusich](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker* and the author of “[Do Not Sell at Any Price: The Wild, Obsessive Hunt for the World’s Rarest 78rpm Records](#).”

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[The Current Cinema](#)

“The Invite” Is a Witty Relationship Comedy That Could Be Wilder

In Olivia Wilde’s bickersome couples comedy, an evening of refreshments and recriminations leads to an intriguing proposition.

By [Justin Chang](#)

June 19, 2026



“The Invite” is the latest entry in the annals of double-date-from-hell movies. Illustration by Madison Ketcham

“The Invite” begins with an aphorism: “One should always be in love. That is the reason one should never marry.” The words are from Oscar Wilde, and the movie is from Olivia Wilde, née Olivia Jane Cockburn, who adopted the professional surname years ago, in honor of the many pseudonymous Irish writers in her family. Some might see hubris in her choice of namesake, and I wouldn’t disagree, though I also wouldn’t judge: Who’s to say who is or isn’t truly Wilde at heart? “The Invite,” her third feature as a filmmaker, has its own tart, unflattering view of matrimony. The script, by Will McCormack and Rashida Jones, takes the form of a chamber piece, its four bickersome characters confined to one location for

the better part of two hours—as close to the Oscar-worthy tradition of drawing-room comedy as Olivia has come.

The drawing room, in this case, is a recently renovated San Francisco apartment, where a married couple, Joe (Seth Rogen) and Angela (Wilde herself), live with their twelve-year-old daughter, Maggie. The kid is away at a sleepover, and Angela has invited the upstairs neighbors, Piña (Penélope Cruz) and Hawk (Edward Norton), over for an evening of wine and charcuterie. Joe, grumpily returning from work, claims to be blindsided by this news, though Angela insists that she told him ages ago—the first disagreement of many. She’s a whirlwind of activity and a ball of nerves, slapping his hand away from the hors d’œuvres and berating him for having forgotten to pick up a bottle of wine. Joe, an equally instinctive complainer, is also a shit-stirrer par excellence. The one benefit of having Piña and Hawk over, he reckons, is that he can finally confront them about their noisy sex life.

This particular grievance carries an unmistakable whiff of jealousy, and I was reminded of an earlier comedy, “Neighbors” (2014), in which Rogen plays a husband and a father confronting the rowdy frat guys next door—and feeling, amid his irritation, a twinge of envy and loss. Twelve years later, there’s more salt and pepper in Rogen’s beard and more vinegar in his demeanor; the let-it-all-hang-out comic boisterousness of his Judd Apatow days has hardened into a shell of middle-aged aggression. Joe looks at his pleasant, comfortable life and sees an abyss. Once an indie-rock front man whose band flamed out after one big hit, he now teaches music—cue the sad trombones—at a good-not-great Bay Area conservatory. Even their gorgeous apartment is, for him, an emblem of failure: it’s the home he grew up in, and one that he could never have afforded, only inherited. For Angela, by contrast, the place is her singular creative outlet, the sole use for her otherwise untapped art-school degree. Wilde and her superb production designer, Jade Healy, treat the apartment as a lovingly furnished combat zone, a space malleable enough to convey either entrapment or distance. The living room can turn suddenly cold and cavernous, with Joe and Angela yelling at each other across an emotional chasm. But then we’ll follow them into the closer quarters of the master bedroom, the one unfinished room in

the apartment, where Angela has yet to settle on a paint color—a bit of indecision that reads as profound ambivalence about their marriage.

Wilde's previous feature, the dystopian thriller "Don't Worry Darling" (2022), was a through-the-looking-glass nightmare of nineteen-fifties-style suburbia whose visual conceits felt thuddingly obvious; nearly every shot screamed "Danger!" so loudly that you couldn't help but search for the exit. "The Invite" is a more compressed, disciplined affair—a return to the dexterous wit of her *début*, the teen comedy "Booksmart" (2019). But even here, Wilde's stylistic choices can veer from shrewd to overly studied. The apartment, though no one's idea of a fun house, is bedecked with mirrors, and, early on, the cinematographer Adam Newport-Berra uses them to splinter the couple's every argument into fragments. A reflective shot might juxtapose two Angelas and one Joe, or isolate one spouse in the foreground and the other in the mirror behind them. The effect is distracting yet apt: at no point are husband and wife fully inhabiting the same plane.

Musically, too, the movie tends toward the overwrought; the score, by Dev Hynes, is so awash in ominously thrumming cello strings you might wonder if the term "chamber piece" has been taken literally. And yet Joe and Angela's animosity is underscored by an *absence* of song. No one is allowed to play Joe's one-hit-wonder record, or to touch the piano that now gathers dust in his office. Only when Hawk and Piña finally show up, interrupting Joe and Angela mid-argument, does anyone dare to break this rule—or to suggest that another kind of beautiful music might yet be made.

In the annals of double-date-from-hell movies, "The Invite" is neither as good as "Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?" (1966), Mike Nichols's still crackling adaptation of Edward Albee's play, nor as bad as "Carnage" (2011), Roman Polanski's mirthless film version of Yasmina Reza's "God of Carnage." As it happens, Wilde's movie is a redo of a Spanish comedy, "The People Upstairs" (2020), which the director and screenwriter Cesc Gay adapted from his own stage work. Gay's movie has already spawned Italian, Swiss, French, and South Korean remakes, though "The Invite" is the first to honor its lineage by casting a Spanish actor as one of its principals—either that, or it was simply and wisely decided that no one but Penélope Cruz could play Piña. A psychotherapist and a sexologist, she

styles her hair in a fetching mass of blond locks and dark roots, and sweeps into the apartment with a suave self-assurance that reduces Angela to even more of a stammering wreck. (Wilde is a terrific director of actors, herself included.) When the subject turns, inevitably, to Piña's high-volume sex life, she makes a heartfelt apology but couldn't seem less embarrassed; in her eyes, we see a matter-of-fact merriment, plus a glimmer of naughty intent. She is, on paper, the character who drifts closest to caricature—the hot-blooded Euro-chic seductress—and yet, onscreen, she's the one figure the movie can't bring itself to mock. She knows herself too well, and is too comfortable in her skin, to make ridicule an option.

Hawk is another story. We initially take our cues from Joe, who can't stand the guy and doesn't buy his ludicrous name, his insistent friendliness, his patronizing New Age sensitivity, the fact that he used to be a firefighter. Hawk lays everything on a touch too thick, whether he's praising Angela's taste in rugs or even complimenting Joe's brutal honesty. ("We love a contentious environment," Hawk declares, by way of either defusing or aggravating the evident tension between his hosts.) Norton, like few other actors, can turn on the charm and the smarm as if they were side-by-side faucets, and what's disarming about the performance is the way he keeps twisting the taps—flooding us with decency one moment, reverting to smug insufferableness the next. All in all, though, Piña and Hawk's arrival is a relief; despite untold opportunities for fresh awkwardness and turmoil, the film seems more at ease in the company of guests. The camera steadies itself, the strings and mirrors take a break, and you can sense Wilde's confidence in her material growing. It's as if the movie itself grasps that four is better than two—a lesson that has a very specific application where the characters are concerned.

Read no further if you wish to preserve the purity of the viewing experience, but Wilde's film is at its fleeting best in the realms of the impure. Piña and Hawk, we learn, like to host group-sex parties, and it is they, not Angela, who end up extending the invite of the title. The fallout of that inquiry—to which Joe and Angela gamely acquiesce—generates its share of laughs, though our amusement comes at a cost. A sudden swerve into experimental terrain is just as swiftly preempted by some predictable slapstick and a fresh round of couples therapy—all so that, in the end, the

threat of polyamory can be banished, the blessings of monogamy reasserted, and Oscar Wilde's disdain for marriage decisively disproved. The closing moments are sweet and poignant; they also suggest a failure of nerve. I'm not saying "The Invite" needed an orgiastic climax—only that it might have benefitted, like any relationship, from less fidelity to a preëxisting script, and perhaps a drop more of its characters' own courage. What happens onscreen isn't just coitus interruptus; given how quickly the neighbors quit the premises, it's more like a premature evacuation. ♦

[Justin Chang](#) is a film critic at *The New Yorker*.

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On Form

By [Linda Gregerson](#)

June 22, 2026

West outside my window so
the sunrise, what I see of it, is indirect,

and at its best, I'd say, this time of year,
my favorite, when the trees

are undistracted into flourishing.
The topmost branches, bare in all their

glory, turning radiant with welcome and
the one tree farther, a farm away,

lit up above the scrublands as if
chosen, as we are,

for a blessing we don't deserve.

•

But how do you manage for faith, she said
(our coffees had come in discardable cups),

and in her eyes and in the still un-
scumbled planes of her face (so young)

the question she's too kind to ask: and how
have you let it come to this?

I am trying to write an essay, I said, about form.

•

Already our sorry remnant of snow
is giving up, which means the roads

will be wretched again, they love to return
to mud. The Romans, whatever you think

of them, did this better. Ditched
and cambered, layered roadbed five

feet deep. Lime from the likewise
layered rock that once was coral and algae

and shell, ash that was once a volcano. I'll
confess the warmer weather has its virtues too.

•

The butterflies, for instance. The ones
in the news. Indigo at the midline, dustings

of silver on the double wing, both fore-
and hind: the chalkhill blue.

We love them for their beauty but the ants,
indifferent to beauty for all we know, at least

as we construe it, love to milk
their honeyed larvae. *We'll feed*

*on your darlings while they're other-
wise defenseless, guard the cells we've*

*built for them underground, and, when
they're ready,*

let them go. Chalk because their one food
grows on chalky soil.

•

Trial and error, wit and will. And conscripts
by the thousands for the labor and the

laying out. But how
in the history of accident had

humanity come upon quicklime?
Which, added to concrete, means

that something not in nature can, like nature,
heal. The science is quite beyond me, and

the Romans will have thought about it
otherwise, not having the advantage of

the spectroscope. The more we know the
more we know the world's a wonder. We're

apprenticed, every one of us, to stone.

*[Linda Gregerson](#) began contributing to *The New Yorker* in 2010. Her poetry collections include "[Canopy](#)."*

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Domesticity

By [Lindsay Turner](#)

June 22, 2026

The owls weren't in distress, although
I thought they sounded like it, calling out so much
in daylight. Barred owls:
Who cooks for you? is how you write the call,
I looked it up.
They were so close it sounded like they were in the house,
like six owls just went off at once out there, you said.
A false spring.
The daffodils were almost blown,
snow was on the way.
Left to desire, we did.

[Lindsay Turner](#) is the author of "[Middle Slope](#)," her third book of poems (October, 2026).

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The Crossword: Wednesday, June 17, 2026

A beginner-friendly puzzle.

By [Robyn Weintraub](#)

June 17, 2026

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[Robyn Weintraub](#) has been constructing crosswords since 2010 and began contributing puzzles to *The New Yorker* in 2020. Her puzzles have appeared in the *New York Times*, the *Los Angeles Times*, and the *American Crossword Puzzle Tournament*.

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